THE INTIMACIES OF RITUAL

And the Human Questions Beneath Them



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The Intimacies of Ritual

52 Customs and the Human Questions Beneath Them

What the world's traditions teach us about being human

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An Executive Class Series by Ron Taylor

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The customs are described from published sources, including the communities' own accounts, and reflect the record at the time of writing. Traditions vary from family to family and place to place; no chapter speaks for everyone who keeps a custom. Sources are listed at the back of the book.

How This Book Works

Fifty-two customs, one for each week of the year. Each chapter begins somewhere specific — a room, a gesture, a cup of coffee — and ends somewhere general: a question about your own life.

Every chapter follows the same shape, so you always know where you are.

The Custom

An opening that puts you inside the tradition.

Where It Came From

The history and circumstances that produced it.

What Actually Happens

The custom explained clearly and concretely.

What It Reveals

The deeper human meaning underneath the practice.

The Human Lens

One or two questions connecting the custom to your own life.

Key Takeaways

Three or four points worth carrying away.

Vocabulary & Phrasal Verbs

Useful words and expressions drawn from the chapter.

Practice

Where the analogy breaks, a language task, a discussion, a writing task.

THE WRITING TASK

Every chapter closes with the same kind of writing exercise, built on the **STAR** structure — a simple, widely used way of shaping an account of something that happened:

Situation

Where you were, and how you came to be there.

Task

What you needed, or what was being asked of you.

Action

What was actually done, and by whom.

Result

What changed as a result — for you, or for someone else.

Four short paragraphs are enough. The structure matters more than the length.

A NOTE ON THE ARRANGEMENT

The book is not organized geographically. That would make it a travel book. It is organized around human questions — how we welcome, how we eat, how we belong, how we remember — so that customs separated by thousands of kilometres can be seen attempting to solve the same problem.

The journey runs: *stranger* → *community* → *family* → *ancestors* → *self*.

PART I

How We Welcome

CUSTOMS 1–7

What does a guest deserve?

1 The Majlis *Saudi Arabia*

2 Hongi *New Zealand*

3 Arabic Coffee *Saudi Arabia*

4 Teranga *Senegal*

5 Bowing *Japan*

6 Mint Tea *Morocco*

7 Mano *Philippines*

The Majlis

SAUDI ARABIA

What Does a Guest Deserve?

Imagine arriving at someone's home in Saudi Arabia.

You are not simply shown where to sit and left to yourself. You are welcomed. Coffee may be prepared and served. Conversation begins. The host gives you time.

The room itself may be called a **majlis** — literally, a place of sitting. But the word describes much more than furniture or architecture. It represents a space in which people gather, receive guests, discuss matters and maintain relationships.

That distinction is important.

In many modern societies, hospitality has become increasingly efficient. We invite someone over, offer them something to drink, exchange a few words, and then return to whatever we were doing. The majlis suggests another possibility:

Perhaps welcoming someone requires giving them your attention.

The Arabic coffee traditionally served to guests is part of this system. The small cups allow the host to serve repeatedly rather than simply

placing a large pot on the table and leaving guests to themselves. The host remains involved in the interaction.

There is also an interesting social dimension to the majlis. Historically, the gathering place was where people could discuss family matters, community concerns, business and politics. It provided a physical setting for relationships to be maintained and information to circulate.

In other words, the majlis does something that many modern institutions struggle to do:

It creates a place where people have time for one another.

We tend to think of hospitality as providing something — a meal, a drink, a bed, perhaps a comfortable chair.

But hospitality is not really about the object.

It is about the **attention**.

A person can give you an expensive meal while making you feel like an inconvenience. Another person can offer you something simple and make you feel that your arrival mattered.

The difference is not what was served.

It is whether you were **received**.

And that may be the deeper lesson of the majlis.

A culture's customs often reveal what it considers important. If welcoming people requires time, conversation and ceremony, then the culture is making a statement:

People are worth stopping for.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the people who enter your life — friends, colleagues, neighbours, students, clients or strangers.

When someone speaks to you, do you give them your attention, or are you already preparing to return to something else?

What do you do that tells another person: "You are welcome here"?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Hospitality is more than providing things.** It involves attention and participation.
2. **The majlis turns hospitality into a social practice.** Gathering, conversation and relationship maintenance are part of the custom.
3. **Customs reveal values.** The way we welcome people tells us something about what we believe people deserve.

SUMMARY

The majlis is a traditional gathering space associated with hospitality, conversation and community life in Saudi Arabia and elsewhere in the Arab world. Guests may be welcomed with Arabic coffee and given time and attention. Beyond the physical room, the majlis represents a social practice: creating space for people to meet, talk and maintain relationships.

Its broader lesson is simple: ***hospitality is not primarily about what we give people. It is about whether we make room for them.***

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

hospitality *(n.)* friendly and generous treatment of guests

Good hospitality makes visitors feel that they belong.

majlis *(n.)* a traditional gathering place for receiving guests and holding conversations

The family gathered in the majlis after dinner.

guest *(n.)* someone invited or received by another person

The guest was offered coffee as soon as he arrived.

attention *(n.)* careful thought or consideration given to someone or something

She gave her guest her full attention.

gather *(v.)* to come together in one place

The family gathered to discuss the matter.

maintain *(v.)* to keep something continuing or in good condition

Regular meetings help maintain relationships.

to make room for *(phrasal verb)* to create space or opportunity for someone or something

Good leaders make room for other people's ideas.

to welcome in *(phrasal verb)* to invite someone to enter and feel accepted

The host welcomed everyone in.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

A majlis is embedded in a particular culture, history and social structure. We should not assume that every society can simply copy the practice and produce the same result.

The broader principle, however, is transferable:

people need places where relationships can develop without everything being rushed.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

hospitality — attention — maintain

DISCUSS

Think of a person who makes you feel genuinely welcome.

What does that person actually do?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when someone made you feel genuinely welcome.

Hongi

NEW ZEALAND

> *What Does It Mean to Truly Recognize Another Person?*

Imagine meeting someone for the first time.

You extend your hand.

Or perhaps you nod.

Maybe you smile and say hello.

These gestures are so familiar that we rarely think about what they mean.

Now imagine greeting someone by pressing your forehead and nose against theirs.

That is the **hongi**, a traditional M[illegible]greeting in Aotearoa New Zealand.

At first, it can seem strange to someone unfamiliar with it. Why would a greeting require such physical closeness?

The answer takes us somewhere much deeper.

The hongi is associated with the sharing of **h**[illegible]ten translated as the breath of life. The meeting is therefore not simply an exchange of

words. It symbolizes a connection between the people greeting one another.

And that changes the way we might think about a greeting.

A handshake says:

“I acknowledge you.”

The hongi suggests something closer to:

“We are sharing something of ourselves.”

That distinction matters.

Most of our daily greetings are remarkably efficient. We say hello to the receptionist. We greet a colleague in the hallway. We nod to someone we know at the supermarket.

But how often do we actually stop and acknowledge the person standing in front of us?

The hongi forces us to slow down.

It requires proximity.

For a moment, there is no screen between the two people. No email. No multitasking. No convenient distance.

There are simply two human beings meeting.

And that may be why customs surrounding greetings are more important than they first appear.

A greeting establishes the relationship.

It answers a fundamental human question:

How are we going to treat one another?

Some cultures emphasize equality.

Some emphasize respect for age or status.

Some emphasize warmth.

Some emphasize physical closeness.

And some combine several of these.

The fascinating thing is that **every society has to solve the same problem**.

Two people meet.

They don't yet know exactly how they relate to each other. So society gives them a script.

The script tells them what to do.

Shake hands.

Bow.

Kiss cheeks.

Touch noses.

Lower your eyes.

Smile.

Use a title.

Use a person's first name.

None of these behaviours is biologically necessary.

They are cultural inventions.

And yet they make social life easier.

Imagine a world in which every encounter required us to negotiate from scratch:

Should I shake your hand?

Should I hug you?

How close should I stand?

Who speaks first?

How much respect should I show?

Custom removes the uncertainty.

It gives us a shared language.

The hongi is therefore more than an unusual way of saying hello. It is a reminder that **human beings need rituals to make relationships visible**.

We cannot see respect.

We cannot see belonging.

We cannot see recognition.

So we create gestures that allow those invisible things to become physical.

That is what customs often do.

They take something abstract —

respect, love, grief, belonging, gratitude, hospitality — and give it a form that other people can see.

Perhaps that is why customs survive.

They allow us to say something important without having to explain it.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the way you greet people.

What does your greeting communicate?

Does it say:

"I see you."

Or does it simply mean:

"I recognize that you are here"?

When was the last time you gave someone your full attention when you greeted them?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Greetings are cultural scripts.** They tell us how to behave when relationships begin.
2. **Physical gestures can communicate invisible values.** Respect, belonging and recognition can all be expressed through the body.
3. **Customs reduce uncertainty.** They give people a shared way of behaving when they meet.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

acknowledge *(v.)* to recognize someone or something as important or present

proximity *(n.)* physical closeness to someone or something

gesture *(n.)* a movement that communicates an idea or feeling

recognition *(n.)* the act of showing that you notice or understand someone

ritual *(n.)* a customary series of actions performed in a particular situation

belonging *(n.)* the feeling of being accepted as part of a group

to slow down *(phrasal verb)* to reduce the speed or pace of something

to relate to *(phrasal verb)* to have a connection with someone or something

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The hongi is not a gesture available to anyone who admires it. It sits inside M~~ōri~~protocol, carries whakapapa and spiritual weight, and is offered on terms set by the people whose custom it is. Copying the form without the standing would be a kind of trespass. What crosses over is smaller and harder: **recognition requires proximity, and proximity requires permission.**

LOOK AT YOUR OWN CULTURE

How do people greet:

- a close friend?
- an older person?
- a business associate?

- a stranger?
- someone they haven't seen for many years?

What changes?

THINK

If your culture suddenly removed all its greeting customs, what problems might arise?

DISCUSS

Which is more important in a greeting: respect, warmth, equality, or recognition?

Explain your answer.

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a first meeting you still remember, and the way you were greeted.

Arabic Coffee

SAUDI ARABIA AND THE GULF STATES

When a Cup of Coffee Becomes a Language

Imagine being handed a tiny cup of coffee.

You drink it.

The host takes the cup back and pours you another.

You drink that one.

Another appears.

At some point, you realize that you have a problem.

You don't want any more coffee.

But how do you say so without being rude?

You gently shake the cup from side to side.

The message is understood.

Enough.

That tiny movement is part of a much larger system of etiquette surrounding Arabic coffee.

The coffee itself is usually served in a small cup called a **finjan**, from a traditional coffee pot known as a **dallah**. The coffee may be lightly roasted and prepared with spices, depending on the region and tradition.

But what makes the practice fascinating is not simply what is in the cup.

It is **what the cup communicates**.

Arabic coffee is recognized by UNESCO as an important expression of generosity and hospitality in Arab societies. It is served in homes and at weddings, gatherings and other important occasions. The knowledge of preparing and serving it is passed from one generation to another through observation and practice.

And the serving itself has rules.

Traditionally, older people and guests are served first.

The coffee is poured in small amounts.

The server remains involved in the interaction.

And the guest has a way of signalling when enough is enough. None of this is necessary to drink coffee.

That is precisely the point.

The ritual is doing something that the coffee does not need to do.

It is expressing respect.

Consider the difference between these two experiences.

Someone puts a large coffee pot on a table and says:

> *"Help yourself."*

Another person prepares the coffee, approaches you, pours it for you, waits for you to drink, and returns when you are ready for another cup.

Both people have given you coffee.

But the second person has given you something else:

attention.

This is why customs are so interesting.

They often take an ordinary activity and surround it with meaning. Drinking coffee is ordinary.

Serving coffee can become an expression of generosity.

The small cup becomes almost like a sentence.

The host is saying:

You are my guest.

You are worth serving.

You are welcome to stay.

And the guest participates in the language by accepting the cup. There is another fascinating dimension to the tradition.

The knowledge is learned.

Young people can accompany older family members when selecting coffee beans and observe how the coffee is prepared and served. UNESCO describes this transmission as part of the living heritage of Arabic coffee.

So the custom does something else besides welcoming guests. It connects generations.

A young person learns not merely how to make a beverage, but **how to behave toward another person**.

That may be one of the most important things customs accomplish. Schools can teach facts.

Parents can teach rules.

But customs teach behaviour through repetition.

You watch.

You imitate.

You participate.

Eventually, you don't have to think about it.

You simply know what to do.

And perhaps that is why rituals can be so powerful.

They turn values into habits.

Generosity becomes a cup.

Respect becomes the order in which people are served.

Hospitality becomes the act of preparing something carefully for someone else.

And "enough" becomes a tiny movement of the hand.

The next time someone offers you a cup of coffee, it might be worth noticing what is actually being offered.

It may be much more than coffee.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the small rituals you use when welcoming someone.
Perhaps you offer coffee.

Perhaps you make a meal.

Perhaps you remember how someone takes their tea.

Perhaps you walk them to the door when they leave.

What ordinary thing do you do that actually communicates something extraordinary?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Objects can become languages.** A small coffee cup can communicate respect, welcome and generosity.
2. **Ritual turns ordinary behaviour into meaningful behaviour.**
3. **Customs are learned through participation.** Young people learn not only what to do, but how to treat other people.
4. **Hospitality requires attention.** Giving someone something and giving someone your attention are not the same thing.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

etiquette *(n.)* the accepted rules for polite behaviour
There are traditional rules of etiquette surrounding the serving of coffee.

generosity *(n.)* willingness to give freely
His generosity made everyone feel welcome.

ritual *(n.)* a customary series of actions performed in a particular way
The preparation of coffee became a daily ritual.

hospitality *(n.)* friendly and generous treatment of guests
Hospitality is highly valued in many cultures.

transmit *(v.)* to pass something from one person or generation to another
Cultural traditions are transmitted through families.

observe *(v.)* to watch carefully
Children often observe adults before learning a traditional practice themselves.

participate *(v.)* to take part in something

Young people participate in family traditions.

to help yourself *(phrasal verb)* to take something without waiting for someone to give it to you

Please help yourself to some coffee.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The coffee etiquette works because everyone in the room has been taught the same code. Shake the cup and the message lands; do it somewhere the code is unknown and nothing at all is communicated. Imported wholesale, the ritual becomes theatre. The principle underneath it survives the journey: **hospitality is a sequence, not a single act.**

THINK

What is the difference between **giving someone something** and **doing something for someone**?

DISCUSS

Think of a custom in your own family.

What did you learn simply by watching other people?

APPLY

What is one small ritual you could create that would make people feel more welcome?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion when someone served you something, and what the serving communicated.

Teranga
SENEGAL

When Hospitality Becomes a Way of Life

Imagine arriving in a country where the word for hospitality means considerably more than simply being polite to a guest.

That word is **teranga**.

It is often translated as *hospitality*, but that translation doesn't quite capture its reach. Teranga is associated with welcome, generosity, respect, community and sharing. It is so closely associated with Senegal that the country is frequently described as the **"Land of Teranga."**

But what happens when hospitality becomes more than an individual virtue?

What happens when it becomes part of how people describe their society?

Consider the difference.

If I invite you into my home and offer you something to eat, I have been hospitable.

But if a visitor arrives while a family is eating, and making room for that person at the meal is considered the natural thing to do, hospitality has moved beyond a special occasion.

It has become a **social expectation**.

That distinction is what makes teranga fascinating.

It is not simply about being generous when you have plenty. It is about the act of **sharing**.

Senegalese cultural accounts frequently connect teranga with community and solidarity. The Peace Corps describes it as a way of life involving respect, community, solidarity and sharing.

And food provides one of its clearest expressions.

Senegal's culinary traditions themselves reinforce this idea. UNESCO's documentation of *ceebu jën*, the country's national dish, describes the dish and its associated practices as an affirmation of Senegalese identity and as a way of reinforcing social inclusion and belonging.

This is important because food can reveal values that speeches cannot.

Imagine a large communal dish placed in the middle of a group. People eat together.

The meal is not simply nourishment.

It becomes a physical demonstration of **belonging**.

There is enough.

There is a place for you.

You are included.

And perhaps this is one of the reasons hospitality appears in so many cultures.

Human beings have always had to solve the problem of the stranger. A stranger arrives.

Should we trust them?

Should we feed them?

Should we protect ourselves from them?

Should we invite them closer?

Different cultures have developed different answers.

Teranga gives one particularly strong answer:

The stranger should be welcomed.

Of course, no culture is perfectly represented by a single word. Senegal is a modern, complex country containing many communities, religions, languages and social realities. Teranga should therefore not be treated as a claim that every Senegalese person behaves identically.

It is better understood as a **widely recognized cultural value**. And that makes it even more interesting.

Because cultures do not have to be perfect to have ideals. In fact, perhaps the ideals matter precisely because they give people something to live up to.

We all have words that describe the people we would like to be.
Generous.

Loyal.

Courageous.

Respectful.

Compassionate.

But there is a difference between admiring a value and building it into everyday behaviour.

Teranga suggests that hospitality can become part of a society's self-image.

And that raises a larger question.

What values does your own culture try to turn into habits?

Perhaps your society values independence.

Perhaps punctuality.

Perhaps privacy.

Perhaps equality.

Perhaps family.

Perhaps hospitality.

We often assume that our own customs are simply "normal."

They aren't.

They are solutions that generations of people have developed to answer recurring human problems.

How should we greet someone?

How should we feed them?

How should we treat an elder?

How should we mourn?

How should we celebrate?

How should we behave toward a stranger?

The fascinating thing about travelling — or simply learning about another culture — is that another society's customs can make our own invisible customs suddenly visible.

We look at teranga and think:

That's interesting. They place such importance on hospitality.

And then, if we look more carefully, we can ask:

What does my culture place such importance on that I barely notice it anymore?

That is where studying customs becomes more than cultural trivia. It becomes a mirror.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the values your culture claims to admire.

Now think about the behaviours it actually rewards.

Are they the same?

And personally:

What value would you like people to associate with you?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Teranga is more than hospitality.** It is associated with welcome, generosity, respect, community and sharing.
2. **Values become powerful when they become habits.**
3. **Food can express social values.** Communal eating can reinforce belonging and inclusion.
4. **Every culture has ideals.** The interesting question is how successfully those ideals become everyday behaviour.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

hospitality *(n.)* generous and friendly treatment of guests

solidarity *(n.)* unity and mutual support within a group

generosity *(n.)* willingness to give freely

belonging *(n.)* the feeling of being accepted as part of a group

ideal *(n.)* a principle or standard that someone considers desirable

inclusion *(n.)* the practice of making people feel accepted and involved

self-image *(n.)* the way an individual or group understands and describes itself

to live up to *(phrasal verb)* to behave according to a standard or expectation

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Teranga is a nation's account of itself, and like all such accounts it is partly aspiration. It also carries a cost that is rarely mentioned: the household that cannot refuse a guest is sometimes a household that cannot afford one. A value adopted as a slogan is not the same thing. **A quality only becomes character once it is expensive.**

COMPARE

What value is most strongly associated with your own culture? How is that value expressed through everyday behaviour?

THINK

Is there a difference between **what a society says it values** and **what it actually rewards**?

DISCUSS

Would you rather live in a society that emphasizes individual freedom or one that emphasizes community responsibility?

Why?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you were treated generously by someone who had no obligation to be.

Bowing

JAPAN

How Much Can a Gesture Say?

A Japanese bow can last only a second.

But in that second, something important may happen.

Two people meet.

One person bows.

The other bows back.

Neither has said anything.

And yet both people may have communicated quite a lot.

The bow can express a greeting, gratitude, respect, apology or acknowledgement. Its meaning depends partly on the situation and on the relationship between the people involved.

Even the depth of the bow can matter.

A casual bow between acquaintances is not the same as the deeper bow used in a more formal or serious situation.

To someone unfamiliar with Japanese culture, this can seem complicated.

But perhaps we should turn the question around.

Why do we assume our own way of greeting people is simple?

Consider what happens when two people meet in an English-speaking business environment.

One person says:

“Good morning.”

The other responds:

“Good morning.”

It appears straightforward.

But there are still hundreds of invisible rules.

Who speaks first?

Do you use someone’s first name?

Do you shake hands?

Do you smile?

How close do you stand?

How long should you maintain eye contact?

Should you call someone “Doctor,” “Professor,” “Mr.,” or simply use their first name?

Every culture has answers to these questions.

We simply don't notice our own answers because we learned them so early.

The Japanese bow makes those invisible rules easier to see. It reminds us that social relationships have **architecture**. There is a structure.

There are expectations.

There are signals.

And people become comfortable partly because they know how to move within that structure.

The bow also demonstrates something interesting about communication. We often think communication means putting ideas into words. But much of human communication happens before words appear. A person's posture can communicate confidence.

A lowered voice can communicate respect.

A smile can communicate friendliness.

A pause can communicate uncertainty.

A person's physical distance from us can communicate intimacy or discomfort.

Our bodies are constantly speaking.

We simply aren't always listening.

The Meaning of Humility

There is another reason the bow is fascinating.

It requires the body to move downward.

That makes humility visible.

For a brief moment, the person bows rather than presenting themselves as physically dominant.

The gesture can therefore communicate something like:

“I recognize your presence.”

Or:

“I recognize the importance of this moment.”

Or:

“I recognize that I have done something wrong.”

The physical gesture gives form to an invisible attitude.

This is something customs do repeatedly.

We cannot see respect.

So we bow.

We cannot see remembrance.

So we wear a poppy.

We cannot see hospitality.

So we pour coffee.

We cannot see belonging.

So we dance together.

The more customs we examine, the more obvious this becomes. Human beings are constantly turning **abstract ideas into physical behaviour**.

And perhaps this explains why rituals survive even in highly modern societies.

Technology changes quickly.

Human needs don't.

We still need ways to say:

I respect you.

I remember you.

You belong here.

I am sorry.

I am grateful.

You are welcome.

The bow is simply one particularly elegant solution to the problem.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the gestures you use every day.

A handshake.

A nod.

A smile.

A wave.

A hug.

A raised eyebrow.

A hand on someone's shoulder.

What do these gestures communicate that words sometimes cannot? And ask yourself:

Do your physical behaviours communicate the same values as your words?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Every culture has rules for social interaction.** We notice them more easily when they are different from our own.
2. **The body communicates.** Posture, distance and gestures can express relationships and emotions.
3. **Ritual makes invisible values visible.** Respect and humility can be expressed physically.
4. **Our own customs are often invisible to us.** We experience them as "normal" because we learned them early.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

gesture *(n.)* a movement used to communicate an idea or feeling

respect *(n.)* admiration or consideration for another person

humility *(n.)* the quality of not considering yourself more important than others

acknowledge *(v.)* to recognize someone or something

hierarchy *(n.)* a system in which people or things are ranked according to status or importance

posture *(n.)* the way a person holds their body

interaction *(n.)* communication or activity between people

to move within *(phrase)* to operate or behave comfortably within a particular system

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The bow encodes a hierarchy that many societies have spent a century deliberately flattening, and it would be strange to import the ranking along with the gesture. Nor is the form the point. What transfers is the observation, not the practice: **the body has already spoken by the time the words arrive.**

OBSERVE

The next time you enter a meeting, watch what people do before anyone begins speaking.

Who stands?

Who sits?

Who approaches whom?

Who initiates the greeting?

What do their bodies communicate?

COMPARE

How would you greet:

- your closest friend?
- your employer?
- an elderly person?
- a stranger?
- someone you have just offended?

What changes?

DISCUSS

Is respect something we feel, something we say, or something we demonstrate?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a moment when your body said something your words did not.

Mint Tea
MOROCCO

When Hospitality Takes Time

A visitor arrives at a Moroccan home.

Tea is offered.

But the tea does not simply appear.

The preparation becomes part of the encounter.

The pot is prepared. The tea is poured. The host and guest talk. More tea may follow.

Nothing is being rushed.

And that is the interesting part.

In much of modern life, hospitality has become increasingly efficient.

“Would you like coffee?”

“Yes.”

“Here you go.”

The entire exchange can take less than a minute.

Moroccan tea suggests another possibility:

Perhaps the time spent preparing something for someone is part of the gift.

Mint tea has become one of the most recognizable expressions of Moroccan hospitality. Traditionally, green tea is prepared with fresh mint and sugar, and the tea is often poured from a height into small glasses.

To an outsider, the dramatic pouring may be the first thing noticed. But the more important feature is what happens around it.

Tea creates a reason to sit.

It creates a reason to talk.

It gives an encounter a beginning, a middle and an end.

And that changes the meaning of the drink.

The tea isn't simply something you consume.

It structures the relationship.

The Value of Slowness

We live in a culture that often treats speed as a virtue.

Fast communication.

Fast food.

Fast payments.

Fast transportation.

Instant answers.

We even describe some relationships in terms of efficiency: *Let's grab a quick coffee.*

The word **quick** is revealing.

We aren't necessarily going for the coffee.

We're going because coffee provides an acceptable excuse to spend a little time together.

Moroccan tea reverses the relationship.

The tea isn't the excuse for the conversation.

The preparation of the tea helps create the conversation.

That distinction is subtle but important.

Imagine that someone takes twenty minutes to prepare something especially for you.

You may value the result.

But you may also value the **effort**.

The time itself communicates something:

I was willing to spend part of my day on you.

This may explain why rituals involving food and drink appear in so many cultures.

They slow human beings down.

Eating together.

Making coffee.

Pouring tea.

Sharing mate.

Preparing an elaborate meal.

These activities create what we might call **social time** — time whose primary purpose isn't production.

No product has to emerge.

No target has to be reached.

The people are the point.

The Mathematics of Hospitality

There is an interesting paradox here.

Modern technology has made many things faster.

But faster doesn't necessarily mean better.

If technology allows us to answer an email in thirty seconds instead of five minutes, that's useful.

But if we try to make a friendship thirty seconds long, something has gone wrong.

Some human activities require **duration**.

Trust requires repeated encounters.

Friendship requires conversation.

Grief requires time.

Love requires attention.

And hospitality often requires the willingness to remain present. The Moroccan tea ritual therefore gives us something larger to think about.

Perhaps one of the most valuable things we can give another person is not money, food or information.

It is our time.

And unlike money, time cannot be recovered.

When you spend an hour with someone, that hour is gone forever. Which is precisely why it can be valuable.

The Question We Rarely Ask

Think about the last time someone gave you their undivided attention.

They weren't checking their phone.

They weren't looking at the clock.

They weren't waiting for the conversation to end.

They were simply there.

What did that feel like?

Perhaps that is what hospitality is ultimately about.

Not:

"What can I give you?"

But:

"How much of myself am I willing to give you?"

A glass of mint tea may be inexpensive.

But the ritual surrounding it can communicate something much more valuable.

You are worth my time.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the people you care about.

How often do you give them ***time without another purpose attached to it****?*

Not time while driving somewhere.

Not time while answering messages.

Not time while doing something else.

Just time.

Who in your life would benefit from more of your undivided attention?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Hospitality can be measured in time as well as generosity.**
2. **Ritual creates social space.** Preparing and sharing tea can provide a reason to slow down and talk.
3. **Speed is not always efficiency.** Some human experiences become more valuable when they take time.
4. **Attention is a form of generosity.** Giving someone your time can communicate their importance.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

hospitality *(n.)* friendly and generous treatment of guests

ritual *(n.)* a customary series of actions performed in a particular way

duration *(n.)* the amount of time something continues

undivided *(adj.)* complete and not shared with anything else

encounter *(n.)* a meeting or experience involving another person

deliberate *(adj.)* intentional and carefully considered

to slow down *(phrasal verb)* to reduce the speed or pace of an activity

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The slowness is not free. Someone prepares, pours, waits and clears, and in many households that someone is not the guest and not the host. A ritual of unhurried time assumes a person with time to give, which is itself a form of wealth. Notice that before admiring it. **Duration is a way of saying that the other person is worth the delay.**

NOTICE

The next time someone offers you tea or coffee, don't immediately think about the drink.

Notice the **interaction**.

Who prepares it?

Who serves it?

Who starts the conversation?

Who decides when it is finished?

DISCUSS

Is giving someone your time more valuable than giving them a gift?

Why?

COMPARE

How does your culture use food and drink to create social relationships?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a gathering you remember for who was there rather than for what was consumed.

Mano

PHILIPPINES

When Respect Becomes a Gesture

A young Filipino approaches an older relative.

They greet each other.

But instead of simply saying hello, the younger person takes the elder's hand and gently brings it toward their forehead.

The gesture is called **mano**.

It is small.

It takes only a moment.

But like the Japanese bow, it carries considerably more meaning than its physical movement would suggest.

The word *mano* means "hand" in Spanish. The gesture is also sometimes called *pagmamano*.

Traditionally, the younger person takes the hand of an older person and touches the back of that hand to their forehead.

The message is clear:

I respect you.

But there is another message underneath it:

I recognize that you came before me.

That second idea makes the custom particularly interesting. Modern societies often celebrate youth.

Young people are associated with energy, innovation and change. Businesses talk about "young talent." Technology companies often build their identities around being new.

But every society has to answer another question:

What do we owe the people who came before us?

The mano provides one answer.

Respect Made Physical

We often say that we respect someone.

But respect is an abstract idea.

You can't see it.

You can't put it on a table.

You can't measure it with a ruler.

So cultures develop ways to make respect visible.

A bow.

A handshake.

A title.

A lowered voice.

A particular form of address.

And in the Philippines, the mano.

The interesting thing is that the younger person performs the gesture.

The body itself acknowledges a difference in age and experience. This doesn't necessarily mean that the older person is always right. It means that **age itself is given significance**.

That distinction matters.

Respect and agreement are not the same thing.

You can respect someone's experience without accepting every opinion they hold.

You can disagree with a parent and still recognize what that parent has contributed to your life.

You can question an elder and still listen carefully.

Perhaps this is one reason rituals of respect survive.

They remind us that a person is more than the opinion they are expressing at this particular moment.

They have a history.

They have lived through things we have not.

They may know things we don't yet know.

What Gets Passed Down?

Customs themselves are examples of this process.

Imagine a child watching an older relative perform a traditional gesture.

At first, the child may not understand its meaning.

Then someone explains it.

Eventually, the child performs it.

Years later, the child may teach it to someone younger.

Something invisible has travelled across generations.

Not money.

Not property.

Not DNA.

Knowledge.

This is one of the quiet functions of custom.

A custom is a kind of cultural memory.

It says:

This is how we have learned to behave toward one another. And because the behaviour is repeated, the lesson can survive even when nobody remembers exactly when the tradition began.

The Modern Question

But there is a tension here.

Every generation changes.

Young people challenge old ideas.

Older generations sometimes resist those challenges.

A healthy society therefore needs both **respect for the past and the ability to change**.

The danger is at either extreme.

If we reject everything that came before us, we lose knowledge. If we accept everything that came before us simply because it is old, we stop thinking.

The mano doesn't require us to choose between the two.

It gives us a useful starting point:

Listen first.

Perhaps that is the deeper lesson.

Before deciding whether an older person's ideas are right or wrong, recognize that they have travelled a different distance through life.

You may still disagree.

But you have listened.

And listening is often where respect begins.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about someone older than you who has influenced your life. What did that person know because they had lived longer than you? And now reverse the question.

What do you know that someone younger than you has not yet had the opportunity to learn?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Respect can be expressed physically.** A small gesture can communicate a complex social value.
2. **Respect does not require agreement.** We can disagree with someone while recognizing their experience and contribution.
3. **Customs transmit knowledge between generations.**
4. **A healthy relationship with tradition requires both respect and reflection.**

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

elder *(n.)* an older and often respected member of a family or community

ancestry *(n.)* the people in previous generations from whom someone is descended

gesture *(n.)* a movement that communicates an idea or feeling

transmit *(v.)* to pass something from one person or generation to another

tradition *(n.)* a belief or practice passed down through generations

significance *(n.)* importance or meaning

wisdom *(n.)* knowledge gained through experience and careful judgment

to pass down *(phrasal verb)* to give knowledge, traditions or possessions to younger generations

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Deference to age preserves what older people know and also protects them from being questioned. The same gesture that transmits wisdom can insulate authority, and a society that cannot contradict its elders loses something as real as what it keeps. Both things are true at once. **A culture needs a way of marking what it owes the people who came before it, without agreeing with all of them.**

COMPARE

How do people in your culture show respect toward older people? Is age itself enough to earn respect?

DISCUSS

Should younger people automatically respect their elders, or should respect be earned?

THINK

What is one lesson you learned from an older person that you could not have learned simply from reading a book?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe someone from an older generation who influenced the way you think.

PART II

How We Eat Together

CUSTOMS 8–14

Why does a meal become an event?

8 The Asado *Argentina*

9 Sharing Mate *Argentina*

10 Fika *Sweden*

11 The Supra *Georgia*

12 The Long Meal *France*

13 The Coffee Ceremony *Ethiopia*

14 Churrasco *Brazil*

The Asado

ARGENTINA

> *The Meal Is More Than the Food*

There is a fire.

There is meat.

There are people standing around talking.

And there is someone who seems to be taking the whole thing very seriously.

That person is the **asador**.

To an outsider, an Argentine asado might look like a barbecue. But that description misses something important.

A barbecue can be a way of cooking dinner.

An **asado can be a way of bringing people together.**

The distinction becomes obvious when you watch what happens before anyone eats.

The fire is prepared.

The meat is selected.

The cooking begins.

People arrive.

They talk.

They drink.

They wait.

And they wait some more.

The meal isn't necessarily rushed toward the table.

The preparation itself becomes part of the occasion.

The person cooking isn't hidden away in a kitchen, preparing food that will eventually appear on plates.

The *asador* is often right there in the middle of the gathering. People watch.

They ask questions.

They comment on the cooking.

They talk with the person tending the fire.

The cook is therefore not simply preparing food.

The cook is helping create the social event.

The Asador

This gives the custom another interesting dimension.

The *asador* has a role.

There is knowledge involved: managing the fire, understanding the meat, controlling the cooking and knowing when different cuts are ready.

But there is also responsibility.

Other people are waiting.

The *asador* is, in a sense, temporarily responsible for everyone's meal.

And that responsibility can become part of the pleasure.

Think about how often food is separated from the people who prepare it.

You order something.

A plate arrives.

You eat.

The person who made it may be completely invisible.

The asado brings the preparation back into view.

You can see the fire.

You can smell the meat.

You can watch the cooking.

You can talk while it happens.

The anticipation becomes part of the meal.

And anticipation is an underrated human pleasure.

Why Do We Wait?

Modern life has become remarkably good at eliminating waiting. Fast food.

Instant messaging.

Same-day delivery.

Streaming.

Online shopping.

We increasingly expect things to happen when we want them. But waiting isn't always wasted time.

Sometimes waiting **creates the experience**.

Think about a birthday.

The anticipation is part of the birthday.

Think about Christmas morning.

The waiting is part of the excitement.

Think about seeing someone you haven't seen for years.

The time before the reunion makes the reunion more meaningful. The asado uses waiting in much the same way.

The meal is not simply:

hungry → food → finished.

It is:

fire → preparation → conversation → anticipation → food → conversation.

The process becomes the experience.

The Social Fire

There is something else happening around the fire.

Humans have been gathering around fires for an extraordinarily long time.

Before restaurants.

Before televisions.

Before smartphones.

Before electricity.

People gathered around heat and light.

They cooked.

They told stories.

They watched one another.

The modern asado retains something of that ancient pattern. The fire gives people a physical centre.

Nobody has to announce:

"Now we will socialize."

The fire does the organizing for them.

People simply gather around it.

Perhaps this is one reason food traditions can be so powerful. They solve several human problems at once.

We need to eat.

We need to belong.

We need to talk.

We need occasions to bring people together.

The meal provides all four.

More Than a Barbecue

It would be easy to say that the asado teaches us that Argentines enjoy meat.

That would miss the point.

The more interesting lesson is that **a meal can be an event rather than a transaction**.

A transaction asks:

What are we getting?

An event asks:

What are we experiencing together?

The difference is enormous.

You can eat an excellent meal alone and remember the food. You can eat an ordinary meal with the right people and remember the evening for years.

Perhaps the asado reminds us that food has never really been just about food.

For thousands of years, meals have helped humans create families, friendships, alliances, celebrations and memories.

We eat because we are hungry.

But we also eat because **we are human beings who want to sit beside other human beings.**

And sometimes the best part of dinner is everything that happens **before dinner begins.**

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about a memorable meal in your own life.

What do you remember?

The food?

Or the people, conversation, laughter, setting and anticipation surrounding it?

What if the experience matters more than the meal itself?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **An asado is more than a method of cooking.** It can become a social event.
2. **The preparation matters.** Watching food being prepared can make the meal more meaningful.
3. **Waiting is not always wasted time.** Anticipation can be part of the pleasure.
4. **Food creates social opportunities.** Eating together gives people a reason to gather and talk.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

asado *(n.)* an Argentine tradition of cooking meat over a fire or grill, often as a social gathering

asador *(n.)* the person responsible for preparing and cooking the asado

anticipation *(n.)* the feeling of looking forward to something

gathering *(n.)* an occasion when people come together

preparation *(n.)* the process of getting something ready

occasion *(n.)* a particular event or time when something happens

transaction *(n.)* an exchange, usually involving goods, services or money

to tend to *(phrasal verb)* to take care of or pay attention to something

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The asado depends on conditions not everyone has: space, hours, and a division of labour that in many households falls along familiar lines, with one person at the fire and others unthanked in the kitchen. Strip those away and the custom does not survive the move. What survives is the structural point: **cooking in front of your guests turns service into occasion.**

COMPARE

Think about a barbecue in your own culture.

What is similar to an Argentine asado?

What is different?

DISCUSS

Why does food seem to taste better when we share it with people we care about?

THINK

What is something in modern life that has become faster but perhaps less enjoyable because of that speed?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a meal you remember vividly, including everything that happened around it.

Sharing Mate

ARGENTINA

What a Shared Cup Asks of You

Six people in a kitchen. One cup.

A small gourd, packed almost to the rim with dried green leaf. A metal straw stands in it at an angle. Someone pours hot water down one side, drinks the cup empty, refills it, and passes it to the person beside them.

That person drinks it empty too.

Same gourd. Same straw.

Then it comes back.

The drink is **mate**, made from the leaves of the yerba mate plant. The gourd is also called a *mate*; the straw is a *bombilla*. The custom came from the Guaraní people and is shared across Argentina, Uruguay, Paraguay and southern Brazil in slightly different forms.

Elsewhere, one cup between six people would be thought unusual. Here it is ordinary — in kitchens, in offices, on park grass, in a parked car.

And it is governed by rules almost nobody writes down.

The Rules Nobody Explains

There is a server. In Spanish, the *cebador*. That person controls the kettle and refills the gourd every time.

The mate does not travel around the circle hand to hand. It returns to the server after each drink, is refilled, and is handed out again.

The order is fixed. Whoever the server begins with, the round continues in that direction, and it does not change because someone is thirsty.

You drink the whole cup. The straw makes a rough sucking noise when the water is gone, and that noise is not bad manners — it is the signal that you are done.

You do not stir with the straw or move it about. It was set in place, and shifting it spoils the brew.

And then the strangest rule of all.

You do not say thank you.

Not because gratitude is unwelcome, but because *gracias* has a job. It means: **I have had enough, do not pour for me again.** Say it early and the server stops including you.

So you keep your thanks until the end.

What Refusing Means

You can refuse, and nobody is forced. But a refusal is visible in a way that declining a cookie is not, because the round has a shape and stepping out of it changes that shape.

Accepting a mate is not a comment on the drink, which is bitter and not to everyone's taste. It is a small statement that you are willing to be part of the group on the group's terms.

That is a lot to ask of a cup.

Intimacy is rarely produced by feeling. It is usually produced by coordination.

Consider what the circle requires. You wait your turn. You accept an object that has been in other people's mouths. You trust the server to be fair. You give up having your drink when and how you like.

None of that is emotional. All of it is practical.

And yet the result is closeness — which is what happens when people make small accommodations for one another without keeping score.

The habit is not fixed. Some drink it with sugar, some with herbs; cold versions are common further north. During the coronavirus pandemic many switched to an individual gourd, and some never went back.

What survives is the arrangement underneath: one object, several people, an agreed order.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the things you never share — your cup, your fork, your headphones. Now think about the short list of people you would share them with without hesitating.

That list is not about hygiene. It is a map of who you have decided to be relaxed around.

What would you have to give up in order to add one more person to that list?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Shared objects create obligations.** One cup for several people forces waiting, order and trust in a way separate cups never do.
2. **Unwritten rules are the hardest to learn.** The circle is easy to join and easy to get wrong, because nothing is explained aloud.
3. **Closeness is built from small accommodations.** Intimacy here is a by-product of coordination, not of conversation.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

gourd *(n.)* a hard, hollow shell from a dried fruit, used as a container
Mate is served in a small gourd.

bitter *(adj.)* having a sharp taste, like strong coffee without sugar
First-time drinkers often find mate surprisingly bitter.

hesitate *(v.)* to pause before doing something because you are unsure
Visitors sometimes hesitate before putting the shared straw to their lips.

accommodation *(n.)* a small adjustment made to fit in with others
Every round of mate is a series of quiet accommodations.

obligation *(n.)* something you feel you ought to do
Accepting the cup carries an obligation to stay for the round.

to pass around *(phrasal verb)* to give something to each person in a group in turn
The gourd is passed around, but always through the person holding the kettle.

to step out of *(phrasal verb)* to remove yourself from something you were part of
Refusing a mate means stepping out of the circle, and everyone notices.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

It would be a mistake to read the mate circle as a symbol of equality. The server has real control: over the water, the order, and how long the round lasts. In some settings that role is affectionate; in others it follows seniority, and the person served first is the one who matters most in the room. Nor is the practice uniform. Many people drink mate alone, and the versions in Uruguay, Paraguay and Brazil differ enough that assuming one set of rules travels everywhere will get you politely corrected.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

obligation — hesitate — to pass around

DISCUSS

Are there objects in your culture that people share which outsiders would find strange?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you joined a group whose rules you did not know.

Fika

SWEDEN

When Stopping Is Part of the Work

It is half past nine in the morning. In an office somewhere in Sweden, people stand up.

Not because a meeting has ended. Not because there is an emergency.

Because it is time.

They walk to a table where there is coffee and usually something to eat with it — a bun, a slice of cake, a plain cookie. They sit down together and talk about something other than the work. Twenty minutes later they go back.

This is **fika**.

The word is both a noun and a verb. You can have a fika; you can fika with someone. To ask a colleague if they want to fika means roughly *shall we stop for a while, together?*

The name is usually explained as a playful reversal of *kaffi*, an old spelling of coffee. That is fitting, because the coffee is the excuse rather than the point.

The point is the pause.

Not a Break, an Appointment

English has a phrase for this: a coffee break. It sounds similar. It is not the same thing.

A break is what is left over. It happens when the work allows it, alone, at a desk, with a screen still open, and it is the first thing to disappear when a deadline arrives.

Fika, in many Swedish workplaces, is closer to an appointment. It happens at a particular time, whether or not the work is finished, with other people, away from the desk.

None of this is required by law, and it is not universal. Plenty of Swedes work jobs — shifts, deliveries, care work — where nobody stops at half past nine. But where the habit holds, it holds firmly enough that not joining is noticed.

The food matters too, modestly. A long domestic baking tradition sits behind it, and the cinnamon bun even has its own day in the calendar. But most fika is unremarkable: filter coffee and whatever is in the tin.

Can Stopping Be Productive?

The honest answer is that fika is not designed to be productive at all. It is not a technique, and nobody invented it to improve output.

And yet something happens in those twenty minutes that is hard to arrange any other way.

People who do not otherwise speak end up at the same table. Information moves sideways rather than upward. A problem worth three emails is settled in one sentence. Somebody having a bad morning is noticed.

Organizations run on relationships that no organizational chart contains.

Fika reliably produces those relationships, precisely because it is not about work.

That is the paradox. The moment you turn the pause into a tool — a networking session, a bonding exercise, fifteen minutes of required fun — it stops doing what it was doing.

It works only while it is genuinely a stop.

There is a less flattering side. A group that always pauses together is also a group with an inside, and newcomers can find the conversation hard to enter, particularly in a second language. The habit that includes most people quietly excludes some.

Still, the arrangement underneath is worth naming.

A society decided that stopping should have a time, a name, and other people in it.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how you rested yesterday. Did you choose the moment, or did it arrive when nothing else was left?

Most of us treat rest as the space around our obligations rather than as one of them. It gets what is spare.

If your rest had a fixed time in the day that you could not move, what would you have to change about everything else?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A scheduled pause behaves differently from a spare-moment one.** Rest with a fixed time survives busy weeks; rest that waits for a gap does not.
2. **Useful conversations happen away from the work.** Fika produces them as a side effect of doing nothing in particular.
3. **A pause loses its value when given a purpose.** Made into a productivity technique, the break stops working.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

pause *(n.)* a short stop in an activity before it continues
The fika is a pause with a fixed place in the working day.

mundane *(adj.)* ordinary and not at all exciting
Most fika is entirely mundane: coffee and a cookie from a tin.

paradox *(n.)* a situation that seems to contradict itself but is true

Fika is a paradox: it is useful only when nobody is using it.

deliberate *(adj.)* done on purpose, after thought

Stopping at a set hour is deliberate rather than accidental.

exclude *(v.)* to keep someone out of a group or activity

A group that pauses together can unintentionally exclude its newest member.

to stop for *(phrasal verb)* to interrupt what you are doing in order to do something else

Colleagues stop for coffee at the same time each morning.

to catch up *(phrasal verb)* to exchange news with someone you have not spoken to recently

Half the value is the chance to catch up with other departments.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Fika sits inside conditions that do not travel with it. Swedish working life has strong employment protections, regulated hours and an expectation that people leave in the early evening; a twenty-minute pause is affordable because the structure around it is not desperate. Copied into a workplace with no job security and unpaid overtime, it becomes a pleasant ritual laid over an unchanged problem. It is also not a national trait: Swedes disagree about it, some workplaces have dropped it, and it has been exported abroad as lifestyle advice, which is a strange fate for something whose character is that it is unremarkable.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

deliberate — mundane — to catch up

DISCUSS

In your working or studying life, who decides when you rest?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when stopping work improved it.

The Supra

GEORGIA

When a Table Needs a Chairman

The table is already too full when you sit down.

Dishes are set out all at once rather than in courses, and when there is no more room the newer plates go on top of the older ones. Wine, often made by someone in the family, is poured.

You reach for your glass.

Someone puts a hand out. Not yet.

At a Georgian **supra**, you do not drink whenever you like. You drink when the toast reaches you.

The Person in Charge of the Evening

A supra has a leader: the **tamada**, or toastmaster. The role is closer to a chairman than a host, and the choice is not casual: it goes to someone thought capable of holding a long evening together.

The tamada decides when a toast begins, what it is about, and how long the table stays with it. Between toasts people eat and talk. During one, they listen.

The toasts follow a sequence rather than arriving at random. The order varies by region, occasion and family, but a supra typically moves

through established subjects — peace, the dead, parents, children, friendship, the guests, the country. The tamada may also invite someone to take up a toast in their own words, a handover known as *alaverdi*.

Speaking is not optional. If the toast comes to you, you speak.

And a toast is not one line long. A good one develops an idea, names people, and says something true about them. Only at the end does anyone drink.

Then it starts again. A large supra runs for many hours, often with polyphonic singing.

What the Structure Does

It is tempting to call this warmth. But a supra is a **structure**, and structures exist because informal arrangements fail in predictable ways.

Consider what an ordinary dinner party does badly.

The confident talk; the quiet do not. Whoever speaks loudest sets the subject. Nobody says the serious thing — about the dead, about the children, about what the guests mean to the household — because no moment is provided for it.

The supra provides the moment. It orders the speaking and gives one person authority to distribute it.

Ceremony is what a culture uses when it does not want an important thing left to chance.

But a supra is not only warm. It is a formal institution with expectations attached, and they fall on people unequally.

Hosting is expensive, and the abundance is not generosity but a standard the household is judged by. The drinking is real: wine is taken in full glasses at each toast, and the pressure at some tables is considerable. The tamada has almost always been a man, and in many households the cooking and serving has fallen to women who spend far less of the evening seated than the guests — though this varies between families and is not what it was two generations ago.

There is a mourning version too, with restrained toasts and no celebration.

Georgians argue about it. Some younger people keep supras for weddings and funerals and eat casually otherwise; some find the long evenings exhausting. Others regard it as one of the few forms that still puts three generations at one table for a whole night.

Both can be true of the same custom.

What to take from it is narrower than a lesson about hospitality. It is that certain kinds of speech will not happen unless a society builds a container for them.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of something you have wanted to say to the people closest to you and never said.

The obstacle is not feeling. It is that no occasion exists on which saying it would seem normal.

If your family had one evening a year where such things were expected, what would you use it to say?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Ceremony distributes attention.** A fixed sequence of toasts ensures quiet people speak and serious subjects are raised.
2. **Formality can make sincerity easier.** Given a moment for real speech, meaning something stops being awkward.
3. **An institution carries obligations too.** The supra involves cost, endurance and roles that have not fallen equally.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

abundance *(n.)* a very large quantity of something
The table shows abundance, dishes stacked on dishes.

sequence *(n.)* a set of things arranged in a particular order
The toasts follow a sequence rather than arriving at random.

sincerity *(n.)* the quality of genuinely meaning what you say
Ceremony makes sincerity ordinary instead of embarrassing.

restrained *(adj.)* controlled and deliberately not showy

The supra after a death is a restrained version of the form.

obligation *(n.)* a duty that circumstances place on you

Hosting brings obligations, including the cost of the table.

to take up *(phrasal verb)* to continue something another person has begun

The toastmaster may invite a guest to take up a toast.

to hold together *(phrasal verb)* to keep something unified and working

A good tamada can hold a table of thirty people together for six hours.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The supra cannot be borrowed as a technique for better dinner parties, because its authority does not travel. The tamada works because guests already accept that the role exists; appoint one at a table that has never heard of the role and you have appointed someone to interrupt people. The wine is not decorative either — the drinking is substantial, and the form without that context is something else. Nor is it one fixed thing: supras differ by region, by generation, and by whether the occasion is a wedding or a funeral.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

sequence — sincerity — to hold together

DISCUSS

Does your culture provide any occasion on which people are expected to speak seriously?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion when you had to speak in front of people who know you well.

The Long Meal

FRANCE

Why the Courses Come One at a Time

You have finished your starter. The plate is taken away.

Nothing arrives.

There is bread on the table, and wine, and the people you came with. Minutes pass before the next dish appears, and the gap is not a failure of the kitchen.

It is the design.

A meal built in courses cannot be eaten quickly. Not because anyone forbids it, but because the food is not all there. You are prevented from finishing early, and what fills the space is conversation.

The structure does the work that willpower would otherwise have to do.

A Sequence, Not a Plate

The full form is familiar even to people who have never sat through it: a drink beforehand, a starter, a main course, then cheese, then dessert.

Not every meal in France has all of that; most weekday meals have far less. But the shape is the reference point, and it appears in full at the

meals that matter — Sundays, birthdays, weddings, the lunch that ends in the middle of the afternoon.

In 2010, UNESCO added the French gastronomic meal to its list of the intangible cultural heritage of humanity. What was recognized was not a recipe but a social practice: the choosing of dishes, the matching of food and wine, the care taken over the table, the order of service.

That is an unusual thing for a country to be recognized for. Not a food. A procedure.

The Argument Against Speed

Every culture has a version of eating quickly, and there is nothing wrong with it. Food eaten standing up is still food.

But a society that eats mainly at speed loses something specific.

It is not nutrition. It is not pleasure, exactly.

It is the **occasion**.

A meal assembles people who would not otherwise sit facing each other. Children and grandparents. In-laws. The friend you have meant to see for a year.

Shorten it to twenty minutes and the assembly still happens, but nothing can be built inside it. Twenty minutes is enough to exchange news. It is not enough for the second thing — the one that comes only after the first subject is exhausted and the table falls briefly quiet.

The long meal produces those silences, then waits to see what fills them.

There is a second effect. A meal in courses puts everyone on one schedule: nobody finishes and leaves while others are eating, because the next plate is coming for everyone.

Compare a table where each person's food arrives when ready and ends when they are done. That is a group of individuals eating simultaneously.

What Is Actually Happening Now

It would be dishonest to call France a country of two-hour lunches. That version exists mainly on Sundays and in the memory of older generations.

In cities the working lunch has been shortening for decades. Sandwich shops are ordinary, plenty of people eat at a desk, and how often anyone sits through a full sequence differs by region, income and age.

What has survived better than the practice is the standard. Comparative surveys of how people spend their days place France among the countries where the most time goes to eating and drinking, and the idea that a proper meal has a shape is still widely held, even by people who rarely have time to produce one.

That gap between what a culture does and what it still believes is worth noticing.

A standard that is not always met still changes what people aim at.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about your last three meals. How many were events, and how many were refuelling?

There is no correct ratio. But most of us have drifted further toward refuelling than we ever chose to.

If one meal a week had to be an occasion, which would you choose, and who would you require to be there?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Structure protects time better than intention.** A meal served in courses cannot be rushed, whatever anyone means to do.
2. **A shared pace makes a group.** When the next dish comes for everyone, nobody finishes and leaves early.
3. **What a culture aims at is not what it does.** The long French meal is now more standard than routine, and still shapes expectations.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

course *(n.)* one separate part of a meal, served on its own

The cheese arrives as its own course.

deliberate *(adj.)* intentional and carefully considered

The pause between courses is deliberate, not an error.

collective *(adj.)* shared by all members of a group

Serving in courses makes the pace collective.

assemble *(v.)* to gather people in one place

A long lunch assembles relatives who otherwise never meet.

refuelling *(n.)* eating purely in order to keep going

Most weekday eating is refuelling, and nothing is wrong with that.

to sit through *(phrasal verb)* to stay present for the whole of something long

Few have time to sit through five courses on a Tuesday.

to fall quiet *(phrasal verb)* to become silent, usually briefly

Conversation often begins after a table has fallen quiet.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The long meal depends on conditions that are not evenly distributed, in France or anywhere. Somebody cooks it and somebody clears it, and historically that somebody has been a woman; the leisure of the seated is produced by the labour of those who are not. It also assumes a working day that releases you at midday, which shift work, care work and retail do not. Treating slow eating as a personal virtue turns a question about time and money into a question about character.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

course — collective — to sit through

DISCUSS

In your culture, what makes a meal an occasion rather than an ordinary one?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a meal that lasted far longer than expected.

The Coffee Ceremony

ETHIOPIA

> *The Honour of Being Made to Wait*

The beans are green when they come out.

Not brown. Green, raw, washed in front of you and tipped into a flat pan over coals. Somebody sits low beside the fire and shakes the pan until the beans darken and crack.

The pan is carried round the room so everyone can draw the smoke toward them.

Only now are the beans ground, by hand.

The grounds go into a clay pot with a long neck, a *jebena*, which returns to the coals. The coffee is then poured from a height into small handleless cups, in one continuous stream.

You have been in the room the better part of an hour. Only now are you handed the first cup.

That hour is the point.

What Is Being Given

Ethiopia is where *Coffea arabica* comes from, and coffee runs through its economy and daily life. The ceremony is not rare or reserved for visitors: in many households it happens routinely, sometimes daily.

It has its own furniture. Fresh grass is often spread on the floor, incense is burned, and something is offered alongside — popcorn is common, or roasted grain.

And it does not end with one cup.

There are three rounds, poured from the same grounds and named: *abol*, then *tona*, then *baraka*, which means blessing. Each is weaker than the last. In many households, leaving before the third is not done — the sequence is complete only when the blessing has been drunk.

So the guest is asked for something too. Not money, not a gift.

Attendance. You have to still be there.

Where the Honour Actually Lies

It is easy to assume hospitality is about what is served: better food, more of it, the good glasses brought out.

The coffee ceremony argues otherwise.

The coffee is good, but it is not the extraordinary part. What is extraordinary is that nothing is done in advance. The host does not disappear into a kitchen and return with a tray.

They sit where you can see them and spend an hour of their day on you, in the open.

A gift of time cannot be delegated, and it cannot be faked.

That is why the length is not an inefficiency to be solved. Serve the same coffee in three minutes from a machine and the drink is unchanged while the meaning has gone. It was never in the cup.

It also explains why the ceremony does so much work beyond hospitality. In many communities it accompanies conversation that has to happen slowly — visiting after a death, settling a disagreement. An hour nobody can leave is useful when something difficult must be said.

The Part That Is Rarely Mentioned

The hour is real, and so is the labour.

The ceremony is usually prepared and served by a woman or girl of the household, often several times a day, and the roasting, grinding and tending of coals is as demanding as it sounds. Calling it only beautiful leaves out who is doing it.

Practice varies. Ethiopia has many peoples and no single national version; details differ by region, faith and family. Some take the coffee with sugar, some with salt or butter. The same tradition is found in Eritrea, and busy urban households shorten it.

What holds across the variations is the structure: a host who works in front of the guest, and a guest who is expected to stay.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time someone gave you their undivided attention for an hour — no phone, no other task running.

Now think about the last time you gave that.

Most of us are generous with money and things, which are easier to give than an afternoon.

Whose company would you give an unhurried hour this week, if the hour were the gift?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Hospitality can be measured in time.** Roasting and brewing in front of a guest gives them the process, not just the drink.
2. **A long ritual makes space for hard conversation.** An hour nobody can politely leave is useful when something serious must be said.
3. **Every hosted ritual rests on someone's labour.** The ceremony is mostly prepared by women, often daily.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

roast *(v.)* to cook something with dry heat until it browns

The beans are roasted in front of the guests.

unhurried *(adj.)* done slowly and calmly, without pressure of time

The sequence is unhurried by design.

undivided *(adj.)* given completely to one thing

The host offers undivided attention throughout.

delegate *(v.)* to give a task to somebody else

Time is the one form of generosity you cannot delegate.

labour *(n.)* demanding physical work, often repeated

The ritual rests on labour that is rarely mentioned.

to draw out *(phrasal verb)* to make something last longer than it needs to

The three rounds draw a visit out into an afternoon.

to sit with *(phrasal verb)* to stay in someone's company, often quietly

Neighbours sit with a grieving family through several rounds.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The lesson does not convert neatly into advice about slowing down. The ceremony belongs to households where someone is present to perform it and social time is built around presence rather than appointments; the guest's ability to stay an hour is as much a condition as the host's ability to give one. Nor is it a leisure activity invented for pleasure — it is embedded in family life, religious observance and mourning, and lifting the pleasant part out of that context misrepresents it. The hotel version most visitors meet is a shortened performance of something else.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

unhurried — delegate — to sit with

DISCUSS

In your culture, how does a host signal that a guest is important?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion when someone gave you far more time than you expected.

Churrasco

BRAZIL

A Meal With No Moment It Begins

There is no announcement. Nobody says that dinner is ready.

Someone stands at the grill with a skewer in one hand and a knife in the other. They have been there a while and will be there longer. Sausage came off first, because sausage cooks quickly, and was eaten standing.

Later there will be beef. Much later, if there are ribs, there will be ribs.

In between, people drift over, take what is ready, and drift away again.

This is a **churrasco**, and it has no start time in the way a dinner does.

Nobody Is Only a Guest

Churrasco is most associated with Rio Grande do Sul, where the older *gaúcho* form uses large cuts and coarse salt. It is eaten across the country now, in gardens, on rooftops, on apartment balconies.

What is worth noticing is not the meat. It is how the work is arranged.

There is a person at the grill — the *churrasqueiro* — and it is not a formality. It means hours in the heat, judging which skewer is ready, and carving onto other people's plates.

But that person is not hidden. Normally cooking happens elsewhere and the cook appears at the end with the result. A churrasco reverses this: the cooking sits in the middle of the gathering, and the gathering forms around it.

So people talk to the churrasqueiro while the churrasqueiro works. Somebody else cuts onions. Somebody has the drinks. Somebody arrives late with bread and is given a task. In many groups the cost is settled beforehand by everyone putting in a share.

The event is not hosted. It is assembled.

That changes the afternoon. At a hosted meal there is a giver and a receiver, and the receiver's job is to be pleased. Here everyone holds a piece of the production, so everyone has a claim on the result.

The Rhythm of Serving

Now the second thing.

A churrasco does not arrive. It accumulates.

The cuts cook at different speeds and are served as they are done, in rounds, over hours. Sausage early, quicker beef next, the long slow cuts whenever they finish. Nobody waits, because everything is never ready at once.

So there is no single seating and no clear ending.

At a table, a meal has a shape everyone shares: it begins, proceeds, finishes, and people leave. A churrasco has no such shape. It has a low

continuous supply, and around it people move — standing, sitting, going out to the front, coming back, changing who they talk to several times.

This is why the day is long. Not because anyone planned it, but because no point arrives at which it has obviously ended.

It is also why the conversation differs. At a table you get the people either side of you. Here you circulate, and speak to people you would not have chosen.

What It Is Not

Meat is expensive. A churrasco is a real cost, which is why the shared contribution is so ordinary and why many gatherings lean on sausage and chicken rather than the cuts in photographs.

The roles are not shared as evenly as that suggests. The grill has traditionally been a man's position, and the work around it — salads, rice, farofa, the clearing up — has often fallen to women, though this varies by family and generation.

And Brazil is large: a churrasco in the south, in São Paulo and in the north-east are not one event.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time you helped make something rather than being handed it. A meal, a repair, a job with other people's hands in it.

There is an ease that comes from having work to do in someone's company. It removes the pressure to be entertaining, and gives you something to talk over rather than about.

Which of your friendships would be different if you regularly made something together instead of meeting to be sociable?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Putting the cooking inside the gathering changes it.** When the work is visible, guests join it instead of waiting to be served.
2. **Shared contribution removes the guest role.** When everyone brings or does something, everyone has a claim on the result.
3. **Continuous serving produces movement.** A meal with no single seating keeps people circulating.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

skewer *(n.)* a long metal pin used to hold food over a fire
Each skewer holds a different cut.

accumulate *(v.)* to build up gradually over time

The meal does not arrive; it accumulates.

circulate *(v.)* to move around a group, speaking to different people

With no fixed seating, people circulate for hours.

contribution *(n.)* something you give towards a shared effort or cost

Everyone makes a contribution: money, bread or time at the grill.

effortless *(adj.)* appearing to require no work at all

The afternoon looks effortless because people are quietly working.

to drift over *(phrasal verb)* to move somewhere slowly, without obvious purpose

People drift over whenever something new comes off the grill.

to lean on *(phrasal verb)* to rely on something for lack of an alternative

Many gatherings lean on sausage and chicken.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The open-ended afternoon depends on time many people do not have. It assumes a free Sunday, somewhere to hold it, and relatives close enough to come without a plan; where those are scarce it becomes a rare organized occasion rather than a habit. The informality is misleading too: there are conventions about who takes the grill and how the cuts are ordered, and getting them wrong is noticed even though nobody writes them down.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

accumulate — contribution — to drift over

DISCUSS

Do you prefer gatherings where you are looked after, or given something to do?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion you helped organize rather than attended.

PART III

How We Belong

CUSTOMS 15–21

What can people accomplish together that individuals cannot?

15 Gotong Royong *Indonesia*

16 Ubuntu *South Africa*

17 The Thanksgiving Address *Haudenosaunee (Six Nations)*

18 The Potluck *Canada*

19 Dabke *Palestine*

20 The Passeggiata *Italy*

21 The Cabin *Norway*

Gotong Royong
INDONESIA

What Many Hands Can Lift

A wooden house stands on its posts at the edge of a village in South Sulawesi. By the afternoon it will stand somewhere else.

Not rebuilt. Moved.

Long bamboo poles have been pushed through the frame under the floor. Dozens of people take hold along both sides, straighten their legs together, and the whole building comes off the ground. Then they walk.

The house travels down the road at the speed of the slowest person carrying it.

There is a name for the principle underneath it.

Gotong royong.

Carrying Together

The phrase is usually explained as carrying a burden jointly — *gotong* being to carry something slung on the shoulders. It covers a wide family of practices found under different local names across the Indonesian archipelago.

Most of it is far less dramatic than a moving house.

A drainage ditch is cleared before the rainy season. A neighbour's roof is repaired. Before a wedding, men put up a canopy across the street; women cook in shifts, sometimes for days, in a kitchen that is not theirs.

In many neighbourhoods it is scheduled rather than spontaneous — *kerja bakti*, a Sunday morning of communal work, arranged through the smallest unit of local administration, the *rukun tetangga*.

Nobody is paid. Somebody usually provides coffee and something fried.

The Arithmetic of It

The obvious point is that some jobs need more than one body. A house cannot be lifted alone. A ditch can be, but not before the rain comes.

The less obvious point is what the work does to the people doing it.

When you help carry a house, you are not being generous. You are entering an arrangement. Your presence today is a claim on theirs when it is your roof, your funeral, your daughter's wedding.

This is not charity. It is a system of debt that nobody settles.

That is precisely why it holds. Charity ends when the giver's goodwill ends. An unsettled debt has no end at all — you were helped, so you go, and going means you can be helped again.

It also means the group has a memory. People notice who came, who has not come for a while, and whether the reason is good. That noticing is the enforcement mechanism, and it is cheap and constant.

What It Costs

Which is also the difficulty.

Gotong royong is often described admiringly from outside, as though it were pure warmth. Inside, it can be an obligation you cannot decline without cost. If you are new, or poor, or on bad terms with a neighbour, the arrangement presses on you harder than on others.

It has also been used from above. Indonesian governments have invoked gotong royong as a national virtue, and the language of voluntary mutual help has at times been attached to work that people were expected rather than asked to do.

It is also thinner in cities. In many urban neighbourhoods it survives as a monthly payment towards security and garbage collection — money instead of hands, which is efficient, and not the same thing.

Still, the underlying idea keeps reappearing after floods, after earthquakes, in the weeks when official help is slow.

Some things can only be lifted by people standing next to each other.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last difficult thing you did entirely alone. Not because it suited you — because asking felt like an imposition.

Most of us have learned to treat needing help as a small failure. Gotong royong assumes the opposite: that needing help is the ordinary condition, and the only real question is whether you show up when someone else is in it.

If your neighbours needed six hours of your labour this Saturday, would they know how to ask you?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Mutual aid is an exchange, not a gift.** Helping today creates a claim on help tomorrow, and the debt is never fully settled.
2. **Obligation can be a form of security.** A community that expects your presence is also a community that will turn up for you.
3. **Communal duty has a cost.** What looks like warmth from outside can feel like pressure from inside, especially for those with least time.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

communal *(adj.)* shared by all members of a group
The Sunday clean-up is communal work, and nobody is paid for it.

obligation *(n.)* something you are expected or required to do

Attendance is an obligation you cannot decline without being noticed.

spontaneous *(adj.)* happening naturally, without being planned

Much of the work is scheduled rather than spontaneous.

mutual *(adj.)* done by two or more people towards each other

Mutual aid works because everybody expects to need it eventually.

decline *(v.)* to politely refuse something

It is difficult to decline when the whole street is outside.

to turn up *(phrasal verb)* to arrive, especially at an event

People notice who turns up and who has not turned up for months.

to press on *(phrasal verb)* to weigh heavily on someone

The expectation presses on newcomers more than on established families.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Gotong royong assumes people who stay. It works because your neighbours in ten years are broadly your neighbours now, so a debt left open is safe to leave open. Where households move every two or three years, the arithmetic collapses: you would be lending labour to people who will not be there to repay it. It also assumes a shared idea of who counts as part of the group, and some households always sit outside that boundary.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

mutual — obligation — to turn up

DISCUSS

Is there anyone you could ask for a whole day's physical help without embarrassment? What makes that possible, or impossible?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a task you completed with a group that you could not have completed alone.

Ubuntu

SOUTH AFRICA

> *A Person Is a Person Through Other People*

You arrive at a door with a question. It is small and will take ten seconds to ask.

You do not ask it.

First there is a greeting. Then you are asked how you are, and you answer properly. Then you ask after the household, and hear about a cousin's illness and someone's new job. Only after that does anyone reach the reason you knocked.

To an impatient visitor this is delay.

It is not. It is the order of things: the relationship is established, and business happens inside it.

The Sentence Underneath

In the Nguni languages of southern Africa — Zulu, Xhosa, Ndebele, Swati — there is a proverb: *umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu*.

A person is a person through other persons.

The abstract noun formed from that root is **ubuntu**, usually rendered as humanness, or personhood.

Read it slowly: it is easy to hear as something gentler than it is. It is not saying people are nicer in company. It is a claim about where a person comes from.

You did not arrive complete and then acquire relationships. You were made a person by other people — fed, named, taught a language you did not invent, corrected, recognized. Your humanity was handed to you, and you are now holding a piece of someone else's.

Personhood is not a possession. It is something people do to each other.

Archbishop Desmond Tutu did more than anyone to carry the word into English. He described a person with ubuntu as open and available to others, and argued that his own humanity was bound up in the humanity of those around him — that you cannot be fully human alone.

He used it for something specific. After apartheid the language of ubuntu was attached to the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, and the word appeared in the closing section of the 1993 interim constitution, which set out a need for understanding rather than vengeance, and reparation rather than retaliation.

That is a serious use of a philosophical idea: a society which has damaged its members must restore them, not only punish, because their humanity and everyone else's are the same material.

What Happened to the Word

Then it travelled, and it got smaller.

Ubuntu now appears in management books, on conference slides, in leadership courses, on posters about teamwork. It is quoted as "I am because we are" — a translation that is not wrong, but arrives with everything difficult removed. In that form it means roughly: be a good colleague.

The flattening is worth sitting with rather than dismissing, because it shows what happens to ideas that cross borders. What travelled was the warmth. What stayed behind was the demand.

The demand is heavy. If your humanity is bound up in mine, my neglect of you damages me, and I cannot be a complete person in a society arranged to your disadvantage. That is a claim with consequences for property, for punishment, for who eats. It does not fit on a poster.

Nor is the flattening only a foreign habit. Within South Africa the concept is argued over — as rigorous moral philosophy, as a term romanticized after the fact, as a word politicians reach for. It has been invoked in a country where violence against African migrants has recurred, which tells you that naming an ideal is not the same as living inside it.

But that gap is what ideals are for.

THE HUMAN LENS

Try the proverb on your own life, literally rather than warmly.

List what you are: your language, your work, your manners, your sense of humour, your idea of what a decent person does. Now try to find one item on that list that no other human being contributed to.

If most of what makes you yourself was given to you by others, what are you currently giving that someone else will one day mistake for their own character?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Ubuntu is a claim about personhood, not a rule about manners.** It says people are made human by other people, rather than born complete and later socialized.
2. **The idea has real consequences.** If humanity is shared, then harm and neglect damage the person who causes them as well as the person who receives them.
3. **Travelling ideas lose their difficult half.** Ubuntu became a slogan about teamwork by keeping the warmth and discarding the obligation.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

personhood *(n.)* the quality or condition of being a full human person
The proverb treats personhood as something granted by others.

proverb *(n.)* a short well-known saying expressing a general truth

The proverb exists in several related southern African languages.

reconciliation *(n.)* the restoring of good relations after serious conflict

The word was attached to South Africa's reconciliation process.

flatten *(v.)* to reduce something complex to something simple and dull

Management writing flattened a philosophy into a slogan.

obligation *(n.)* a duty you owe to someone else

The warmth travelled abroad; the obligation stayed behind.

to be bound up in *(phrasal verb)* to be closely and inseparably connected with

Tutu argued that his humanity was bound up in everyone else's.

to sit with *(phrasal verb)* to stay with a difficult idea instead of resolving it quickly

It is worth sitting with the fact that the word has been commercialized.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Ubuntu is not a technique, and it cannot be adopted the way a company adopts a value statement. It grew inside particular languages, kinship systems and histories, and the concept is contested by the people it belongs to — there is no single agreed definition to import. There is also a real critique to take seriously: a philosophy that locates personhood in the group can be turned against individuals who dissent, leave, or refuse the group's expectations. Communal belonging and personal freedom are not

automatically in agreement, and any honest reading has to hold both.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

personhood — obligation — to be bound up in

DISCUSS

Is a person shaped mainly by their own choices, or mainly by the people around them? What would change in how you judge others if you took the second answer seriously?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time someone else's actions changed who you became.

The Thanksgiving Address

HAUDENOSAUNEE (SIX NATIONS)

What If Gratitude Came First?

People are gathered in a room, and there is business waiting. A ceremony, a council, a community meeting — something to be discussed and decided.

Nobody begins with the business.

A speaker begins instead to name what is already here. The people. The earth. The waters. The fish, the plants, the food crops, the medicine herbs, the animals, the trees, the birds, the winds, the sun, the moon, the stars.

Nothing has been asked for yet.

This is the Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address, known by names usually translated as something close to *the words that come before all else*. The Haudenosaunee — Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, Seneca and Tuscarora — are six nations bound in one confederacy.

The Onondaga Nation describes it as an acknowledgment of the people, the earth and all of creation, given before ceremonies, cultural activities and community gatherings. The Smithsonian's National Museum of the American Indian, which publishes a version, describes

a tradition of giving thanks to the elements of the natural world and recognizing that living things are connected.

It is spoken in Haudenosaunee languages, and the wording is not fixed — it varies between nations, communities and speakers, and with the occasion. No version is the version.

But the shape is public, and the shape is the interesting part.

Outward, Not Inward

Most of us open something important by naming what we lack. What do we need? What has to be decided by Friday?

The address starts from the opposite end. It begins with what is already given, and keeps moving outward — from the people in the room to the ground beneath them, to the water, to what lives in it, to what grows, walks and flies, to the wind, and past the sky.

The human beings are named first, then left behind — one item on a long list.

You are not the centre of it. You are early in it.

After the thanks given to each part of creation, published accounts record a returning phrase: *Now our minds are one.*

Not the same opinions. Not the same personalities. A shared direction of attention, agreed before anything difficult begins.

A gathering elsewhere might open by naming the land it stands on and the people who make its work possible. A small thing, and not the point of this.

Gratitude Is Not a Feeling

Here is the harder part.

We treat gratitude as a mood. Something warm that costs nothing and ends when the feeling ends.

The address does not leave it there. The published Smithsonian text opens from the idea that people have been given a duty to live in balance and harmony with one another and with all living things. Thanks and duty arrive together.

If you are grateful for water and poison it, what was your gratitude?

Thanks that changes nothing was never thanks.

It also sets aside a question the modern world asks constantly: *who owns this?* Ownership is a real legal idea, and a thin one. You can own a river and ruin it, entirely within your rights.

Relationship works differently. You look after a friend because of what is between you, not because you hold title to them. You look after a child for the same reason.

The address treats the world as the second kind of thing.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of what your morning depends on before you have made a single decision. Water. Food grown by strangers. Air. Roads laid by people long dead.

You earned almost none of it, and you cannot repay it directly.

So what do you owe the things that keep you alive but cannot send you a bill?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Gratitude can be a starting point rather than a response.** The address names what already exists before anyone names what they want.
2. **Thanks and obligation belong together.** Published accounts tie the giving of thanks to a duty to live in balance with other living things.
3. **Ownership and relationship ask different questions.** You can own something and destroy it; a relationship carries obligations a title deed does not.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

gratitude *(n.)* the feeling or expression of being thankful
The address treats gratitude as the beginning of a gathering, not the end.

acknowledge *(v.)* to recognize openly that something exists or matters
The speaker acknowledges the waters before any business begins.

sustain *(v.)* to provide what is needed for something to continue

The address names the plants and animals that sustain human life.

obligation *(n.)* something you must do because of a duty or relationship

Gratitude, in this tradition, carries an obligation with it.

interconnected *(adj.)* connected to and dependent on one another

The Smithsonian describes a tradition recognizing how interconnected living things are.

to look after *(phrasal verb)* to take care of someone or something

We look after what we are related to, not only what we own.

to hand down *(phrasal verb)* to pass knowledge or practice to a later generation

The address has been handed down in Haudenosaunee languages for generations.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The Thanksgiving Address belongs to the Haudenosaunee nations. It is a living ceremonial practice with its own languages, speakers and occasions, not a technique outsiders may adopt, adapt or perform. It is not a prayer to be borrowed, and no version of it is anyone's to hand out. What can honestly travel is not the ceremony but the question it puts first: what already sustains you, and what does that place you under obligation to do? That question is available to anyone. The address is not.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

gratitude — obligation — to look after

DISCUSS

Is gratitude worth anything if it changes nothing about how you behave?

What in your life do you own, and what are you in relationship with — is the list the same?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you realized you depended on something you had never thought about.

The Potluck

CANADA

> *When Nobody Is Quite the Host*

A folding table in a community hall, covered with a paper cloth.

On it: two lasagnas, a rice cooker still plugged into an extension cord running across the floor, a tray of samosas, a bowl of shredded cabbage salad, a plate of butter tarts, a pot of soup someone is stirring, and a bag of dinner rolls still in the bag.

Nobody made this meal.

Everybody made a small part of it.

Along the edge there are serving spoons that do not match, because they came from nine different kitchens and will go home to nine different drawers.

The Luck of the Pot

The word is old and English, and it originally meant something else. To take pot luck was to eat whatever happened to be in the pot when you arrived unannounced — the meal was not planned for you, and you took your chances.

The modern North American sense inverts that. Now the meal is planned by everyone and prepared by no one in particular: each

household brings a dish, and dinner is whatever the sum turns out to be.

In Canada it is close to a default social form. Church suppers and community-hall dinners. The staff lunch in December. A new neighbour's welcome. Parent-teacher nights, curling clubs, apartment-building parties, classes for newcomers where the table ends up describing the room better than the introductions did.

It travels well because it solves an old problem cheaply.

The Problem With Being Fed

Hospitality is normally an asymmetry.

Someone cooks, pays, cleans, and worries for two days beforehand. Someone else arrives, is fed, says thank you, and leaves owing something — not money, but a turn. Guests know this. It is why people say *you must let us have you over*, and why some of us avoid invitations we cannot return.

The gift is real, and so is the debt underneath it.

A potluck dissolves the debt by making everyone slightly responsible.

You are not being fed. You are feeding, and being fed, in the same hour. The cost is split so thin that nobody can be ruined by it and nobody is owed. The person whose apartment it is may have done no cooking at all, and their contribution is the room.

That changes who can hold a gathering. A full dinner for fourteen is beyond most kitchens and many budgets. Fourteen dishes is beyond nobody. So the potluck lets people be hosts who could not otherwise afford to be — students, large families, anyone in a small place with a bad oven.

It also changes what the meal is. Every dish arrives attached to a person. Something is asked about, and the answer is a grandmother, a shop across town, a recipe that was adjusted because the right ingredient was not available here. Food carries biography in a way a catered tray does not.

Where It Strains

It is not frictionless.

Left uncoordinated, a potluck reliably produces four desserts and no main course, which is why the sign-up sheet exists — and the sign-up sheet, with its assigned categories, is faintly at odds with the spirit of the thing.

The labour is not evenly shared either. Someone always brings a dish that took three hours; someone always brings chips bought on the way. Both are within the rules, and both get noticed. That work has traditionally fallen more heavily on women, and in many groups still does.

And a table assembled from many kitchens is difficult for anyone eating around an allergy or a religious restriction, because no one person can tell you what is in everything.

None of that is fatal. It is the ordinary friction of an arrangement in which responsibility is genuinely divided rather than assigned.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about who has fed you in the last year, and who you have fed.

For most people the two lists are uneven, and the imbalance is quietly managed — invitations declined, favours mentally logged, a bottle brought to keep the accounts level.

A potluck is a way of refusing to keep the accounts at all.

Is there a friendship you have let cool because you felt you owed a return you could not make?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Hospitality normally creates a debt.** One person carries the cost and effort, and the guest leaves owing a turn.
2. **Shared contribution removes the imbalance.** When everyone brings something, nobody is purely a guest and nobody is ruined by the cost.
3. **Distributed responsibility needs some coordination.** Left entirely to chance, a shared meal produces gaps and duplication.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

asymmetry *(n.)* a situation in which two sides are unequal

Ordinary hospitality contains an asymmetry between host and guest.

contribution *(n.)* something given towards a shared effort

Her contribution was a pot of soup and two serving spoons.

dissolve *(v.)* to cause something to disappear gradually

Splitting the cost dissolves the sense of obligation.

friction *(n.)* small difficulties or disagreements between people

Every shared arrangement produces some friction.

biography *(n.)* the story of a person's life

Each dish arrives with a small piece of biography attached.

to bring along *(phrasal verb)* to take something with you to an event

Bring along whatever you can manage.

to be at odds with *(phrasal verb)* to conflict with something

A detailed sign-up sheet is at odds with the informality of the meal.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The potluck is not a universal solution to unequal hospitality, and it is not distinctively Canadian — it is common across North America and in many other places under other names. More importantly, it assumes a setting where informality reads as friendliness rather than as insult. In many cultures a host's whole standing rests on providing everything, and being asked to bring a dish would suggest the household could not manage. There, the generosity runs the

other way: the host absorbs the cost precisely so that the guest owes nothing on the night. Neither arrangement is more hospitable; they place the effort in different hands.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

asymmetry — contribution — to bring along

DISCUSS

Would you rather be looked after completely as a guest, or share the work and the cost? What does your answer say about how you handle being helped?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an event you organized where other people supplied most of what was needed.

Dabke

PALESTINE

The Line That Holds

Plastic chairs have been pushed back to the wall to clear the floor.

A drum starts. Then a reed pipe, thin and loud, the kind of sound that carries over a hundred people talking.

Somebody takes somebody's hand. A second person joins, then four more, and within a few seconds there is a line across the room — shoulders touching, arms linked or hands held low, everyone facing outward.

Then the feet come down together, and the floor takes it.

This is **dabke**, and at this wedding it will go on, in bursts, for hours.

How a Line Works

Dabke is danced across the Levant — in Palestine, Lebanon, Syria and Jordan — with steps, names and tempos that vary by region and by village, and it is danced wherever people from those places have settled.

The basic mechanics are simple enough to join by joining.

There is a step, repeated: a count of weight shifts, a cross, a stamp. The line does it together. New dancers attach at the end, watch the

shoulders in front of them, and are carried through the first minute by everyone else's timing.

At the head of the line is the leader, the *lawweeh*, often holding a handkerchief or a string of beads. This dancer is the only one released from the pattern. He improvises — jumps, turns, drops low, calls the change of tempo — while behind him the line holds the base step steady, which is what makes his improvisation legible at all.

The word is usually linked to an Arabic root meaning to stamp the foot. There is a story often told about the origin: that flat mud roofs had to be packed down before the winter rain, and neighbours would line up along the roof and tread it flat together, in rhythm, singing. Whether that is history or explanation offered afterwards, it describes the form accurately — a job that only works if a row of people move at the same instant.

What Bodies Learn That Words Do Not

Here is the thing about a line dance that a circle of conversation cannot do.

You feel the person next to you.

Their weight comes through your arm before their foot lands. If you are late, you feel it as a pull. If you are early, you feel yourself dragging. Within thirty seconds you are not deciding when to step — you are stepping when the line steps, and the correction happens below the level of thought.

A group that moves together stops being a set of individuals with the same opinion and becomes a single object with many legs.

That is why so many societies put dancing at the centre of the events that make new social facts — weddings above all, but also engagements, graduations, homecomings, holidays. A wedding announces that two families are now one thing. It is a claim, and claims are easier to believe when a room has just spent an hour physically demonstrating one.

It also explains how the dance is transmitted. Nobody learns dabke from an explanation. A child stands at the end of the line holding an uncle's hand, is pulled along wrongly for a year, and then one evening is not wrong any more.

The Weight It Carries

For Palestinians, dabke carries something additional, and it should be stated plainly rather than dramatically.

Many of the specific styles belong to particular villages and districts. A large number of Palestinians have not lived in those places since 1948, and their descendants — in the West Bank, in Gaza, in refugee camps in Lebanon and Jordan, and in communities across the world — dance village steps for villages they have not seen.

So the dance functions as a record. It is performed at national commemorations and at demonstrations, and staged by professional dance companies in theatres. It is also taught in community centres and

school halls, which is a deliberate act: a form held in bodies survives conditions that destroy archives.

But the frame matters. Because outside attention tends to reach Palestinians only through politics, dabke is often described abroad as resistance and nothing else. That description is not false, and it is badly incomplete. On the overwhelming majority of nights it is danced, dabke is not a statement. It is a wedding, and someone's cousin is showing off at the head of the line, and the drummer is being asked to play one more.

Joy is not a break from the serious business. For most people, most of the time, it is the business.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time you did something in physical unison with other people — singing, rowing, marching, dancing badly at a party.

Most modern belonging is verbal. We agree with people. We share views. We follow accounts. It is belonging conducted entirely through opinion, which is why it collapses the moment an opinion changes.

What do you belong to in a way that does not depend on agreeing with anyone?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Synchrony builds groups faster than agreement.** Moving in time with others creates a sense of unity that words have to work much harder to produce.
2. **A dance can hold a record.** Styles carried in bodies survive displacement, and can be passed on where documents and places cannot.
3. **A people's celebrations should not be read only as politics.** Dabke carries political weight, but it is first and mostly danced for joy.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

unison *(n.)* the state of doing something at the same time as others
The line brings its feet down in unison.

improvise *(v.)* to invent something as you perform, without preparation
Only the leader improvises; the rest keep the step.

transmit *(v.)* to pass something on to other people or generations
The dance is transmitted by holding a hand, not by explanation.

commemoration *(n.)* an occasion held to remember an event or people
It is performed at weddings and at commemorations alike.

displacement *(n.)* the forced movement of people away from their home
Village styles have outlasted the displacement of the villages.

to attach to *(phrasal verb)* to join yourself to something

Newcomers attach to the end of the line and copy the shoulders in front.

to show off *(phrasal verb)* to display your skill in order to be admired

The leader is expected to show off; that is the role.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

A reader elsewhere can borrow the observation that bodies build belonging, but not the dance itself, and not what it means to the people dancing it. Dabke sits inside a specific history of dispossession, and a foreign audience learning three steps at a workshop is doing something different from a family dancing at a wedding in a camp. There is also a real internal complexity that outsiders flatten: arrangements differ by family, region, class and generation — who leads, whether men and women dance in the same line, how a staged performance relates to a village version. Treating it as one uniform tradition is the first mistake.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

unison — improvise — to attach to

DISCUSS

Why do so many cultures mark weddings with dancing rather than with speeches? What does the dancing do that the speeches cannot?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion when you had to coordinate closely with other people in order to succeed.

The Passeggiata

ITALY

Seeing and Being Seen

It is early evening in a small Italian town, and the main street has filled up.

Not with traffic. With people walking.

They are walking slowly, from one end of the street to the other, where they will turn around and walk back. A woman pushes a stroller. Three men of about seventy walk abreast at a speed that would not trouble anyone. A group of teenagers has stopped in the middle and is blocking everyone, which is tolerated.

Nobody is going anywhere.

A man has changed his shirt to do this.

The Walk That Arrives Nowhere

This is **la passeggiata** — the stroll. It happens in the hours before dinner, and on Sunday it happens after lunch, and in summer it happens late, when the heat has let go.

The route is fixed by habit rather than rule: the main street, the piazza, the seafront if there is one. Up to the end, turn, back. People may do the length four or five times.

The pace is the point. Walking this slowly makes stopping easy, and stopping is the actual content. You stop because you have met someone. You talk for two minutes or twenty. Then you walk on and stop again forty metres later.

Somewhere in the middle of it people sit down outside a bar, or buy an ice cream, or drink something before dinner. Then they rejoin.

And people dress for it. This is not a small detail. The Italian phrase *fare bella figura* — to present yourself well, to make a good impression — is a real social value, and the evening walk is one of the places it operates. You are going out to be looked at by people who know you.

Why a Town Needs to Look at Itself

Here is the useful question. What does a community actually get from assembling in the street for an hour with no purpose?

It gets information.

In one lap you learn that the couple from the corner house are speaking again, that someone's mother is out of the hospital and walking, that a young woman is visibly pregnant, that a family you do not know has moved into the apartment above the pharmacy, that a man who is always there is not there.

None of that was announced. All of it was seen.

A community that never physically assembles cannot notice anything.

There is a second thing, which matters more than it looks. The passeggiata produces meetings nobody arranged.

Adult friendship in most modern places runs on appointments. To see someone you must both find a free evening three weeks out, and if the evening falls through the friendship quietly downgrades. Nothing survives that system except close friends and colleagues.

The people you lose are the middle ones — the neighbour, the former classmate, the man from the shop. Those loose connections turn out to carry a great deal: information about work, help in an emergency, the sense that a place is yours.

A daily walk on a fixed route maintains all of them at zero cost, because it does not require anyone to decide to meet.

The Other Half

Being seen every evening by everyone you know is not only warmth.

The same mechanism that notices an illness notices what you are wearing, who you are walking with, whether your business is failing, whether your son has a job. Historically the passeggiata was where young people could be looked over as prospective matches, in public, under the eyes of the whole town — supervision and opportunity at once.

Small-town visibility is care and surveillance in the same instrument. For most people that trade is worth it. For someone who is different in a way the street disapproves of, it is not.

And it is uneven. The habit is strongest in small towns and in the south, weaker in large northern cities, and it has thinned in many places as working hours, cars and shopping centres changed where the evening goes. Plenty of Italians rarely do it. Plenty of others would not consider skipping it.

THE HUMAN LENS

Count the people you would recognize on your own street. Now count the ones who would recognize you.

For most of us both numbers are low, and they are low by design: we travel by car, we socialize by arrangement, and our evenings happen indoors where nobody can see in.

How many people would notice, within a week, if you stopped going outside?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Visibility is how a community monitors itself.** Assembling in public transmits news that nobody has to announce.
2. **Unscheduled meeting keeps weak ties alive.** Friendships that require an appointment tend to be lost; a fixed route and hour maintains them for free.
3. **Being seen cuts both ways.** The same attention that provides care also provides judgment, and not everyone benefits equally.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

stroll *(n.)* a slow relaxed walk taken for pleasure

The evening stroll has no destination.

pace *(n.)* the speed at which someone moves

The pace is deliberately slow, so that stopping is easy.

assemble *(v.)* to come together in one place as a group

A town that never assembles cannot notice its own members.

surveillance *(n.)* close observation of people, especially to control them

Small-town visibility is care and surveillance in the same act.

tolerated *(adj.)* allowed, though not exactly approved of

The teenagers block the street and are tolerated.

to look over *(phrasal verb)* to examine or assess someone

Young people were looked over by the whole town at once.

to fall through *(phrasal verb)* to fail to happen as planned

When an arranged evening falls through, the friendship weakens.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The passeggiata depends on physical conditions that cannot be adopted by decision. It needs a walkable centre, a street where people are not outnumbered by cars, evenings warm enough to be outdoors for much of the year, and a population that lives near the middle of the town rather than in dispersed housing reachable only by driving. A town built around car travel cannot hold one, however much its residents might like the idea. It also assumes a shared timetable — a moment when most people are free at once — which shift work and long commutes have already broken in many places, including in Italy.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

stroll — assemble — to fall through

DISCUSS

Are the people you know slightly better than strangers worth maintaining? What would it take, practically, to see them without arranging it?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when a chance meeting changed something in your life.

The Cabin

NORWAY

The Comfort of Doing Without

The last part cannot be driven.

You leave the car where the ploughing stops, put a backpack on, and walk — or, for half the year, ski — the final stretch in. Someone is carrying the food. Someone is carrying the kerosene.

The cabin, when you reach it, is colder inside than out.

So the first thing that happens on arrival is not sitting down. It is kindling, then small wood, then the stove door left slightly open until it draws. Then the water: a bucket, a walk to the stream, or snow packed into a pan on the stovetop.

The room becomes habitable in about an hour.

You brought a phone. There is nothing here to charge it with.

What a Hytte Is

The Norwegian **hytte** is a vacation cabin, and it is close to a national institution. Cabins stand in the mountains, in the forests and along the coast, and enough families have access to one — their own, a relative's, or one rented for a week — that the practice reaches well beyond the people who own property.

The traditional standard is deliberately modest. No running water. An outdoor privy. A wood stove for heat and often for cooking. Oil lamps rather than electric light. Beds in a room too small for the number of people in it.

The days are arranged around the outdoors. You go out in whatever the weather is doing, which is where the saying repeated all over Norway earns its place: *there is no bad weather, only bad clothing.*

This connects to something broader called **friluftsliv** — literally free-air life, a term that came into common use in the nineteenth century. It means time spent outdoors as a good in itself. Not training, not achievement, not a summit photograph. A walk in cold rain counts.

Norwegian law supports it directly. The right of access to uncultivated land — walking, skiing and camping across country regardless of who owns it — was written into legislation in the mid-twentieth century, and it means the outdoors is not something you must own in order to enter.

Why Choose the Harder Version

Here is the strange part. These are people who have, at home, hot water and central heating and everything else. They drive for three hours in order to carry a bucket.

The usual explanation is escape, but escape is the wrong word, because nothing about a cabin weekend is restful in the ordinary sense. There is a great deal of work in it.

Which is the point.

At home the chain between effort and result has been cut. You are warm because a system is warm; you did nothing and you know nothing about it. At a cabin the chain is short enough to hold in your hand. The room is warm because someone split wood this morning. There is water because someone walked to the stream. If nobody does these things, the consequences arrive within the hour, and they arrive for everyone.

Inconvenience is what makes a household need each other.

A house with every convenience is a house in which four people can co-exist without cooperating. Remove the conveniences and jobs appear — and jobs are what give people a reason to be in the same room, doing something side by side rather than facing each other and being expected to talk.

The second effect is on attention. When there is little to do, small things become large. The weather becomes interesting because it is going to affect you. Cooking takes an hour because it takes an hour. Boredom, which is unbearable in short bursts, changes character on the third day.

The Honest Part

The traditional hytte is not the whole picture, and Norwegians argue about this among themselves.

Many newer cabins have road access, electricity, plumbing, underfloor heating and an internet connection, and some are larger than an ordinary house. There is a real and continuing debate in Norway about cabin developments spreading across mountain areas, about their environmental cost, and about whether the simple life has quietly become a property market.

There is also the plain matter of access. A cabin is capital. Many are inherited, and the households without one in the family are not evenly distributed. The freedom to spend a weekend doing without depends on owning something to do without in.

And the simplicity is chosen. That is not a criticism, but it should be said clearly: carrying water for two days when you could leave at any moment is a different experience from carrying water because there is no tap.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how many of the things that keep you alive today you could explain, let alone perform. Your heat. Your water. Your food's route to you.

None of that ignorance is your fault. It is the cost of a system that works: convenience is invisibility, and invisibility is why we notice nothing until something fails.

Which of your comforts would you be willing to give up for a weekend, if the price of keeping it is never thinking about it at all?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Reduced convenience creates cooperation.** When warmth and water require work, a household has shared tasks instead of parallel lives.
2. **Effort restores attention.** A short chain between what you do and what you get makes ordinary things — weather, fuel, a meal — worth noticing.
3. **Chosen simplicity is not scarcity.** Doing without is restorative largely because you could stop at any time, and that difference should be named.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

modest *(adj.)* simple and not large or expensive

The standard of the traditional cabin is deliberately modest.

habitable *(adj.)* fit or comfortable to live in

The room becomes habitable about an hour after the stove is lit.

inconvenience *(n.)* a difficulty that causes extra effort or trouble

The inconvenience is not a flaw in the weekend; it is the design.

capital *(n.)* wealth held in the form of property or money

A cabin is capital, and many are inherited rather than bought.

restorative *(adj.)* having the effect of making someone feel well again

Two days of hard, simple work turns out to be restorative.

to do without *(phrasal verb)* to manage in the absence of something

Families go there specifically to do without hot water and lighting.

to draw *(v., of a fire)* to pull air through so that it burns properly

Leave the stove door open a little until the fire draws.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Cabin life rests on conditions most countries do not have: a small population spread across a great deal of accessible land, a legal right to cross uncultivated ground, and a level of general wealth that makes a second building normal rather than extravagant. Without those, the same impulse produces long lineups for scarce campsites rather than a quiet weekend. There is a deeper limit as well. This is voluntary simplicity with a car parked at the end of the track, and it

should not be read as a lesson for people whose lives already lack running water and reliable heat. The comfort of doing without belongs to those who can stop.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

habitable — inconvenience — to do without

DISCUSS

Does modern convenience make life easier, or only more invisible? Which would you rather have: the comfort, or the understanding?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when you had far fewer resources than usual and had to manage.

PART IV

How We Remember

CUSTOMS 22–28

How should we remember the dead?

22 Día de los Muertos *Mexico*

23 The Empty Chair *Poland*

24 The Olive Harvest *Palestine*

25 Remembrance Day Poppy *Canada*

26 Ancestor Altars *Vietnam*

27 Chuseok *South Korea*

28 The Irish Wake *Ireland*

Día de los Muertos

MEXICO

> *How Should We Remember the Dead?*

A table is cleared, and photographs are put on it.

Then a glass of water, because the journey is long. Then salt. Then the food the person in the photograph liked, cooked the way they liked it. Then candles, copal incense, and marigolds — *cempasúchil* — pulled apart so that a line of orange petals runs from the table towards the door.

The table is called an **ofrenda**, an offering.

Nobody is decorating a room. Somebody is setting a place.

What Actually Happens

The days are the first and second of November, alongside the Catholic feasts of All Saints and All Souls. In many communities the first is for children who have died and the second for adults, though families differ on this as on almost everything else.

The ofrenda goes up over several days. Bread is baked for it — *pan de muerto*. Sugar skulls are bought, often with a name across the forehead, sometimes the name of someone still living.

Graves are cleaned. Weeds pulled, stones washed, flowers laid. In parts of Michoacán and Oaxaca families keep a vigil in the cemetery through the night, with candles and food, and it sounds like a large family gathering, because that is what it is.

Elsewhere it is quieter, and in some northern regions it has historically been observed lightly or not at all. There is no single Mexican version of this.

The custom is old, and the custom is also unfinished.

Not the Mexican Halloween

The comparison is common, and the reason it fails is worth stating precisely. Halloween works on the pleasure of fear: the dead are frightening, and the fun lies in being frightened.

Día de los Muertos assumes something else — that the dead are your dead, known by name and by appetite, and that on these nights they are expected.

You do not defend yourself against a guest. You cook for one.

The skeletons in the imagery are not threats. They play music, wear hats, court each other, show off. The elegant skeleton in the feathered hat, *La Catrina*, began as a printed satire by the engraver José Guadalupe Posada — a comment on vanity long before she became a face at parties.

What Visibility Has Done

Global attention has changed the practice at home.

A James Bond film opened with a vast Day of the Dead parade through Mexico City — a parade that did not exist. Mexico City then began holding one, and it draws enormous crowds. An animated film took the imagery to children in dozens of countries.

Some Mexicans welcome this. Some think a domestic and religious observance is being turned into a costume and an export. Both views are held sincerely, often inside one family.

The ofrenda, meanwhile, has proved harder to change than the street. The parade is new. The glass of water is not.

The Work of Remembering

What the ritual quietly proposes is that remembering is not a feeling but a task.

Grief in much of the world is treated as something that happens to you, and something you are expected to finish. Sadness is permitted for a period, after which a person is meant to have moved on.

The ofrenda arranges it differently. There is a date. There are jobs. You buy flowers, cook a particular dish, find the photograph, say the name aloud to a child who never met them.

The dead do not need the food. The living need the occasion.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of someone you have lost. Now think about when you last spoke of them out loud, to another person, on purpose.

Most of us have no date in the calendar for it. We remember privately and unpredictably, which is why remembering can feel like something going wrong rather than something being done.

If you had to set a table once a year for the people who are gone, whose photographs would be on it — and what would you cook?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Remembering can be a practice rather than a mood.** A fixed date and a set of tasks give grief somewhere to go.
2. **The dead can be familiar rather than fearsome.** The imagery is domestic and comic, and that difference is the heart of the custom.
3. **Wide visibility changes a tradition.** Public forms have grown up beside the private ones, and Mexicans disagree about the result.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

offering *(n.)* something given, often to the dead or to a god
The table of food and flowers is an offering, not a decoration.

observance *(n.)* the practice of keeping a custom or religious occasion

The observance varies enormously between regions and households.

vigil *(n.)* a period of staying awake, often at night, to watch or remember

Some families keep a vigil at the graveside until morning.

satire *(n.)* art or writing that mocks something in order to criticize it

The famous skeleton in the hat began as a satire on vanity.

sincerely *(adv.)* genuinely, without pretence

Both views about the parade are held sincerely.

to pull apart *(phrasal verb)* to separate something into pieces

The marigolds are pulled apart and the petals laid in a path.

to move on *(phrasal verb)* to stop being affected by something and continue with life

Mourners are often expected to move on before they are ready to.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a religious observance with Indigenous and Catholic roots, kept by communities through conversion, revolution and migration. It is not a technique for processing grief, and it does not detach from its beliefs without becoming an aesthetic. Nor is it uniform: this chapter is assembled from several regions, and families in Oaxaca and in Monterrey may recognize little of each other's practice. An outsider can be a guest at it; wearing the face paint as a costume is a different act.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

observance — vigil — to move on

DISCUSS

Does your culture give people a fixed time to remember the dead, or is remembering left to each person privately? Which is easier to live with?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion on which you deliberately remembered someone who was gone.

The Empty Chair

POLAND

> *What We Owe the People Who Are Not Here*

It is the evening of the twenty-fourth of December, and a child has been sent to the window to watch for the first star.

Inside, the table has been laid. Under the white cloth there is a little hay. The dishes are meatless — often said to be twelve, though the number and the recipes vary by region and by household.

Count the chairs.

There is one more setting than there are people in the house.

Wigilia

The supper is called **Wigilia**, from the Latin for a watch or vigil, and for many Polish families it is the most important meal of the year — more so than Christmas Day itself.

It begins when the star appears. Before anyone eats, a thin white wafer called *op atek* is passed around. Each person breaks a piece from everyone else's and says something to them: a wish, a hope, sometimes an apology. It takes a long time, because everybody must do it with everybody.

Only then does the food come.

Through all of it the extra place stays empty. A plate, cutlery, a chair. Nobody sits there. Nobody clears it.

Nobody Agrees What It Means

Ask a Polish family and you may get several answers at the same table.

One is the stranger. The place is for whoever knocks — a traveller, someone with nowhere to go — and on this night no one is turned away. Many connect this to the Holy Family, who found no room.

One is the absent. The son working abroad, the daughter who could not get leave, the relative in the hospital. Poland has sent people away for centuries, by economy and by force, and in some households the empty setting has meant a particular person for decades.

One is the dead: those who used to sit at this table and do not now.

Some families hold all three without ranking them. Some are firm that theirs is the true one. Some no longer explain it, and lay it because it has always been laid.

The ritual does not require agreement. It only requires the chair.

The Use of an Ambiguity

It is tempting to treat the disagreement as untidiness, as though the custom would be improved by settling it.

But consider what the vagueness does.

A place set only for the dead would be a memorial, and it would be sad. A place set only for a stranger would be a rule of hospitality, and slightly abstract, since most years nobody comes.

Left unspecified, it holds whoever the household is missing this particular year — and nobody has to say out loud who that is.

That matters more than it sounds. Grief and worry are hard to announce at a family meal. A brother nobody mentions, a marriage that ended, a name that would change the temperature of the room: the empty place includes them without requiring anyone to speak.

Attendance Is Not Membership

Most of our arrangements count people by presence. Who is at the table, who is in the office, who replied. Absence is a subtraction: fewer chairs, one less portion.

The extra setting refuses the subtraction. The household is not the list of people currently in the room, and being unable to come is not the same as not belonging.

You can hold a place you cannot occupy.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last large meal you attended. Was anyone missing — and did anyone say so?

Most families handle absence by not raising it, on the grounds that mentioning it would spoil the evening. The Polish table does the opposite: it makes the absence visible on purpose, and then gets on with dinner.

Who is missing from your table this year, and would your family be more comfortable or less if there were a chair for them?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Absence can be marked rather than hidden.** An empty setting states plainly that someone is missing, without requiring anyone to discuss it.
2. **An unexplained ritual can be more useful than a settled one.** Because families disagree about what the place is for, it can hold the stranger, the absent and the dead at once.
3. **Belonging is not the same as attendance.** A household can count people it cannot see.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

setting *(n.)* the plate, cutlery and glass laid for one person at a table

There is always one more setting than there are guests.

absence *(n.)* the state of being away or not present

The custom makes an absence visible instead of quietly ignoring it.

ambiguity *(n.)* the quality of having more than one possible meaning

The ambiguity is not a fault in the tradition; it is what makes it work.

memorial *(n.)* something that exists to remember a dead person

If the place were only for the dead, the evening would become a memorial.

vague *(adj.)* not exact or clearly stated

The meaning is deliberately vague, and families explain it differently.

to turn away *(phrasal verb)* to refuse to let someone in

On this night, the story goes, nobody is turned away.

to get on with *(phrasal verb)* to continue with something

The family marks the absence and then gets on with the meal.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a Christian observance in a country where the church has shaped the calendar, and the empty place carries a religious meaning for many households that keep it; lifted out as a general technique for acknowledging absent people, most of it is left behind. It also sits on a specific history of emigration, war, deportation and borders that moved, which is why an empty chair reads differently in Kraków than in a country whose families have mostly stayed put. And it is not universal even in Poland. Some families have never laid the extra place, and some who do would be uncomfortable being asked to explain it.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

absence — ambiguity — to turn away

DISCUSS

Is it kinder to mention someone who is missing, or to leave the subject alone? Does your answer change if the person has died?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a gathering at which someone important was absent.

The Olive Harvest

PALESTINE

> *What Land Knows About Time*

Sheets are spread on the ground under a tree, edge to edge, so that nothing is lost.

Older hands strip the branches they can reach, pulling down through the leaves with the fingers spread like a comb. Children go up into the tree. Someone is on a ladder. Someone kneels at the edge of the sheet, picking out twigs before the olives go into the sack.

There is tea made on a small fire, and bread, and last year's oil to dip it in.

The tree being emptied today was planted by someone nobody present has met.

The Season

The harvest runs through the autumn, roughly mid-October into November, across Palestine and the wider Levant — Lebanon, Syria, Jordan — and among Palestinians living in Israel and abroad.

It is family labour. People come back for it: from the city, from work, sometimes from another country. Households that farm nothing else still turn out for the olives, in good years and in years when the yield is poor.

The sacks go to a press. The oil comes home in tins and is the household's cooking oil for the year, some of it sold or given away. Olives are cured for the table. In Nablus and elsewhere, oil has long gone into soap.

The first oil of the season is eaten at once, poured on a plate, with bread and *za'atar*.

None of this is ceremonial. It is a job with a deadline, done by everyone available.

Trees as Records

An olive tree is slow. It takes years before a young one is worth harvesting, and it can keep producing for centuries. Some trees in these groves are very old and are known as individuals.

That changes what a tree is. Not a crop. A fixed point.

Plots are inherited and divided among children, and then among theirs, until a family's holding is counted not in hectares but in trees: these six are ours, that row was my uncle's, the big one at the corner was my grandmother's.

You do not plant an olive tree for yourself.

Whoever put that tree in the ground was working for someone they would never meet. Everyone harvesting it today stands in the same relation to somebody not yet born.

The Harder Facts

The season is not straightforward for everyone, and it would be dishonest to describe it as though it were.

Many Palestinian farmers cannot simply walk to their own groves. Where land lies behind the separation barrier, or close to Israeli settlements, access requires permits and coordinated entry granted for limited periods — sometimes fewer days than the harvest needs. United Nations humanitarian bodies record incidents each season, including trees damaged or destroyed and harvesters obstructed or attacked.

The practical consequence is a compressed harvest and fruit left on trees. Volunteers, Palestinian and international, often come to help clear groves inside a narrow window.

That is the situation, stated plainly.

Knowing a Place by Working It

There is a knowledge of a place that only labour produces.

You can own land and know nothing about it. But if you have picked a particular slope every autumn since childhood, you know where the ground gives way, which tree ripens first, where the wind comes from in the afternoon.

That knowledge is not written down. It passes from a grandmother to a child who was there holding the edge of the sheet, and who will one day be the person on the ladder.

Continuity is not a feeling. It is a set of jobs somebody keeps doing.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of somewhere your family has a long connection to. Now ask what work you have ever done there.

Most of us inherit places as sentiment: a town we came from, a house in a photograph. Few inherit them as tasks. Sentiment can be lost in a generation without anyone noticing. A task cannot — someone either does it in October or does not.

What is one thing you look after that will matter most to people you will never meet?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Some work is done for people not yet born.** A tree that produces for centuries makes each generation a custodian rather than an owner.
2. **Labour teaches a place as ownership cannot.** Knowledge of ground, weather and trees comes from repeating the same work in the same spot.
3. **Continuity survives as practice.** A family stays connected to land by turning up for the harvest, not by feeling connected to it.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

grove *(n.)* a small group of trees, especially fruit or olive trees
The grove has been divided between cousins for three generations.

harvest *(n./v.)* the gathering of a crop, or the season when it happens
The harvest runs from October into November.

custodian *(n.)* a person responsible for looking after something
Each generation is a custodian of trees it did not plant.

yield *(n.)* the amount a plant or piece of land produces
A poor year reduces the yield but not the obligation to pick.

compressed *(adj.)* pressed into a shorter time or smaller space
Restricted access makes for a compressed, anxious harvest.

to look after *(phrasal verb)* to take care of someone or something
Somebody has to look after the trees between one autumn and the next.

to turn out *(phrasal verb)* to come and be present at an event
Relatives who farm nothing else still turn out for the olives.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Continuity here is not a lifestyle choice. For many families the harvest is income and food, and it takes place under conditions — occupation, restricted movement, limited access to land — that no reader outside them should imagine they understand from a chapter. The comparison fails in the other direction too: a fixed relationship to one place brings limits as well as depth, and many Palestinians live far from groves their families own. Attachment to

land is not automatically a virtue, and calling it beautiful should not become a way of overlooking what makes it hard.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

grove — custodian — to turn out

DISCUSS

Is there a difference between owning a place and belonging to it? Which of the two does work create?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a piece of seasonal or repeated work you have taken part in with your family.

Remembrance Day Poppy

CANADA

> *How a Country Agrees to Remember*

A cardboard tray sits on a shop counter at the end of October, full of small red flowers made of felt and plastic, with a tin beside it for coins. Volunteers hand them out at stations and outside supermarkets.

You take one. You put a coin in, or you do not — nobody watches.

The pin is a straight one and will not stay in a coat. Everyone has a solution: a second pin, a bit of tape, the back of an earring. For two weeks half the country wears a flower that is slightly crooked.

Then, on the eleventh of November at eleven in the morning, the country stops for two minutes.

Where the Flower Comes From

The poppy grew on the disturbed ground of the Western Front, and it entered public memory through a poem — *In Flanders Fields*, written in 1915 by John McCrae, a Canadian doctor serving in the war.

The campaign is run by the Royal Canadian Legion, an organization of veterans. The flowers are given for donations, the money goes to veterans and their families, and the Legion holds the rights to the symbol in Canada — which matters later in this chapter.

The ceremonies are much the same everywhere: a memorial, a wreath, a bugle, the two minutes. In Ottawa, at the end of the national ceremony, people file past the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier and leave their poppies on it until the stone is covered.

Nobody organized that last part. It began among the people attending.

What a Shared Object Does

Remembering alone is ordinary. Remembering together is a technical problem.

Millions of people cannot hold the same thought at once. What they can do is perform the same small action, which is what a symbol is for. The poppy is not the memory. It is the agreement to have one.

So the object has to be simple, cheap and identical. It stands for nothing very specific, which is why it can be worn by a veteran, a pacifist's grandmother and a bus driver on the same morning.

A country cannot feel anything. It can only do things at the same time.

The Argument

But a symbol everyone is expected to wear becomes something else, and Canadians argue about this every autumn.

There is the white poppy, which appeared in Britain in the 1930s and is distributed by peace groups in Canada. Those who wear it say it commemorates all victims of war, civilians included. The Legion has

objected, both to the message and to the use of the poppy, and there has been legal argument over the symbol.

There is compulsion. Public figures who appear without one are criticized. Some people wear one to avoid a conversation rather than to have a thought, and it is fair to ask what a symbol is worth once it is effectively obligatory.

And there is the question of who is remembered. Indigenous people served in large numbers and did not return to equal treatment at home; a separate national day of recognition for Indigenous veterans now falls three days earlier.

None of this is settled.

Disagreement Is Part of It

It is tempting to read the argument as damage, as though the ritual would work better if everyone agreed.

But look at what the disagreement is about. Nobody argues that the dead should be forgotten. The dispute is over what remembering commits you to: whether it honours the people or the cause, whether it belongs to the state or to the mourners, whether it can include the enemy's dead.

That a country asks those questions in public, once a year, is not a weakness in the ritual. It may be the most alive part of it.

A symbol nobody questions is not deeper remembrance. It is decoration.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of something you have worn or observed because everyone around you was doing it. A silence. A ribbon. A minute standing up.

Ask honestly whether you were thinking about the thing itself, or about being seen to.

That is not a reason to stop. Public rituals work partly through the half-present, who hold the occasion open for those who are entirely present — the ones with a specific name in their heads.

Would you still take part in a public act of remembrance if nobody could see whether you had?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Collective memory needs an object.** A crowd cannot share a thought, but it can share a small identical action at a fixed time.
2. **A voluntary symbol differs from an expected one.** Once wearing it stops being a choice, it says less about the wearer.
3. **Public disagreement is not a failure of remembrance.** The argument is evidence that the subject still matters.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

commemorate *(v.)* to remember and show respect for a person or event

The two minutes commemorate the dead of several wars, not only one.

wreath *(n.)* a circle of flowers or leaves laid at a memorial

A wreath is laid at the monument before the silence begins.

compulsion *(n.)* the state of being forced or strongly expected to do something

Critics argue that quiet compulsion has replaced free choice.

pacifist *(n.)* a person who believes war is never justified

Some pacifists wear a white poppy instead of a red one.

obligatory *(adj.)* required, not optional

A symbol that has become obligatory reveals little about its wearer.

to hand out *(phrasal verb)* to give something to many people

Someone hands them out at the entrance to every station.

to stand for *(phrasal verb)* to represent an idea

People disagree about exactly what the flower stands for.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a national ritual built on one country's particular wars, and it carries an argument about those wars inside it; it cannot be borrowed as a general model without importing the argument too. It is organized rather than spontaneous: a veterans' organization runs the campaign, holds the rights to the symbol and directs the

funds. And the "everyone" of national remembrance has never been everyone. Canadians whose families arrived after these wars, and Indigenous Canadians whose service was not matched by equal treatment at home, have their own relationships to the day.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

commemorate — obligatory — to stand for

DISCUSS

Is a public act of remembrance still meaningful if people take part out of social pressure? Who should decide what a national symbol means?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a public ceremony or day of remembrance you have taken part in.

Ancestor Altars

VIETNAM

Keeping the Dead in the Living Room

The altar is high on the wall of the main room, above head height, usually facing the door.

On it: framed photographs, a brass bowl of grey ash with the stubs of old incense sticks standing in it, a small vase of flowers, a plate of fruit, cups for tea.

Someone comes in from work, lights incense — usually three sticks — holds them for a moment between their palms, puts them in the ash, and goes to the kitchen.

The whole thing takes half a minute.

Below the altar, the television is on.

What It Is

The practice is called **thô cúng tn tiên**, the veneration of ancestors, and in a great many Vietnamese households it is part of how a home is arranged. The altar is not put away in a spare room. It occupies the best position in the main room, where guests sit.

Incense is lit at the new and full moon of the lunar month, before something important — an examination, a journey, a business decision

— and at **Tht**, the lunar new year, when ancestors are welcomed home for the holiday and seen off at the end of it. Around Tht, graves are cleaned.

The photographs are of parents and grandparents, sometimes further back. Maintaining the altar has traditionally fallen to the eldest son, though arrangements vary widely by household and region.

It crosses religious lines. Buddhist families keep altars, and so do families who would not call themselves religious. Many Vietnamese Catholic households keep one too, and families abroad set them up in apartments in Sydney, Houston and Prague.

Giñ

The most important date attached to a person is not their birthday. It is the day they died.

The **giñ**, the death anniversary, is kept every year. Relatives come, often a great many. Food is cooked — good food, typically dishes the person was fond of — and set on the altar, and incense is lit.

After a while the food is taken down.

Then everybody eats it.

That detail is the whole character of the thing. The meal offered to the dead becomes lunch for the living, at a table full of cousins, with the noise you would expect. Nothing about it is solemn. A giñ is one of the ways an extended family sees itself in one room.

The dead are not visited. They are kept in.

An Address, Not an Occasion

Most societies have some way of remembering the dead. What differs is the frequency.

In much of the world, remembering is an event: a funeral, then an anniversary, then a visit to a cemetery across town, each requiring a decision and a journey. Between those events nothing is arranged, so the dead recede — not for lack of love, but because nothing in the day mentions them.

An altar changes the arithmetic. It is in the room. You pass it going to bed. Lighting incense costs almost nothing, so it can be done often, and what is done often needs no emotional occasion.

Which is why the practice does not look morbid to the people doing it. Grief is not the point. Continuation is.

A grandmother who died before a child was born is, for that child, a face on the wall that has always been there, with a plate of fruit in front of it. That is a different way to acquire a dead relative than being told about one.

THE HUMAN LENS

Ask yourself where your dead are kept.

For many people the answer is a drawer, a box in a cupboard, a folder on a phone that is opened rarely because opening it hurts. That is not neglect. It is a decision that these things belong somewhere private, to be looked at when you are strong enough.

The other arrangement puts them at eye level in the room where you eat, which makes them ordinary — and ordinary is easier to carry than rare.

If a photograph of someone you lost hung where you would see it forty times a day, would that be harder, or would it get easier?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Frequency changes the weight of remembering.** A small daily act needs none of the emotional preparation an annual visit requires.
2. **The dead can hold a position in a household.** An altar gives them a place in the home rather than an appointment in the calendar.
3. **A commemoration can be a family occasion.** A death anniversary ending in a shared meal keeps an extended family in contact with itself.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

altar *(n.)* a raised table or shelf used for religious offerings

The altar stands in the main room, above head height.

veneration *(n.)* deep respect shown to someone, often through ritual

The veneration of ancestors is a daily habit rather than a ceremony.

incense *(n.)* a substance burned to produce a fragrant smoke

Incense is lit at the full moon and before anything important.

anniversary *(n.)* the yearly return of a significant date

The death anniversary matters more in many households than the birthday.

solemn *(adj.)* serious and without humour

A death anniversary is not a solemn occasion; it is a family lunch.

to take down *(phrasal verb)* to remove something from a raised position

After the incense burns down, the food is taken down and eaten.

to see off *(phrasal verb)* to accompany someone as they leave

At the end of the new year holiday the ancestors are formally seen off.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a religious practice, not a technique for coping with loss, and it rests on beliefs a reader may not share — that the dead can be present, can be fed, take an interest. Remove the beliefs and keep the shelf and you have a display cabinet. It also carries obligations. Someone must maintain the altar, host the anniversaries and pay for them, and that duty has historically fallen along lines of birth order and gender, with much of the cooking done by women who married

into the family. There is pressure in it as well as comfort, and households negotiate it differently, particularly abroad and among the young.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

veneration — solemn — to take down

DISCUSS

Would you rather remember someone through a few significant occasions each year, or through small daily habits? What does each choice cost?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe how your family keeps the memory of someone who has died.

Chuseok

SOUTH KOREA

Why Families Go Back

The highway out of Seoul is a line of brake lights that does not move.

In the trunk of each car: gift boxes, wrapped and ribboned — cooking oil, canned goods, dried fish, fruit in moulded trays. In the back seat, children asleep. A journey that takes three hours in an ordinary week takes eight or nine tonight, and everybody knew it would, and set out anyway.

They are going to where their family is from, which for many of them is not where they live.

The Holiday

Chuseok falls on the fifteenth day of the eighth lunar month, under the autumn full moon, and the holiday covers three days. It is often translated as Korean Thanksgiving, which gets the harvest and the travel right and little else.

Before the day, families see to the graves. **Beolcho** is the work of cutting back the grass and weeds grown over a family's burial mounds through the summer — real labour, done in heat. Then **seongmyo**, the visit itself: bowing at the grave, laying out food and drink.

At home there is **charye**, a memorial rite for recent generations of ancestors, the dishes arranged in a prescribed order and the family bowing together.

And there is **songpyeon**: small rice cakes shaped by hand into half-moons, filled with sesame or beans or chestnut, steamed on pine needles that leave them smelling of forest. Making them is a family job, with the children producing the ugly ones.

In some regions there are older public forms — wrestling, and a women's circle dance under the full moon.

The Return Is the Ritual

Strip away everything else and what is left is the journey.

Millions of people leave the cities in the same week and the same direction: outwards, towards smaller towns, towards a house where an older relative still lives, towards a hillside with the family's graves on it.

This is not a holiday in the sense of a break. Much of it is work, and the traffic alone is punishing. People go because of a date on the calendar rather than because they have decided to.

That is the useful part: nobody has to decide.

A family that gathers only when someone feels moved to arrange it will gather less and less. Enthusiasm is unreliable and the calendar fills up. A fixed obligation removes the negotiation — you are not choosing to see

your cousins, you are going to Chuseok, and your cousins will be there because they are going too.

So a family sees itself whole, in one place, once a year. Children learn who their relatives are by sitting in a room with them.

What It Costs, and What Is Changing

None of this comes free, and Koreans discuss the cost openly.

The preparation is enormous, and has traditionally fallen to women, particularly daughters-in-law, who spend days cooking for a rite performed by others. The strain has a name in common use — holiday syndrome — and appears in the newspapers each year beside the traffic reports.

Practice is shifting in response. Some families have simplified or dropped the charye rite. Some buy the ritual food ready-prepared. Some spend the holiday abroad, or stay home and sleep. Cremation has become normal, and a visit to a columbarium is not the walk up a hill to a mound.

The older members of many families regard all this as loss. The younger ones point out that the version being lost was not equally shared.

Both are describing the same holiday.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about your extended family — the cousins, the aunts, the people you would recognize at a funeral.

Now ask what keeps you in contact with them when there is no fixed occasion. Not affection; affection is not the problem. The problem is that a gathering needs somebody to organize it, and organizing it means deciding it matters more than everything else that week.

A calendar makes that decision in advance, for everyone at once.

Is there a date in your year that you would attend even when you did not feel like it — and if not, what holds your wider family together instead?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A fixed date does work that goodwill cannot.** Gatherings that depend on somebody choosing a moment happen less and less over time.
2. **Returning is itself the ritual.** The journey, the labour at the graves and the crowded house matter as much as the rite at the table.
3. **Traditions carry an uneven cost.** The preparation has fallen mainly on women, and much of the change in the holiday follows from that.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

rite *(n.)* a formal act performed in a set way, often religious

The rite is performed at a table of food arranged in a prescribed order.

mound *(n.)* a raised mass of earth, here a traditional grave

The grass on the family's burial mounds is cut back before the holiday.

obligation *(n.)* something you are required to do

The journey happens because it is an obligation, not because it is convenient.

prescribed *(adj.)* laid down as a rule

The dishes are placed in a prescribed order rather than an ordinary one.

strain *(n.)* pressure or stress caused by demands on a person

The strain of preparing for the holiday falls unevenly within families.

to set out *(phrasal verb)* to begin a journey

Families set out knowing the roads will be at a standstill.

to fall to *(phrasal verb)* to become someone's duty or responsibility

Most of the cooking has traditionally fallen to daughters-in-law.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The gathering rests on a structure a reader may not have: a place the family is understood to come from, ancestors buried there, and a rite someone in the household knows how to perform. Without that, an annual date alone will not produce the same thing. The holiday is also inherited from a Confucian tradition of family hierarchy — who bows, who cooks, who is served — and cannot be lifted out of that history and treated as a pleasant reunion. Nor is it one practice:

households differ enormously in what they still do, and a growing number do none of it.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

obligation — rite — to fall to

DISCUSS

Are family obligations a burden, a support, or both? Would your family see each other more often if there were a date nobody was allowed to skip?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a journey you made to be with your family.

The Irish Wake

IRELAND

> *The House Where Nobody Is Left Alone*

The front door is on the latch, because there is no point answering it.

Inside, the coffin is in the front room and the room is full. In the kitchen, women who are not family are making tea in quantities; someone has arrived with sandwiches, someone else with a fruit cake; and there is a line along the hall waiting to shake hands with the widow and say the thing that is said: *sorry for your trouble.*

It is one in the morning. Nobody has suggested that anyone go home.

At the back of the house a man is telling a story about the deceased, and people are laughing.

The Older Form

The traditional wake is a historical practice and worth describing as one.

The body was washed and laid out at home, and waked there for a night or two before burial. It was never left alone; people sat up with it in shifts through the night.

House customs went with it: clocks stopped, mirrors covered or turned to the wall, a window opened for a time. Candles lit. Tobacco, snuff and pipes handed round, and drink taken.

In earlier centuries there was **keening** — *caoineadh* — a formal lament performed aloud by women, sometimes by women brought in for the purpose. It had almost disappeared by the twentieth century, discouraged by clergy and by changing taste.

There were wake games too, and singing, and a noise that visitors found shocking beside a corpse. Church authorities objected to the merriment for generations, with limited success.

Burial followed within a few days.

What Survives

Much of that is gone. Undertakers and funeral homes have taken over the laying-out. The keening women are gone. The games are gone.

What has not gone is the speed and the crowd.

Funerals in Ireland still happen fast, generally within about three days of the death, so people must drop things and come. Death notices are published nationally on a website that has become an institution, and people check it.

House wakes continue, particularly in rural areas, and neighbours call in at any hour without arranging it. Where the wake is at a funeral

home, the same thing happens in a different room: the lineup, the handshake, the condolences, the standing about.

Attendance is enormous by the standards of most countries. You go to the funeral of a neighbour, of a colleague's father, of a man you played football with once.

Two Things at Once

The obvious question is how the laughing and the grief occupy the same house.

Part of the answer is that the wake is organized not around the feelings of the bereaved but around their situation. A person whose husband died this morning cannot be cheered up. What can be done is practical: fill the house, take over the kitchen, keep the kettle going, and make sure that when they look up there is somebody there.

The other part is that the wake gives everyone a job. The widow is not sitting in an armchair being pitied. She is receiving three hundred people, which is exhausting and specific and keeps her on her feet.

Grief with a task attached is easier to carry than grief with nothing to do.

Then there is the talk. Across the days of a wake the dead person is discussed continuously, in an ordinary voice — what they said once, what they were like, the thing nobody has forgiven. Some of it is funny. This is not denial. It is the first draft of what the person will be now that they are only a story.

Nobody manages the tone. Someone laughs; two minutes later someone is crying in the hall; neither is a mistake.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time someone you knew — not closely, but knew — had a death in the family.

Most of us do the same thing. We wait a few days so as not to intrude. We send a message rather than call, because a message can be answered when they are ready. Then we leave them in peace.

The wake assumes the opposite: that the danger is not intrusion but the quiet afterwards, and that the response to someone's worst week is to arrive at their house without being asked.

When someone you know is grieving, do you go to them — or do you wait to be told it is a good time?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Company can matter more than comfort.** Filling a house does not reduce the grief, but it removes the isolation that usually comes with it.
2. **Mourning and laughter are not opposites.** Talking about the dead in an ordinary voice is how a community begins to fix what the person was.
3. **Rituals change while their function survives.** The old wake customs have largely gone; the crowd, the speed and the obligation to attend remain.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

wake *(n.)* a gathering held before a funeral, traditionally beside the body

The wake lasted two nights, and the house was never empty.

bereaved *(adj./n.)* having recently lost someone close through death

The bereaved family stands in the hall for hours receiving visitors.

lament *(n.)* an expression of grief, often sung or spoken aloud

The formal lament had largely died out by the last century.

condolences *(n., pl.)* expressions of sympathy to someone who has lost a person

People line up along the hall to offer their condolences.

undertaker *(n.)* a person whose job is to prepare the dead and organize funerals

Undertakers now do the work families once did at home.

to call in *(phrasal verb)* to visit briefly, often without arranging it first

Half the village called in during the two days of the wake.

to sit up *(phrasal verb)* to stay awake late, especially to keep watch

Relatives took turns sitting up through the night.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This works because of a particular density of connection: small towns, families settled in one place for generations, and a shared understanding of what a funeral requires. Crowds arrive because everyone knows they should, and that knowledge cannot be imported by decision. The practice is embedded in a religious framework that has weakened considerably in Ireland itself, and much described here is historical — the keening, the games and the laying-out at home are largely gone. And the closeness that fills the house can be intrusive: not everyone wants three hundred visitors, and some people grieve badly in company.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

bereaved — condolences — to call in

DISCUSS

Is it better to give a grieving person space or company? Who should decide which they get?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe how people in your community respond when someone dies.

PART V

How We Mark Change

CUSTOMS 29–35

Why can anticipation be as meaningful as the event?

29 The Novena *Colombia*

30 Hatsum de *Japan*

31 The Christmas Book Flood *Iceland*

32 Sitting Before a Journey *Russia*

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35 The First Salmon Ceremony *Coast Salish and Columbia River Nations*

The Novena

COLOMBIA

The Nine Nights Before

It is the sixteenth of December and the house is fuller than it can hold.

Somebody has brought a tambourine. Somebody else has brought a small tin of maracas that a child is already refusing to share. In the kitchen there is a pot of *natilla* setting, and a bowl of *buñuelos* still too hot to pick up. The nativity scene in the corner has been under construction for a week and has acquired, as it always does, more animals than the story requires.

Then someone opens a small worn booklet, and the room goes quiet, and the prayers begin.

Nine nights of this. And Christmas has not arrived yet.

What Happens

The **Novena de Aguinaldos** runs from the sixteenth of December to the twenty-fourth. Nine evenings, one prayer each.

The structure is fixed and everyone knows it. There are opening prayers, a reading for that particular day, and prayers addressed to Mary and to Joseph and to the child. The text is old — it is generally attributed to an eighteenth-century Franciscan friar, and was later adapted into the version most families now read.

The booklets are everywhere in December. They are sold in shops, given away, and photocopied so many times that the type has gone soft.

The reading is short. What surrounds it is not.

Between prayers everyone sings *villancicos* — Christmas songs, accompanied by whatever percussion the household owns and several instruments improvised on the spot. Then there is food, and a great deal of talking, and eventually someone works out whose house it is tomorrow.

Because it moves. A novena is rarely held nine times in one place. It rotates between houses, and it also happens in offices, in schools, in apartment buildings and among groups of friends, so that a person may attend several in the same December and none of them at home.

Practice varies. Some households keep every night carefully; others manage four or five; some read the prayers quickly and get to the food. Not everyone who attends is devout, and everyone knows that too.

The Point Is Not the Twenty-Fifth

Here is the strange thing about the arrangement.

Christmas Day, in Colombia as elsewhere, is one day. The gifts, if there are gifts, come on the night of the twenty-fourth. The whole enormous machinery of December points at a single evening.

And that evening is, by design, the ninth novena. The last one. The end of a series rather than a thing standing on its own.

Most cultures treat the period before a celebration as preparation — the shopping, the cooking, the cleaning, the tolerating of relatives. It is work performed so that the real event can happen.

The novena inverts that. The nine nights are not the run-up to the celebration. **They are the celebration, and Christmas is simply where they stop.**

This solves a problem that most festivals have. A single day cannot hold what people load onto it. You wait for weeks, and then the day comes, and it is a day: it has weather and traffic and an argument in it, and somebody is tired.

Nine nights cannot disappoint in the same way, because no one of them is carrying the weight. If Tuesday is thin, there is Wednesday.

The Arithmetic of Anticipation

There is a well-known observation about holidays: people often enjoy the looking-forward more than the thing itself.

We usually treat this as a small sadness — evidence that reality falls short, that imagination oversells. The novena treats it as information.

If anticipation is where the pleasure actually lives, then the sensible thing is not to shorten the wait but to furnish it. Put people in it. Give it songs and a rotation and a dish that only appears in December. Make the corridor as good as the room.

And notice what this does to the ordinary evenings of the month. Without the novena, the sixteenth of December is a Tuesday with some shopping in it. With the novena, it is the first night.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of something you are currently waiting for. A trip, a result, a person arriving, the end of a hard stretch of work.

Most of us treat that waiting as dead time — a corridor to get through as fast as possible so the real thing can start. We are, in a sense, absent from a large part of our own lives, standing slightly ahead of ourselves.

The novena suggests a different arrangement: that the waiting can be inhabited, and that it may turn out to hold more than whatever it is you are waiting for.

What are you postponing your enjoyment until — and what is happening in the meantime that you are not looking at?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Anticipation can be built rather than endured.** Giving the waiting period its own structure, food and company turns a corridor into a place.
2. **A single day cannot carry a month of expectation.** Spreading a celebration across nine evenings means no one evening has to be perfect.
3. **Repetition creates familiarity, not boredom.** The prayers are the same each year, which is precisely why everyone can join in without being taught.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

anticipation *(n.)* the feeling of looking forward to something that has not yet happened

For many families the anticipation of December matters more than the day itself.

devout *(adj.)* deeply religious and serious about religious practice

Not everyone at the gathering is devout, and nobody expects them to be.

rotation *(n.)* an agreed list of who does something, or where, in turn

By the second night there is usually a rotation of houses for the rest of the week.

improvise *(v.)* to make or do something without preparation, using whatever is available

Children improvise percussion with saucepans when the maracas run out.

inhabit *(v.)* to live in something, or to occupy it fully

The novena is a way of inhabiting the wait rather than skipping it.

to look forward to *(phrasal verb)* to feel pleasure about something that is going to happen

People look forward to the ninth night, but they do not save their enjoyment for it.

the run-up to *(n. phrase)* the period of time just before an event

The nine evenings in the run-up to Christmas are the busiest of the year.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a Catholic devotion, not a technique for enjoying December. The prayers are prayers; the nine nights follow a religious form with its own meaning for the people reading it, and lifting the structure out while discarding the content leaves something rather thinner than what is described here. It also depends on conditions that cannot be arranged by wanting them: households near enough to visit nightly, a shared calendar, and enough people who know the songs. In practice it is uneven — some families keep all nine nights, many keep a few, and city life and distance have made a full novena harder than it once was.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

anticipation — rotation — to look forward to

DISCUSS

Is looking forward to something a form of enjoying it, or a way of avoiding the present? Which of the two are you doing at the moment?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a period of waiting in your life and what you did with it.

Hatsum de

JAPAN

The First Thing You Do

It is a little after midnight and the line does not appear to have an end.

It is cold enough that everyone is breathing visibly. The path up to the shrine is lined with stalls selling grilled things on sticks and sweet drinks, and the crowd moves forward at the speed of a crowd — a few steps, a stop, a few steps. Nobody is annoyed about it. Being here is the point, and so is taking a long time to arrive.

At the front, people throw a coin into the offering box, bow, clap, bow again, and say something silently. It takes perhaps twenty seconds. Then they move aside so the next person can do the same.

This is **hatsum de**: the first shrine or temple visit of the year.

The Shape of It

The word means, roughly, *first visit*. It is usually made in the first days of January, and for many people on the first day itself, though the large shrines stay busy for the best part of a week.

Some go at midnight. Some go on the morning of the first, having slept. Some go with the whole family in formal clothes, and some go in a coat over the previous night's clothes.

Several things happen there besides the prayer.

Many people bring back the charms and arrows and paper talismans they bought last year, and leave them at the shrine to be disposed of properly. The old year's protection is returned rather than thrown away. Then they buy this year's.

Many draw an **omikuji** — a paper fortune, taken at random from a box or a drawer. It grades your coming year somewhere between great blessing and considerable misfortune, and comments on specific matters: health, study, business, what you are waiting for, the person you are hoping to meet. A bad one is commonly tied to a rack of strings at the shrine and left behind.

Some write a wish on a small wooden plaque and hang it with thousands of others.

Practice varies enormously. Millions of people do this every year, and a great many of them would not describe themselves as religious in any strict sense. It is done because it is January, because the family goes, because it is what you do first.

First Acts

Japanese has a habit of marking the first instance of things in a new year. The first sunrise. The first calligraphy. The first dream. The year's first anything is worth noticing.

Underneath the custom sits a simple and rather stubborn idea: **that how a thing begins tells you something about how it will go.**

This is not, strictly, true. January the first is an arbitrary line drawn across a continuous sequence of days, and nothing about the universe resets at midnight.

But something does reset, and it is not nothing.

Consider what it means to make your first act of the year a deliberate one. You have not yet checked your messages. You have not yet been irritated by anybody. You have not yet resumed the ninety habits you were carrying in December. For a moment you are standing in the cold with your family, doing something you chose, before the year has had a chance to make its own suggestions.

The order matters. Not because the first act causes the rest, but because the first act is the only one you get to choose from outside. Every subsequent act is a response to the one before it.

A year does not begin at midnight. It begins the first time you do something on purpose.

The Honest Version

There is a temptation to make this sound cleaner than it is.

The lines are long and uncomfortable. The stalls are commercial. Many visitors are there for the atmosphere and the food and the fact that everyone else is going. Charms are bought for exams and driving tests with an entirely practical attitude.

But a first act does not require sincerity to work. You do not have to believe the fortune slip. You only have to go and stand in the cold, deliberately, on the first day — and then look back later and notice that this is where the year started.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the first hour of your ordinary day.

Most of us hand it over. We wake and immediately begin responding — to a screen, to a message, to whatever arrived overnight. The day has started without us, and we spend the rest of it catching up with something that was already in motion.

Hatsum de takes the first act of the largest unit of time available and gives it away to nothing except intention: a walk, a coin, a bow, a short silence.

What is the first thing you do each morning — and did you choose it, or did it choose you?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Beginnings are the one point we control from outside.** Everything after the first act is a reaction to what came before it.
2. **A ritual does not require belief to function.** Many people go without a religious motive and the act still marks the year.
3. **Closing the old is part of opening the new.** Returning last year's charms before buying this year's makes the transition a two-part act, not just a start.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

shrine *(n.)* a place regarded as holy, often built for a god, spirit or saint
The path to the shrine is lined with stalls on the first days of January.

talisman *(n.)* a small object believed to bring protection or good fortune
Last year's talismans are handed in before new ones are bought.

deliberate *(adj.)* done intentionally, after thought rather than by habit
The visit is the year's first deliberate act.

arbitrary *(adj.)* decided by chance or convention rather than for a real reason
The date is arbitrary, which does not stop it from being useful.

intention *(n.)* a plan or purpose behind what someone does
The custom gives the opening of the year to intention rather than to routine.

to set the tone *(phrase)* to establish the mood or standard for what follows

A quiet, chosen beginning sets the tone for the weeks after it.

to hand over *(phrasal verb)* to give control of something to someone or something else

Most of us hand over our first waking hour without noticing.

to see in *(phrasal verb)* to be present at the moment something begins, especially a new year

Families see the year in together, then walk to the shrine in the cold.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a religious practice at religious sites, and it belongs to a landscape of shrines and temples that most places do not have — the crowds work because the buildings are there, staffed, and open at midnight in every part of the country. The customs around it, particularly the returning and buying of charms, sit inside beliefs an outsider cannot borrow just by imitating the gestures. It is also not uniform: Shinto shrines and Buddhist temples are both visited, practice differs by region and family, attendance has changed over generations, and plenty of people do not go at all. Treating it as a productivity idea about "starting the year well" mistakes a devotional act for self-improvement.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

deliberate — arbitrary — to set the tone

DISCUSS

Does the way something begins really affect how it continues, or do we only decide that afterwards, when we look back?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when you deliberately changed how you began something.

The Christmas Book Flood

ICELAND

Permission to Go Quiet

It is the evening of the twenty-fourth of December. Dinner is finished. The presents have been opened, which in Iceland happens on Christmas Eve rather than the morning after.

And the room has gone silent.

Four people are sitting in the same lamplight, each holding a book that was wrapped an hour ago, each reading it. Somebody has made hot chocolate. Nobody is talking. Nobody is going to talk for some time.

This is **jólabókaflóð** — the Christmas book flood.

Where the Flood Comes From

The name describes the publishing year, not the evening.

Icelandic publishers release a great many of their titles in the autumn, aimed squarely at Christmas. The season is announced by **Bókatíðindi**, a catalogue of the year's new books produced by the publishers' association and distributed to households — a plain document, essentially a list, which arrives in the mail and gets read with the attention other countries give to a shop window.

So the flood is a market phenomenon. Books are published together, advertised together, discussed together, and bought as gifts in large numbers by a small population.

Then on Christmas Eve a lot of people give each other books, and a lot of people spend the night reading them.

It is worth being careful here, because the custom is often described abroad as though the entire country simultaneously shuts down to read, by some sort of national ordinance. It is not that. It is a widely enjoyed habit in a country with an unusually strong book culture — and like all habits, it is kept by some households closely, by others loosely, and by others not at all. People also get socks.

The Quiet Part

Still, something unusual is going on, and it is not really about books.

Look at what most Christmas customs ask of people. They are gregarious. You are expected to gather, to host, to talk, to play, to be pleased in company for several consecutive hours. The measure of a good Christmas is very often noise.

For a certain kind of person this is a long day.

The book flood produces, at the end of the noisiest evening of the year, a socially approved silence. Everyone is together. Everyone is also alone. You are in the room with your family and you are somewhere else entirely, and nobody is going to ask if you are all right.

It is the rare form of company that does not require performance.

That is a genuinely difficult thing to arrange. Silence between people usually has to be explained. If you stop talking at a family gathering, someone will eventually want to know what is wrong. If you take a book to the sofa on Christmas Day in most households, you are removing yourself from the celebration and everyone will notice.

The book flood removes the need to explain, because reading is the celebration. Withdrawing is the thing everyone came to do.

Attention as a Gift

There is a second, smaller idea inside the custom, and it concerns what is actually being given.

A book is a strange present. It is not much use on the night. It cannot be worn or eaten or displayed. What you have handed someone is not an object but an obligation of time — several hours of their attention, at minimum, if the gift is to be used at all.

And choosing one for a particular person is a claim. It says: *I think I know how your mind works. I think this will do something to you.* You can be wrong about that in a way you cannot be wrong about a scarf.

So a night of everyone reading is a night of everyone taking each other's guesses seriously, in silence, in the same room.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time you were with people you love and did not have to talk.

Not a pause in conversation — an agreed, extended, unembarrassed quiet, with the other person still there. Most of us have to defend that arrangement, or arrange it by leaving the room.

We tend to treat togetherness and solitude as things that have to be traded off, so that time with people costs us the quiet and quiet costs us the people.

Who are the people you can be silent with — and when did you last do it on purpose?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Company and solitude are not opposites.** A shared silence gives people each other's presence without demanding performance from anybody.
2. **A custom can make an ordinary act socially legitimate.** Reading during a family gathering is normally a withdrawal; here it is the event, so it needs no excuse.
3. **Some gifts are claims about the receiver.** Choosing a book for someone is a statement about how you think their mind works.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

catalogue *(n.)* a complete list of items, especially things available to buy
The autumn catalogue lists the year's new titles and arrives in the mail.

gregarious *(adj.)* sociable; enjoying and seeking the company of others
Most Christmas customs are gregarious, which makes this one unusual.

solitude *(n.)* the state of being alone, often by choice and without loneliness
The evening offers solitude without asking anyone to leave the room.

legitimate *(adj.)* accepted as reasonable or allowed
The custom makes it legitimate to stop talking on the busiest evening of the year.

simultaneously *(adv.)* at the same time
Publishers release their titles simultaneously in the autumn.

to shut down *(phrasal verb)* to stop operating or become inactive
The country does not shut down to read, whatever the story abroad suggests.

to withdraw from *(phrasal verb)* to remove oneself from a group or activity
Reading at a family gathering usually means withdrawing from it.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The book flood rests on a publishing industry shaped for it and on a small population with high readership and a long literary history — conditions that cannot be adopted by deciding to adopt them. It is a commercial season as much as a tradition, and it is often exaggerated

abroad into something more uniform and more solemn than it is: many households keep it, others read for half an hour, others do something else entirely, and no one is obliged. There is also a limit to the quiet itself. Silence works as company only between people who are already easy with one another; imposed on a tense family, an evening of everyone reading is not peace, it is avoidance.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

gregarious — solitude — to withdraw from

DISCUSS

Is silence between people a sign of closeness or of distance? How do you tell the difference?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a gift you chose for someone that required you to think carefully about who they are.

Sitting Before a Journey

RUSSIA

The Minute at the Door

The bags are by the door. The coats are on. Somebody has the tickets and somebody else has checked twice that the tickets exist.

There is nothing left to do and the taxi is coming.

And then someone says it — *let's sit for the road* — and everybody sits down. On the sofa, on a suitcase, on the edge of a chair, in their outdoor clothes, in a hallway they are about to leave.

Nobody says anything.

Half a minute, perhaps. Then they stand up and go.

The Custom

The phrase is *prisyadem na dorozhku* — roughly, *let's sit down for the little road*. It is a household custom, kept before departures across Russia and in other countries of the region, particularly for longer journeys.

The rules, such as they are, are simple. It happens after everything is packed and everyone is ready. Everyone sits, including whoever is staying behind. It is short. Then the sitting ends and the leaving happens.

Its origins are usually explained superstitiously. The traditional account has it that a sudden departure disturbs the spirits of the household, and that a moment of stillness settles them, or misleads them into thinking nobody is going anywhere. Similar folk logic sits behind other travel rules: not returning for a forgotten item once you have set off, or if you must, looking in a mirror before you leave again.

That is the traditional explanation. It is not usually the living one.

Ask people who keep the custom today and most will tell you something more practical. It is the last chance to remember what you have forgotten. It calms children. It stops the departure being a scramble. It is what their grandmother did, and it seems to work, and the reason is beside the point.

A custom can survive long after its explanation has been quietly replaced.

What a Threshold Does

The interesting question is not why the sitting started but why it lasted.

Consider the state that most departures are in. The last twenty minutes before leaving are the least sensible of any journey: half-decisions, doubled-back steps, a rising volume, someone unable to find a thing they had in their hand a minute ago. The mind is already in the taxi and the body is still in the hall, and the two are not cooperating.

Then everyone sits, and the machinery stops.

What the pause does is separate two states that were about to run into each other. Before it, you are a person in a house. After it, you are a person travelling. The sitting is neither. It is the joint between them, and it exists in order to be empty.

Human beings appear to need these joints. We put them everywhere: a moment of silence before eating, a pause before a speech, the beat before a difficult sentence, the long breath before opening a door you do not want to open. In each case the pause performs no task at all. That is precisely its function.

Without a joint, a change of state has to happen while you are moving, and you carry the previous state into the next one — you arrive at the station still in the argument you were having in the kitchen.

Sitting Together

There is one more detail worth noticing, and it is the people staying behind.

They sit too. They are not going anywhere, and they take part anyway.

That turns the pause into something shared. For half a minute the household is complete for the last time, all of it in one room, nobody in motion. Then it divides.

There is nothing sentimental in the way this is done. There is no speech. The custom does not ask anyone to say what they feel about the person leaving. It just puts everyone in the same room, sitting, with

the coats on — which is possibly the most that can be asked of a family at eight in the morning.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how you leave places. The office at the end of a hard day. A hospital. A house where something was decided.

Most of us do not leave them. We walk out of the door while still inside the thing, and then discover an hour later that we brought it with us, and that whoever we meet next is now dealing with it too.

The sitting is a mechanical answer to that: not a feeling to have, not a thought to think, just thirty seconds of doing nothing between one part of your life and the next.

When you cross from one part of your day into another, do you stop at all — or do you carry the last hour into the next one?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **A pause with no task is doing something.** The empty moment separates two states that would otherwise run into each other.
2. **Customs outlive their explanations.** The superstition is remembered, but most people who keep this one now describe it in practical terms.
3. **Departures are shared events.** Those staying behind sit too, which makes the household briefly whole before it divides.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

threshold *(n.)* the entrance to a place, or the point between one state and another

The custom belongs to the threshold, when leaving has been decided but not yet done.

superstition *(n.)* a belief that certain actions bring good or bad luck, without a rational basis

The superstition is remembered fondly and believed by rather fewer people.

departure *(n.)* the act of leaving, especially at the start of a journey

The minute of stillness makes the departure orderly instead of frantic.

scramble *(n.)* a hurried, disorganized effort to do something

Sitting down turns the last few minutes from a scramble into a stop.

stillness *(n.)* complete absence of movement or noise

For half a minute the hallway is full of coats and stillness.

to set off *(phrasal verb)* to begin a journey

Once everyone has stood up again, they set off without further discussion.

to double back *(phrasal verb)* to return the way you came

Tradition advises against doubling back for a forgotten item, and everyone does it anyway.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a small household habit, not a philosophy, and it would be a mistake to inflate it into one. It belongs to a particular way of travelling — long distances, real luggage, families seeing each other off, journeys that were once far harder to make and far rarer than they are now — and it makes much less sense before a commute or a short flight booked yesterday. It is also uneven: some families keep it every time, some only for long trips, some laugh at it, and younger people in cities may know it mainly as something their grandparents insisted on. The folk explanations behind it are genuine folk belief, not a metaphor invented to make a nice point about transitions.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

threshold — departure — to set off

DISCUSS

Are there transitions in your day that would be improved by thirty seconds of doing nothing? Which ones, and what stops you?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a departure you remember clearly and how the people involved handled it.

The Twelve Grapes

SPAIN

Half a Minute of Everybody Trying

Everyone in the room has a small bowl.

In the bowl are twelve grapes, counted out during the afternoon, and in some houses peeled and de-seeded by whoever was willing to do it. On the television is a clock tower in Madrid, and the whole country is looking at it.

The quarter-hour chimes go first. Nobody eats during those; the quarters are a warning.

Then the hour begins, and twelve people in a living room start stuffing grapes into their mouths as fast as they can while a bell rings.

By about the eighth there is trouble. Somebody is laughing and therefore cannot swallow. Somebody has two left with one chime to go and is going to lose. Somebody's cheeks are entirely full and they are gesturing rather than speaking.

Then the twelfth strike, and shouting, and everyone kisses everyone, and it is next year.

The Custom

The rule is one grape per chime of midnight on the thirty-first of December: **las doce uvas de la suerte**, the twelve grapes of luck. One for each month of the coming year.

Finishing all twelve in time is said to bring good fortune. Failing is said to be funny, which is the outcome most people actually get.

The reference clock is the one at the Puerta del Sol in Madrid, broadcast live, and the broadcast is itself part of the custom — the two presenters, the explanation of how the chimes work, the crowd in the square in the cold. Households across the country synchronize themselves to a clock face they are watching on a screen.

The custom took its modern shape in the early twentieth century. A frequently repeated account credits grape growers in the south-east with promoting it after a large harvest, and there are earlier references to grape-eating at midnight in Madrid; the exact origin is not settled. Whatever started it, it spread, and it spread further into parts of Latin America, where it is kept with local variations.

Canned grapes are widely sold for the purpose. Everyone knows this and buys them anyway.

Why It Has to Be Silly

There is an obvious question about the twelve grapes, which is why a country would mark the most significant temporal boundary it has by nearly choking.

Most New Year customs are either solemn or sentimental: resolutions, reflections, a toast, a song about old acquaintances, a firework display designed to be moving. They ask you to feel something appropriate to the scale of the moment.

The trouble is that the scale of the moment is unmanageable. A whole year has ended. Another is starting, and it contains everything that is going to happen to you and the people you love, and you know none of it. That is not really a feeling you can have at midnight with a drink in your hand.

So the grapes do something else. They take twelve months of unknown future and convert it into a physical task lasting about half a minute, with a clear rule, an obvious way to fail, and a bowl.

Hope compresses better than it expands.

And the task is deliberately, unavoidably undignified. There is no way to eat twelve grapes to a bell and look composed. Everyone in the room is reduced to the same condition at the same moment — the grandmother, the teenager, the guest who is meeting the family for the first time.

That levelling is not a side effect. A year is frightening in private and manageable in company, and the fastest route to company is a shared indignity. You cannot be self-conscious in a room where everybody's mouth is full.

The Twelve Months

There is one more thing in the design.

The grapes are not twelve of anything. They are the months, in order, and you eat them in sequence at speed.

Which means that for half a minute you are, absurdly and physically, going through next year — hurried, slightly behind, doing your best, not entirely in control of the pace.

The bell does not wait. That is the accurate part.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how you mark the things that matter most to you. A birthday, an anniversary, the end of something long.

We often reach for solemnity, because the occasion seems to deserve it — and then find the solemnity does not fit, and that the evening goes flat under the weight of what it was supposed to mean.

The grapes take the largest occasion available and answer it with a game that everyone loses badly.

When something in your life is too big to feel properly, do you try to rise to it — or is there something to be said for making it small and ridiculous and doing it with other people?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Large feelings need small containers.** A year of unknown future is unmanageable; twelve grapes to a bell is not.
2. **Shared silliness levels a room.** Nobody can perform dignity with a full mouth, which puts everyone present in the same state at once.
3. **A custom can be national without being solemn.** Millions of people coordinate to a single televised clock in order to do something faintly ridiculous together.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

chime *(n.)* a ringing sound made by a bell or clock
One grape is eaten for each chime of midnight.

synchronize *(v.)* to make things happen at exactly the same time
Households synchronize themselves to a clock they are watching on television.

undignified *(adj.)* lacking seriousness or self-respect in appearance
There is no dignified way to eat twelve grapes to a bell.

levelling *(n.)* the removal of differences in status between people
The levelling is immediate: everyone in the room looks equally foolish.

solemn *(adj.)* serious and formal in manner
Most New Year customs are solemn, and this one very deliberately is not.

to keep up with *(phrasal verb)* to move or progress at the same rate as something else
Almost nobody keeps up with the bell, which is part of the entertainment.

to count out *(phrasal verb)* to take a number of items one by one from a larger quantity

The grapes are counted out into bowls during the afternoon.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The grapes work because everyone is doing them at once, to the same clock, in a country where the broadcast is a shared reference point — repeated alone or among people who find it merely odd, the levelling effect disappears entirely and it is just a person eating fruit quickly. Practice also varies: some families are competitive about it, some treat it as something for the children, some skip it, and it is kept differently across Spain and across the Latin American countries that adopted it. The origin story about a grape surplus is widely repeated but not firmly established, and the custom should not be read as ancient. It is also, prosaically, a choking risk, which is why grapes are often peeled and why small children are watched.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

chime — solemn — to keep up with

DISCUSS

Why do so many cultures attach wishes to a particular moment on the clock, when nothing about that moment is different from the one before it?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe how you last marked the end of a year or another significant ending.

The Haft-Sin Table

IRAN

> *Hope You Can Put on a Table*

A cloth is spread, and then the table is built object by object.

A dish of green sprouts, grown at home over the past couple of weeks and now standing several centimetres high. A small bowl of dark, sweet wheat paste. Dried fruit of a particular tree. Cloves of garlic. An apple. A heap of dark red powdered sumac. A little vinegar.

Around them, depending on the household: a mirror, candles, painted eggs, a bowl of water, a book of poetry, a bowl with a goldfish in it.

Somebody straightens the apple by a centimetre because it was not sitting properly.

This is the **haft-sin**, and it is being arranged for **Nowruz** — the new year that begins at the moment of the spring equinox.

Seven Things Beginning with S

The name means *seven S's*. Each of the seven principal items begins with the Persian letter *sin*, and each carries a meaning.

The usual seven are **sabzeh**, sprouted wheat or lentils, for rebirth and growth; **samanu**, a sweet paste made from wheat germ, for strength and plenty; **senjed**, the dried fruit of the oleaster, for love; **seer**, garlic,

for health; **seeb**, apple, for beauty and health; **somaq**, sumac, for the colour of sunrise; and **serkeh**, vinegar, for age and patience.

Lists vary. Some households substitute one item for another; **sonbol**, the hyacinth, and **sekkeh**, a coin, appear in many versions. The additions around the seven vary more still, and reflect the family: the mirror and candles, the *Divan* of Hafez or the *Shahnameh* or a holy book, the goldfish that not everyone now approves of.

The table stays up through the holiday, which runs for about two weeks and includes visits between relatives in a well-understood order — younger to older, and then back.

Two things need saying plainly. Nowruz is far older than Islam; it comes out of ancient Iranian tradition and has been kept continuously for thousands of years. And it is not only Iranian. It is celebrated in Afghanistan, Tajikistan, Azerbaijan, Uzbekistan, parts of Turkey, Iraq and India, by Kurdish communities across several countries, by Zoroastrians, Baha'is, Ismailis and others, and in diaspora communities everywhere. The customs differ considerably between them. What follows is about one form of one of them.

Making It Visible

Every culture has hopes for the coming year. Almost all of them keep those hopes inside people's heads, where hopes normally live.

The haft-sin takes them out and puts them on a table.

Look at what that involves. Health is not a thought about health; it is garlic, bought and placed. Patience is a small glass of vinegar. Renewal is not a resolution about renewal — it is a dish of wheat that somebody had to start soaking two weeks ago and water daily, and which is now visibly, undeniably alive on the table.

A wish you have to grow for two weeks is a different kind of wish.

This is the part of the custom that repays attention. We tend to think of symbols as decorations — pictures standing in for ideas we already hold. But the arrangement runs the other way round. The object comes first, and it makes demands: it has to be sourced, prepared, placed, and looked at every day by everyone who walks past.

An abstraction cannot do that. Abstractions do not need watering.

And because the table is a physical arrangement, it can be shared without being explained. A child does not have to understand what patience means to grow up knowing which small glass on the table is the patience one. The meaning arrives through the hand and the eye, years before anybody defines it.

The Sprouts at the End

There is a detail at the close of the holiday that completes the idea.

On the thirteenth day, families go outdoors — parks, riversides, anywhere green — and spend the day out of the house. The sabzeh, the

sprouts grown for the table, are taken along and thrown into running water.

The thing you grew is not kept. It is grown deliberately, watched for two weeks, and then given away to a river.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about something you are hoping for this year. Now ask where that hope currently exists.

For most of us the honest answer is: nowhere. It lives in the head, is thought about occasionally, and leaves no trace in the room we are sitting in. Nothing on our table refers to it. Nothing needs watering.

The haft-sin does not make hopes come true, and nobody claims it does. What it does is refuse to let them stay invisible.

If someone walked into your home, would they be able to tell what you are hoping for?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Symbols make abstract hopes into objects with demands.** Something you must grow, place and tend occupies your attention in a way a thought does not.
2. **Meaning can be transmitted before it is understood.** Children learn the table by living beside it, long before anyone explains what each item stands for.
3. **Nowruz belongs to many peoples.** It predates Islam by a long way and is celebrated across a wide region and diaspora, with customs that differ from place to place.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

equinox *(n.)* either of the two times a year when day and night are of equal length

The new year begins at the exact moment of the spring equinox.

sprout *(n./v.)* a young growth from a seed; to begin to grow

The wheat is sown at home so that the sprouts stand green on the table.

abstract *(adj.)* existing as an idea rather than as a physical thing

Health is abstract until somebody puts a head of garlic on a cloth.

diaspora *(n.)* a population living outside the region their community came from

The holiday is kept across a large region and in diaspora communities worldwide.

tend *(v.)* to look after something and give it regular care

The sprouts have to be tended daily for two weeks before the table is set.

to stand for *(phrasal verb)* to represent or symbolize

Each item on the table stands for something wished for in the coming year.

to set out *(phrasal verb)* to arrange things in a particular order or position

The seven items are set out on a cloth a few days before the equinox.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Nowruz is not a decorating idea, and the table is not a mood board for intentions. The items carry meanings inside a long-held cultural and, for many families, religious framework; the seven are not interchangeable with seven objects you happen to like. It is also a mistake to describe any single version as the version — practice differs sharply between Iran, Afghanistan, Central Asia, Kurdish communities and others, between religious traditions, between regions, and between generations, and this chapter describes one common Iranian form rather than a general rule. For many families in exile the holiday also carries loss with it, and it has at times been discouraged or politicized; it is not simply a cheerful spring festival.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

abstract — tend — to stand for

DISCUSS

Does making a hope visible change your relationship to it, or is it only a reminder of something you already knew you wanted?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an object in your home that represents something you care about, and how it came to be there.

The First Salmon Ceremony

PACIFIC NORTHWEST

> *What Do We Owe What Feeds Us?*

The first fish of the run is carried up from the water.

Not tossed into a bucket. Carried.

It is laid down carefully, where people can gather. It is spoken to. It is treated less like a catch than like a visitor owed a proper welcome.

Then it is cooked and shared, often in very small portions, so that everyone present receives some.

Afterwards the bones and the remains are returned to the water.

That last part is the heart of it. The salmon is not simply consumed. Something goes back.

Not One People, Not One Ceremony

There is no single First Salmon Ceremony, and no single people who keep it.

Versions of the observance are held by many distinct nations: Coast Salish peoples, the Nuu-chah-nulth, the Chinook, and the nations of the Columbia River, among them the Yakama, the Umatilla, the Nez Perce and the Warm Springs communities.

These nations have their own languages, laws and histories. Their ceremonies differ, and the differences are not decoration.

Their territories span what is now the border between Canada and the United States. The ceremony is older than that border, and older than both countries.

Some elements are public. Others are not, and are not meant to be. Only what these communities have themselves made public is described here.

An outsider's understanding stops early here, and it should.

The Debt Runs Both Ways

The idea underneath the ceremony is reciprocity.

In these traditions the salmon are not a resource that happens to swim past. They are understood to give themselves — deliberately, as relatives who return each year to feed the people.

A gift of that size creates an obligation.

So the people owe something back: honour, correct treatment, restraint, and the return of the remains to the river so that the salmon can go home and come again.

This is not folklore, and it is not an early form of fisheries management, though outsiders sometimes describe it that way to make it sound reasonable to themselves. It is a religious observance, held now, by communities who believe what it says about the world.

What Has Happened to the Runs

The runs are not what they were.

Salmon populations across the region have fallen severely. Dams block the rivers. Spawning habitat has been lost to logging, agriculture, development and warming water.

The right to fish at all had to be defended. Treaties, and in Canada court-recognized Aboriginal rights, protected fishing rights for these nations; the rights were ignored for generations, then fought for and upheld in the courts.

Many of these same nations now lead some of the most serious salmon restoration work anywhere: hatcheries, habitat repair, dam removal.

The ceremony continues alongside that work. The obligation did not lapse when the fish became scarce.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about what you ate yesterday.

You almost certainly could not name the field, the boat, the animal or the hands involved. The food arrived through a system built so that you would never have to look at it. You paid, and the transaction closed. Nothing was owed afterwards.

That is not a failure of gratitude. It is a structure. Most of us are fed by systems we never see and cannot answer to.

The First Salmon Ceremony belongs to people who can see it — who know the river, the season, the run, and what their own behaviour does to all three. The debt is visible, so it can be paid.

The easy question is whether you should feel thankful for your food.

The harder one is what a real relationship with what sustains you would require you to do — and whether you would still want it if you knew.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **The ceremony is an exchange, not a thank-you.** Receiving the first salmon creates an obligation, and returning the remains to the water is part of paying it.
2. **Many nations, many forms.** Coast Salish, Nuu-chah-nulth and Columbia River peoples each keep their own version; there is no single practice and no single people.
3. **It is a living observance inside a difficult present.** Declining runs, dams and hard-won treaty rights are the conditions in which it is kept today.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

reciprocity *(n.)* an exchange in which each side gives something to the other

The ceremony rests on reciprocity between people and fish.

obligation *(n.)* something you must do because of what you have received

A gift on that scale creates an obligation.

observance *(n.)* the keeping of a religious or ceremonial practice

It is a living observance, not folklore.

restraint *(n.)* the act of limiting what you take

Restraint is part of what is owed in return.

habitat *(n.)* the natural place where a species lives and breeds

Spawning habitat has been lost across the region.

to give back *(phrasal verb)* to return something in exchange for what you received

The remains are given back to the river.

to depend on *(phrasal verb)* to need something in order to live

Whole communities have depended on the run for generations.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is not a metaphor about gratitude that anyone can borrow. It is a relationship with one river and one species, built over generations by people who live there, and it carries religious meaning that does not travel. The reciprocity is real rather than symbolic: the obligation is owed to an actual population of fish that can and does decline. You cannot perform the feeling without the relationship, and you cannot have the relationship without staying and being answerable for what happens next.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

reciprocity — obligation — to give back

DISCUSS

What are you fed by that you have never seen? If you could see it, would anything you do change?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time when you received something that left you owing a response.

PART VI

How We Face the Unknown

CUSTOMS 36–42

Why do we want to know what comes next?

36 Turkish Coffee Fortune-Telling *Turkey*

37 The Nazar Boncu u *Turkey*

38 Alasitas *Bolivia*

39 Tihar's Crow Day *Nepal*

40 New Year's Effigies *Ecuador*

41 MŌ i or *Romania*

42 Martenitsa *Bulgaria*

Turkish Coffee Fortune-Telling

TURKEY

> *When Someone Else Tells Your Future*

The cup is small and the coffee is finished.

What is left at the bottom is a thick sediment of grounds, too fine to drink. Someone says: turn it over.

You put the saucer on the cup, flip the two upside down, and wait for the porcelain to cool while the wet grounds run down the inside walls and dry there in streaks.

Then the cup is lifted, and someone looks in.

This is **kahve falı** — coffee fortune-telling. The reader turns the cup slowly and says what the shapes resemble. A road. A bird. A door. One figure walking away from another.

And out of those shapes, a story about you.

The Rule About Your Own Cup

In many households the understanding is that you do not read your own cup. Someone else reads it for you.

That detail is easy to skip past, and it may be the most revealing thing here.

If the point were only to know what happens next, it would not matter who did the looking. But it does.

What is on offer is not information. It is being told.

Consider what happens in those minutes. Another person holds an object that was in your hands a moment ago and studies it. They talk about your work, your family, a difficulty that is nearly over. They use your name. They watch your face while they speak, and adjust.

Somebody is paying sustained attention to your life and describing it out loud, as though it had a shape.

That is rarer than prediction.

Held Lightly, Held Seriously

People do this in very different spirits.

For many it is entertainment at the end of a meal, and nobody at the table would call it belief. Divination sits uneasily with religious teaching for a great many Muslims, and plenty of people who enjoy the cup would say plainly that it means nothing. Others take it seriously and go to readers whose word they trust.

Both are ordinary positions and neither is foolish. Most of us hold on to something the same way — a habit we would not defend in an argument and would not give up either.

What they share is the appetite. Something wants the future put into words by a voice that is not our own.

Why We Ask

Uncertainty is not painful because it is unknown. It is painful because it is shapeless.

An unread cup contains everything at once: the job, the loss, the illness, the ordinary Tuesday. A read cup contains three or four things, in a sequence, with a road in it.

The reading does not reduce what can happen to you. It reduces what you are holding in your head.

And notice how a reading tends to go. The reader names a worry and you say yes, that one. You supply the meaning; they supply permission to say it aloud. By the end you have often heard yourself explain your own life to somebody else over an empty cup.

We buy the same thing in more respectable forms — forecasts, projections, five-year plans — and for the same reason. Not certainty, which nobody can sell. A story with an order to it.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of the last time you wanted someone to tell you it would be fine.

You knew they could not know. That was not the point. You wanted the sentence said out loud by a person who was looking at you.

When you ask about the future, are you asking to be informed — or asking to be attended to?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Prediction is often about attention, not knowledge.** The custom requires another person to read for you, and that requirement is the heart of it.
2. **A story reduces uncertainty without reducing risk.** Naming three possible futures makes the unknown easier to carry, though nothing has changed.
3. **People hold the same practice at different depths.** Some treat the cup as a game and some as guidance, and both attitudes sit in the same rooms.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

sediment *(n.)* solid material that settles at the bottom of a liquid
The reading begins once the sediment has dried against the side of the cup.

divination *(n.)* the attempt to learn hidden or future things by ritual means
Divination is viewed with suspicion in many religious traditions.

uncertainty *(n.)* the state of not knowing what will happen
Uncertainty is harder to carry when it has no shape.

sustained *(adj.)* continuing at the same level for a period of time
Few things flatter us like somebody's sustained attention.

resemble *(v.)* to look like something else
The reader says which shapes resemble a bird or a door.

to skip past *(phrasal verb)* to ignore or fail to notice something

It is easy to skip past the rule that you may not read your own cup.

to hold on to *(phrasal verb)* to keep something rather than let it go

People hold on to small customs they would never try to justify.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The cup is not a therapy session, and reading it as one flattens what people think they are doing. For some readers and clients it carries real authority, and bad news in a cup can frighten someone for weeks. There is a cost, too: readings are sold, and people pay money they do not have to hear about a marriage or an illness. The custom belongs to a setting — a household, a coffee, two people who know each other.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

uncertainty — resemble — to skip past

DISCUSS

Would you rather hear a confident prediction that might be wrong, or an honest answer that explains nothing?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a decision you made without knowing how it would turn out.

The Nazar Boncu1u

TURKEY

> *The Danger of Being Admired*

It is pinned to the inside of a baby's shirt, where a stranger leaning over the stroller would not see it.

The same object hangs from a car mirror, over a shop door, on a key chain, on a chain at the throat. A flattened disc of glass: dark blue at the centre, then white, then a wider ring of blue, so that it looks like an eye looking back at you.

It is the **nazar boncu u**. *Nazar* means the look, the gaze. The bead is worn to ward it off.

In parts of western Anatolia they are still made by hand at the furnace, the rings dropped on one by one.

What the Belief Actually Says

The fear is not of a curse spoken by an enemy.

It is of a look — often an admiring one, from somebody who wishes you no harm and could not tell you they had done anything.

Somebody sees the healthy child, the new car, the shop that is suddenly busy. Something passes through them, half admiration and half something else. Afterwards, in this way of thinking, the child falls ill.

This is why the bead goes precisely where the good fortune is. Not on the old car. On the new one.

What draws the eye is what needs protecting.

There is a matching habit in speech. When people praise a baby or a piece of luck, many will say *ma allah* — a word placing the good thing in God's care, and marking the praise as praise only.

Not a Turkish Idea

The blue bead is Turkish; the belief is not.

Fear of the envious or admiring eye is found in Greece, across the Arab world and Iran, in South Asia, in southern Europe, in Latin America, and among communities descended from all of these. The names differ, the remedies differ, the theology differs. The blue glass is one local answer to a very widespread worry.

Nor is it held in one way. For some the bead is decoration and nothing more. For others it is a serious precaution taken on behalf of a child. Some devout Muslims regard amulets as improper and rely on prayer instead. All of these people live in the same street.

Envy Is Not Superstition

Set the glass aside and look at what the belief has noticed.

Other people's feelings about your good fortune are a real force in your life. Not a supernatural one — a social one. A promotion changes how

colleagues speak to you. Money changes families. Visible success buys attention that is not all warm.

We know this so well that we manage it constantly. We play down good news in front of a friend who has had a bad year. We wait before announcing a pregnancy. We call a new job "nothing special, really." We do not think of this as protection against the eye. It is exactly that.

The bead does something else, quietly. It gives the admirer somewhere to put their own feeling. With the protection already in place, a visitor can praise the baby freely without being suspected, and without suspecting themselves.

It manages a difficulty on both sides of a compliment.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of something good that happened to you recently and ask who you told, and who you did not.

There was probably at least one person you decided not to tell yet.

Was that kindness towards them, or protection for yourself — and would you be willing to say which?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **The feared gaze is usually an admiring one.** The belief concerns envy that its owner may not even recognize, not deliberate malice.
2. **Protection follows visibility.** The bead is placed on whatever is newest, healthiest or most likely to be praised.
3. **The custom manages the admirer too.** A protective object, or a protective word, lets people praise good fortune without awkwardness.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

envy *(n.)* the uncomfortable feeling caused by someone else's good fortune

The belief takes envy seriously as a force between neighbours.

amulet *(n.)* a small object worn or carried for protection

Some people consider an amulet improper and rely on prayer instead.

gaze *(n.)* a long or steady look

The whole custom is built around the power of another person's gaze.

conspicuous *(adj.)* easily noticed; standing out

A new car is conspicuous, which is precisely the problem.

misfortune *(n.)* bad luck, or an unlucky event

The bead is meant to absorb misfortune before it reaches the child.

to ward off *(phrasal verb)* to keep something harmful away

The glass eye is hung above the door to ward off harm.

to play down *(phrasal verb)* to make something seem less important than it is

We play down good news in front of people who are struggling.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Treating this only as a clever social insight is a way of not taking it seriously. Many people mean it literally: a child's illness is explained by a particular visitor, and that explanation can fall on a real neighbour and damage a relationship permanently. The belief has teeth. It is also not one system — what the eye is, who can cast it and what undoes it vary by country, community and generation. And the object has become an export, sold as decoration to people who like the colour. That is not a corruption of the custom, but it is not the custom either.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

envy — conspicuous — to play down

DISCUSS

Is envy something we should hide from other people, or admit to them? What happens in a friendship when it is admitted?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you chose not to share good news.

Alasitas

BOLIVIA

When a Wish Takes Up Space

On the stall in front of you, everything is the wrong size.

There is a house you could hold in one hand, with windows and a doorstep. Next to it, a truck. Beside the truck, bundles of banknotes no longer than a finger. A suitcase. A passport. A university certificate with a seal on it, small enough to fit in a pocket. Sacks of cement. Tiny tools laid out in rows.

People move along the stalls, picking things up, putting them down, choosing.

This is **Alasitas**, the fair of miniatures, which opens in La Paz in late January and fills streets and squares for weeks. The name comes from Aymara and means, roughly, *buy me*.

The Figure and the Blessing

At the centre of it stands **Ekeko**, a small, broad, smiling household figure of abundance, hung all over with miniature goods so that you can barely see him under them. He is an Aymara figure, and in many homes he keeps a shelf and is given a cigarette.

What you buy at the fair is normally taken to be blessed.

That can happen twice in one afternoon. A *yatiri*, an Aymara ritual specialist, may bless the miniatures with smoke and offerings; people also line up outside churches to have them blessed by a priest. Andean and Catholic practice stand side by side here, and most people at the fair see nothing strange in that.

The miniatures are bought, and very often given away — bought for somebody else, and received from somebody else.

You Have to Choose One

Here is the part that repays attention.

A wish, in the head, does not have to decide anything. It can be *things going better*. It can be *more money*, with no figure attached. It can stay vague for years, because nothing ever asks it to be specific.

A stall asks.

You cannot buy an unclear miniature. There is a house and there is a truck, and they cost money you have counted, and you must pick one out and carry it home. The moment you do, the wish has edges. It has a shape, a price, and a location on a shelf.

A vague wish costs nothing and commits you to nothing.

That is why it is so easy to put off.

The miniature also puts the wish where other people can see it. Somebody visits the house and sees a small van on the shelf, and now the plan to buy a van exists outside your own head. It has been

declared, in an object, in front of witnesses who did not have to be told anything directly.

And there is a clock in it. The fair comes round again next January. The miniature will still be there, on the shelf, a year older, and so will you.

Note what is being asked for, too. Houses. Vehicles. Qualifications. Passports and travel documents. These are not fantasies of luxury. They are, mostly, the ordinary apparatus of a secure life, wanted by people who do not yet have it.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of something you want that you have never said out loud in a full sentence.

Now put a price on it, and a date, and say who would need to know.

Does your wish survive being made specific — or does part of its appeal depend on never being tested?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **An object forces a wish to become specific.** You cannot buy a miniature of "things going better"; you have to choose the house or the truck.
2. **A visible wish is a declared one.** Something on a shelf tells other people what you intend without you having to announce it.
3. **What people ask for is usually ordinary.** The miniatures are houses, vehicles and documents — the equipment of a stable life.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

miniature *(n.)* a very small copy of something larger

Each miniature is bought, blessed and carried home.

abundance *(n.)* a large quantity of something, especially of what people need

Ekeko is a figure associated with abundance and household plenty.

vague *(adj.)* not clearly expressed or defined

A vague wish is comfortable precisely because nothing can test it.

stall *(n.)* a table or small stand from which goods are sold

The stalls are covered in tiny houses, trucks and certificates.

intention *(n.)* what a person plans or means to do

The object turns a private hope into a stated intention.

to pick out *(phrasal verb)* to choose one thing from several

You have to pick out one miniature and pay for it.

to put off *(phrasal verb)* to delay doing something

A wish with no shape is easy to put off for years.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is not a motivational technique, and describing it as one strips out everything that makes it what it is. Alasitas is a religious fair with Aymara roots and a Catholic dimension, involving a deity, specialists and blessings that people take seriously; the miniature is not a private psychological tool. Nor does buying a small house produce a house. Much of what is wished for at the fair is out of reach for economic reasons that no ritual addresses, and pretending otherwise is a way of not looking at that. The fair also varies — between families, between Aymara devotion and city habit, and between people who come to pray and people who come for the crowds.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

vague — intention — to put off

DISCUSS

Does saying a goal out loud make it more likely to happen, or only more embarrassing to abandon?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe something you wanted for a long time before you did anything about it.

Tihar's Crow Day

NEPAL

> *The Guest Nobody Invited*

Early, before the household has eaten, somebody goes up to the roof with a plate.

It is not much: cooked rice, a little of what has been prepared, sometimes set out on a leaf. It is left on the roof, or on a ledge, or by the doorway, where it can be seen from the air.

Then the person goes back down.

The crows come, as crows do — noisily, cautiously, one first and then several.

This is **Kag Tihar**, the day of the crow.

Where the Day Sits

It is the first day of **Tihar**, a Hindu festival kept over five days in Nepal in the autumn, and known among Newars as Swanti. It is a major festival, not a curiosity: houses are cleaned, lamps are lit, groups go from door to door singing.

Each day has its own observances. The crow is honoured on the first. On the second, **Kukur Tihar**, dogs are given a marigold garland, a tika on the forehead and good food. On the third, cows are honoured in the

morning, and in the evening comes **Laxmi Puja**, the worship of the goddess of wealth, when houses are lit for her arrival. The fourth differs between communities — oxen are honoured, and among Newars it is **Mha Puja**, a worship of the self, falling at their new year. The fifth is **Bhai Tika**, when sisters mark their brothers' foreheads and pray for their long life.

So the crow opens a sequence that ends with a family in a room.

Why the Crow

The crow is not the dog.

Nobody owns it. It gives nothing back. It takes food from garbage cans and fields and is chased off doorsteps for the rest of the year. And it carries something heavier: the crow is widely regarded as a messenger of **Yama**, the god of death, and its call at your house has long been associated with bad news.

That is the creature fed first, before anything else in the festival.

Look at what that involves. You are not rewarding an animal that serves you. You are not honouring a pet. You are setting out food for the thing whose voice you would rather not hear.

The bearer of bad news is given breakfast.

One Way to Read the Sequence

Consider the order across the five days.

A wild bird at the edge of the roof. Then the dog, which lives with people but is not family. Then the cow, then the household's own animals or the self. Then, at the end, a brother sitting still while his sister marks his forehead.

The circle narrows inwards. Something that is not yours at all, then something that depends on you, then someone who belongs to you.

That is a reading, not a doctrine, and worshippers would explain the days in their own terms. But the shape is there. The festival does not begin with the family. It begins outside, with what was never invited.

THE HUMAN LENS

Most of us are generous towards what is close and useful. The circle stops somewhere — usually just past the people who can return the favour.

Think about what lives at the edge of your own life. The neighbour you do not speak to. The relative who only brings difficult news. The animals on your street you notice only when they are a nuisance.

What arrives uninvited in your life, and can you receive it without immediately trying to drive it away?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **The first day honours the least loved animal.** The crow is a scavenger and a messenger of death, and it is fed before anyone else.
2. **Obligation is not the same as affection.** Setting out food does not require liking the creature that eats it.
3. **The five days move from the edge inwards.** Wild bird, dog, cow, household, and finally the family sitting together.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

scavenger *(n.)* an animal that feeds on waste or on what others leave behind

The crow is a scavenger, and that is part of why it is disliked.

threshold *(n.)* the doorway or entrance to a building

Food is left on rooftops and near the threshold.

offering *(n.)* something given as part of a religious act

The plate of rice is an offering, not a snack for a bird.

messenger *(n.)* someone or something that carries news

The crow is regarded as a messenger of the god of death.

observance *(n.)* the practice of keeping a religious custom

Each day of the festival has its own observance.

to set out *(phrasal verb)* to place things ready for a purpose

Somebody sets out the food before the household eats.

to drive away *(phrasal verb)* to force a person or animal to leave

For most of the year the same birds are driven away from the door.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is worship, not an animal-welfare gesture or a nature appreciation day, and reading it as a lesson in tolerance imports a frame from somewhere else. The crow is fed because of its place in a religious understanding of death and duty, and honouring an animal on one day implies nothing about how it is treated on the other days, or about anyone's views on animals generally. Practice varies too: Newar observance differs from others, the fourth day is not kept the same way everywhere, and Tihar is observed by Nepali communities well beyond Nepal, in India and across the diaspora.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

offering — observance — to set out

DISCUSS

Is it possible to have a genuine obligation towards something you do not like? Where do your own obligations stop?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you had to help someone you did not particularly want to help.

New Year's Effigies

ECUADOR

The Year Has a Body

For the last week of December, there is a man sitting outside the house.

He is on a plastic chair by the door, or propped against the wall, or tied to the front of a car. He wears somebody's old trousers and a shirt nobody wanted any more. His body is newspaper and sawdust. His face is a mask.

Children walk past him every day. He is part of the street.

He is the **año viejo** — the old year — and on the last night of December he will be burned.

Making the Old Year

The figures are called **monigotes**, and before New Year they are everywhere in Ecuador: sold along roadsides, made at home from clothes nobody will miss, built by whole neighbourhoods in Guayaquil at a size that takes several people to move.

Many are not "the year" in general. They are somebody in particular.

Politicians. Officials. Footballers, singers, cartoon characters, whoever has filled the news. A good monigote is a caricature — recognizable,

unflattering, understood by the whole street without a word of explanation.

In many places a **testamento** is read aloud before the burning: a mock will in which the old year looks back on itself, confesses its failures and leaves its faults to named people, usually to laughter. In some neighbourhoods there are also the **viudas**, the widows of the old year — men dressed in black, mourning extravagantly, stopping cars to ask for coins.

Then midnight, and the streets fill with fire and firecrackers, and the figure that sat by the door all week burns down to nothing.

Why It Has to Be a Thing

A year is not an object. That is the problem with it.

You cannot put a year down. You cannot hand it back. Whatever happened in it stays available to you at three in the morning, in no particular order, for as long as you keep it.

So the year is given a body.

It is built from your own possessions — trousers you wore, a shirt from a real cupboard. It is given a face. It sits in the street for days, being looked at. By the time it burns, it is a thing, and things can be destroyed.

You cannot end what has no edges.

That is the work being done here, in public, at an agreed hour, with the whole street doing the same. Not privately deciding to move on. Standing outside at midnight while it burns.

Laughing at the Untouchable

The satire is not decoration.

For one night a figure who cannot ordinarily be reached — a minister, a president, a man whose decisions ran through everybody's year — stands in a residential street in a paper face while ordinary people read out his failures as a joke and set fire to him.

He is not harmed. He may not even hear about it. That is the point: this is speech, not violence, licensed by the calendar.

It is very hard to be frightened of something you have just watched burn while everyone laughed.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about what you still carry from the last year or two. Not the large griefs — the residue. The argument, the job, the version of yourself you did not like.

Most of it has no shape. It cannot be put down, because there is nothing to put down.

What would you have to build, out of your own clothes and your own past, before you could get rid of it?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Endings need objects.** A year cannot be finished, but a figure made of newspaper and old trousers can.
2. **Public destruction differs from private resolution.** The whole street burns its year at the same hour, watching each other do it.
3. **Mockery is a form of power.** Burning a caricature of someone untouchable is speech, and it changes how frightening they feel.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

effigy *(n.)* a model of a person, often made in order to be destroyed
The effigy sits outside the house for days before it burns.

caricature *(n.)* an exaggerated picture or model that mocks someone
A good monigote is a caricature the whole street recognizes.

satirical *(adj.)* using humour to criticize people in power
The reading of the will is satirical, and often aimed at politicians.

grievance *(n.)* a complaint about something considered unfair
The old year's grievances are read out loud before it is burned.

residue *(n.)* what remains after most of something is gone
The residue of a bad year is harder to name than its disasters.

to get rid of *(phrasal verb)* to remove or dispose of something unwanted
The figure exists so that people have something to get rid of.

to look back on *(phrasal verb)* to think about something in the past

Reading the will is one way of looking back on twelve months.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Effigy-burning is not automatically harmless, and it would be dishonest to present it as pure carnival. Elsewhere the same act has been used to threaten real people, and even in Ecuador there are arguments about figures that cross from mockery into intimidation. There are physical costs too: street fires and firecrackers cause burns every year, and city authorities regulate where figures may be burned. The custom is not uniquely Ecuadorian — versions are kept in Colombia, Peru, Mexico and elsewhere — and it varies by city and household. And a fire ends nothing by itself. Nothing about a burning year prevents the next one from beginning badly.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

effigy — grievance — to get rid of

DISCUSS

Is there a real difference between privately deciding to move on and doing something visible in front of others?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe something you had to end before you could begin something else.

Mɑ̃r{i-or
ROMANIA

A Promise You Pin to Your Coat

Somebody hands it to you on the first morning of March and, because your hands are full, pins it on for you.

It is small. Two threads, one red and one white, twisted together, with something hanging from them — a flower, a horseshoe, a chimney sweep, a bead. It goes on the coat, high on the chest, or is knotted round the wrist.

Then you go to work wearing it, in cold weather, in a city where everyone else is wearing one too.

It is the **mŏr i or**, from *martie*, March. The word is a diminutive: little March.

The Thing About the Chest

Notice where it goes.

Not in a pocket. Not on a shelf at home. On the outside of your coat, at the height of the collarbone, where you cannot see it and everybody who speaks to you can.

That placing does something particular. All day — in line, on the tram, in every conversation — the first thing another person registers about you is that somebody thought of you this morning.

They also see who did not receive one, which is part of it, and not a small part.

People will tell you the red and white stand for winter and spring, cold and warmth, snow and blood. The explanations vary by region and by grandmother, and none is official. What is constant is the pairing: two colours twisted, not one. Something ending held against something beginning.

A Promise With an End Date

Here is what makes this object unusual.

Most things we give to mark affection are meant to last. A ring, a watch, a photograph, a book with a name inside it. We give permanence because permanence is what we would like to promise.

The mărțișor is not like that. It is worn for the early days of March, or for the whole month, depending on where you are and whose family you belong to, and then it comes off. In many places it is tied to the branch of a fruit tree and left there.

The end is agreed in advance.

It is a promise that does not ask to be kept forever.

That is a strange kind of freedom. Nobody has to display it in June to prove they still care. The thing is given, worn in public, and then released — and none of that is a failure.

We are much better at beginning things than at agreeing when they will stop.

Hope You Can Feel Through a Coat

Consider what is being celebrated.

It is the first of March. Nothing has happened yet. The trees are bare, the ground is hard, and in much of the country it may still snow for weeks. Spring is not present. It is merely due.

So people pin a small bright object to their clothes and go out into the cold wearing an announcement about a season that has not arrived.

The hope is not a thought about the future. It is an object with a weight, tugging slightly at the fabric, that other people can see from across a room.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think of a hope you are carrying at the moment. Something you want that has not happened yet.

It probably lives in your head, where only you know about it.

If you had to wear that hope where everyone could see it, would you still be willing to carry it?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **It is worn where others can see it.** The object is not a keepsake but a public sign that somebody thought of you.
2. **Some promises are better for being temporary.** The end is agreed in advance, so taking it off costs nothing.
3. **Hope can be given a physical form.** People announce a season before it arrives by pinning it to their coats.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

token *(n.)* a small object given as a sign of feeling or intention
The token is pinned on and worn openly all month.

charm *(n.)* a small ornament attached to a cord or bracelet
A horseshoe or some other charm hangs from the twisted thread.

lapel *(n.)* the folded part at the front of a coat or jacket
Half the people on the tram have something red and white on the lapel.

temporary *(adj.)* lasting only for a limited time
It is a temporary object, and everybody knows it from the start.

anticipation *(n.)* the feeling of waiting for something expected
The custom is entirely about anticipation, since spring has not begun.

to hand out *(phrasal verb)* to give things to a number of people
Teachers hand them out to a whole class on the first morning.

to take off *(phrasal verb)* to remove something you are wearing
Nobody is embarrassed to take it off when the month is over.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is not a romantic occasion, and reading it as one gets it badly wrong: they are handed out between colleagues, to teachers, to grandmothers, by children to each other, and almost none of it is courtship. It is, however, strongly gendered in current practice — given largely to women and girls — and not everyone is comfortable with that. There is commercial pressure too: mass-produced trinkets and obligation gifts. And the colour symbolism is folk explanation rather than a fixed code, so nobody should be told what red and white "mean". Nor is it only Romanian: it belongs to a wider family of customs, and its close relative is the subject of the next chapter.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

token — anticipation — to take off

DISCUSS

Are the promises we make easier to keep when everyone can see them, or harder?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a small gift that mattered more than its value.

Martenitsa
BULGARIA

Waiting for Permission to Take It Off

By the middle of March, the red and white thread on your wrist has gone grey at the edges.

You have worn it through rain and through sleeves. It is grubby, slightly frayed, and you are not allowed to remove it.

Not until you see something.

So you have begun to look up. At rooftops, at utility poles, at the bare branches along the road. You are looking out for a stork, a swallow, or the first blossom on a tree — and until one appears, the thread stays where it is.

Baba Marta

It arrives on the first of March. **Martenitsa**: red and white yarn, tied at the wrist or pinned to a coat, often as two small woollen dolls — **Pizho**, the white one, and **Penda**, the red — given between family, friends and colleagues with wishes for health.

The month belongs to **Baba Marta**, Grandmother March, whose temper is held to explain the weather. She is pleased and the sun comes out; she is annoyed and it snows by lunchtime. March behaves like that, and the figure fits it.

Readers of the last chapter will recognize the object. The Romanian mărțișor is its close relative; the two belong to a shared regional custom that Bulgaria, Romania, Moldova and North Macedonia had inscribed together on UNESCO's list of intangible cultural heritage in 2017. Kin, not copies: each has its own name, figures and rules.

What makes the Bulgarian version distinct is the ending.

The World Decides When

Most things we wear come off when we choose. This one does not.

The martenitsa is worn until a sign of spring is seen — commonly a stork or a swallow, in some places a tree in blossom. Then it comes off, and it is not thrown away. It is tied to a blossoming branch, or in some regions placed under a stone.

Notice what that does to the wearer.

For two weeks or more, an ordinary person walking to work is scanning the sky. Not out of interest in birds. Because they want the thing off their wrist, and only a bird can allow it.

The custom does not tell you to appreciate spring. It gives you a reason to look for it.

Those are very different instructions, and only one of them works.

And the whole street is doing it, watching the same rooftops — which is why the news that somebody has seen a stork travels so fast.

Why Not Just Use a Date

The calendar could settle this easily. Pick a date at the end of the month, and everybody removes the thread together.

But a date is the same date whether the snow has stopped or not. Some years the trees are early; some years spring holds off for weeks. A calendar cannot know, and it does not look.

So the ending is handed to something outside human control. You cannot arrange to see the first stork, or bring it forward because you are tired of waiting.

When it comes, it comes as news rather than as a scheduled event — and the token goes onto the tree that told you.

THE HUMAN LENS

Most of us carry something we have not been able to put down. A worry, a grudge, a role in the family, a period of life that is technically over.

We say we are waiting for the right moment. Sometimes that is honest. Often it means we are waiting for someone else to release us, because releasing ourselves feels presumptuous.

What are you waiting for permission to put down — and is the permission you want ever actually going to arrive?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **The ending is given away.** The wearer cannot decide when to remove the thread; a stork, a swallow or a blossom decides it.
2. **A task makes people notice.** Nobody must be told to admire spring while they are searching the rooftops for it.
3. **Signs are not the same as dates.** A calendar can be wrong about the weather; a blossoming tree cannot.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

yarn *(n.)* thread made of twisted fibres
The bracelet is nothing but red and white yarn.

blossom *(n.)* the flowers on a fruit tree
For some, the first blossom rather than a bird ends the wearing.

vigilant *(adj.)* carefully watchful
Half the city turns vigilant about rooftops for two weeks.

arbitrary *(adj.)* decided by chance or preference rather than by reason
A fixed date feels arbitrary when the snow is still falling.

release *(v.)* to allow something or someone to go free
Only the sign can release you from the thread.

to look out for *(phrasal verb)* to watch carefully in order to notice something
People look out for storks on the way to work.

to hold off *(phrasal verb)* to delay or stay away

Spring can hold off for weeks, and the wearing continues.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is a folk custom with a named figure and regional rules, not a philosophy of patience, and turning it into one flatters the reader at the tradition's expense. The rules vary: the required sign differs from place to place, plenty of people simply stop at the end of March, and in a city where storks are not seen the ending is settled by convention. Be careful with the regional relationship, too. Each community has its own name, form and account of the custom, and the joint inscription says they are related, not identical. And waiting for a sign is a poor rule for serious decisions, most of which arrive without one.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

vigilant — arbitrary — to look out for

DISCUSS

Is it easier to end something when an outside event marks the ending?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe something you delayed until the moment felt right.

PART VII

How We Celebrate

CUSTOMS 43–49

Why do societies periodically abandon restraint?

43 Carnival *Brazil*

44 Money Spraying *Nigeria*

45 Bull-Jumping *Ethiopia*

46 Dragon Boat Festival *Taiwan*

47 Sing-Sing *Papua New Guinea*

48 Holi *India*

49 First-Footing *Scotland*

Carnival

BRAZIL

> *When a Society Agrees to Let Go*

A drum starts.

Then another, then two hundred, all struck on the same beat, and the sound arrives in your chest before it reaches your ears.

This is the *bateria*, the drum section of a samba school. In front of it, several thousand people in matching costume are waiting to move.

Most of them have been preparing for a year.

Carnival looks like abandon. It is built on rehearsal.

Carnival is the season before Lent, and in Brazil it is not one event but many. In Rio de Janeiro, samba schools parade through a purpose-built avenue of grandstands. In Salvador, crowds walk for hours behind trucks carrying bands. In Recife and Olinda, the music is frevo and maracatu, and giant puppets move above the heads of the crowd.

And almost everywhere there are *blocos*: street bands that anybody can follow, for nothing, in whatever they happen to be wearing.

A Competition Dressed as a Party

The Rio parade is a contest.

Each school presents a theme and a song written for that theme. Judges score the drumming, the costumes, the floats, the dancing, the crowd's response. There are time limits. There are penalties.

Schools are promoted and relegated between divisions, like soccer clubs. Results are announced on Ash Wednesday, and they are argued about for months.

So the loudest celebration on earth is also an examination — one that neighbourhoods spend the year, and considerable money, preparing to sit.

What the Costumes Were Built On

Samba was formed in Afro-Brazilian communities, by the descendants of enslaved people, drawing on musical and religious traditions carried from Africa and developed in Bahia and Rio.

For a period in the early twentieth century, those gatherings were treated by the authorities as a public problem, and were policed as such. The same music was later adopted as a symbol of the nation.

That history sits underneath the feathers, and it is worth holding on to. What a country celebrates now is not always what it permitted before.

The Scheduled Release

Why do societies do this at all — set aside days when the usual rules loosen?

Perhaps because rules cost something to keep. Every ordinary week asks you to be punctual, restrained, useful and quiet. That is a debt, and it accumulates.

Carnival is one way of settling it in public, together, on a date everyone knows in advance.

There is a second thing happening as well. For a few days the ordinary order of the city is turned around. People appear as somebody else — masked, costumed, crowned, dressed above or below their station — and a bank clerk can spend a night as a king in feathers while a stranger beside them plays the fool.

You cannot do that alone in a room. It only works if everyone agrees to it at the same time.

Notice that last part. The release is scheduled. It has a start, a route, a set of judges and an end. Ash Wednesday arrives, the streets are swept, and the ordinary week resumes.

A society that never lets go has to hold on all year.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how you release pressure.

Some people have nothing but small leaks — a late night, an argument, a week of bad sleep. Others have something planned and shared, a date in the calendar when they are allowed to stop performing.

The second kind is easier to return from.

When did you last let go on purpose, with other people, rather than simply collapsing on your own?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Release is often organized, not accidental.** Carnival is scheduled, rehearsed and judged, which is what allows it to be wild.
2. **Celebration can carry difficult history.** Samba's roots lie in Afro-Brazilian communities whose gatherings were once suppressed by the state.
3. **One name can cover many customs.** Rio, Salvador, Recife and countless street *blocos* celebrate differently, and no single image represents them all.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

restraint *(n.)* control over what you say, feel or do
Ordinary life asks for restraint almost every hour of the day.

abandon *(n.)* behaviour without caution or self-control

The parade looks like pure abandon from the grandstands.

rehearsal *(n.)* practice before a performance

A single minute of the parade may represent months of rehearsal.

suppress *(v.)* to stop something by force or authority

For a time the authorities tried to suppress these gatherings.

descendant *(n.)* someone related to a person who lived long ago

The music was shaped by the descendants of enslaved Africans.

to hold on *(phrasal verb)* to keep control, or to keep something with effort

You cannot hold on tightly every week of the year.

to let go *(phrasal verb)* to stop controlling or restraining something

Communities need occasions when they are permitted to let go.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

It is tempting to describe Carnival as a "safety valve" and stop there. That flattens it. For many people in a samba school, the parade is not an escape from ordinary life but a serious annual project with real costs, real hierarchies and real ambition. Treating it only as release ignores the labour, and ignores the communities who built the tradition under conditions that were anything but festive.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

restraint — rehearsal — to let go

DISCUSS

Does your society have a permitted time to lose control? If not, where does the pressure go instead?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion you helped organize that other people simply enjoyed.

Money Spraying

NIGERIA

Why Generosity Wants an Audience

The couple are dancing.

Someone steps out of the crowd, lifts a hand above their heads, and lets banknotes fall — one at a time, slowly, so that everybody can see them land.

Then somebody else does it. Then four people at once.

The notes settle on shoulders, on hair, on the floor. Children and helpers gather them up into bags for the family.

This is **spraying**, and at parties across Nigeria it is one of the ways a guest says: *I am here, and I am glad for you.*

Spraying appears most famously at weddings, and at the large Yoruba celebrations often called *owambe* parties, but it is not limited to one people or one region. It happens at naming ceremonies, at funerals for those who lived long lives, at anniversaries and album launches.

The money matters. So does the manner.

A gift dropped from the hand in front of two hundred people is doing more than one job.

Two Kinds of Giving

Think about the difference between an anonymous donation and a public one.

The anonymous gift is clean. Nobody can accuse you of showing off. But it also creates nothing between you and anyone else.

The public gift is messier and more useful. It says who supports whom. It tells the room which families are connected. It creates a record — and a record creates obligation.

Because spraying is rarely a single event. The guest who sprays at your wedding will hold their own celebration one day, and you will be there, and you will remember.

Seen that way, the money is not really payment. It is closer to bookkeeping between families.

It is also, unavoidably, competitive. Everybody present can see who gave, how much, and with what confidence. That is part of the pleasure and part of the pressure, and guests who cannot match the room feel it. Generosity performed in public is never entirely free of comparison.

The Law and the Custom

Nigerian law has long treated the naira as something to be protected. Under the Central Bank of Nigeria Act, abuse of the currency — including spraying, dancing on notes and defacing them — is an offence, and in recent years prosecutions have brought that rule to national attention.

This puts a widely loved custom and a written law in direct conflict. Some argue the practice damages the currency and cheapens it. Others argue that the state is legislating against joy, and that the tradition long predates the rule.

The argument is unfinished. Meanwhile, at many parties, people adapt: they hand notes over rather than throw them, or they spray foreign currency, or they carry on much as before.

Customs rarely die because they become illegal. They change shape.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time you gave something generously.

Did anybody see?

We are taught that the purest giving is invisible, and there is something in that. But invisible giving builds nothing between people. It leaves no thread anyone can follow back.

When you give publicly, are you performing your generosity, strengthening a relationship, or both at once — and does the difference matter to the person receiving?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Public generosity does social work.** Visible giving records relationships and creates future obligation in a way private giving cannot.
2. **Reciprocity is the engine.** Today's guest is tomorrow's host, and the giving circulates rather than simply flowing outwards.
3. **Law and custom can pull in opposite directions.** Spraying is beloved and, under Nigerian currency law, an offence — a tension still being worked out.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

generosity *(n.)* willingness to give money, help or time freely
The custom turns generosity into something the whole room can see.

obligation *(n.)* a duty to do something in return
A public gift quietly creates an obligation for the future.

reciprocity *(n.)* the exchange of favours or gifts between people
Reciprocity is what keeps the money moving from party to party.

deface *(v.)* to damage the appearance of something
The law treats it as an offence to deface banknotes.

anonymous *(adj.)* done without the giver's name being known
An anonymous gift protects the giver from any accusation of display.

to gather up *(phrasal verb)* to collect scattered things together
Helpers gather up the notes and hand them to the family.

to show off *(phrasal verb)* to display something in order to impress others

There is a thin line between honouring your hosts and showing off.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Spraying is not simply "tipping" or "gifting cash", and reading it that way will mislead you. It sits inside long-standing systems of family obligation, status and mutual support that a visitor cannot see from the dance floor. Nigeria is a country of many peoples and practices, and how, when and whether one sprays differs by region, faith, generation and family. Whether it is joyful, competitive or wasteful is an argument Nigerians conduct among themselves.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

generosity — obligation — to show off

DISCUSS

Is generosity less valuable when other people are watching? Who decides?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you helped someone and the help was seen by others.

Bull-Jumping

ETHIOPIA

> *What a Community Requires Before It Says "Adult"*

A line of cattle stands side by side, held steady by men gripping horns and tails.

A young man, stripped bare, steps up onto the back of the first animal.

Then he runs.

Across the line, down the other side, turn, and back again — usually four crossings in all, on hide that shifts under every step.

Among the Hamar people of the South Omo Zone of south-western Ethiopia, this is *ukuli bula*, the bull-jumping. It is not a display for spectators. It is the ceremony through which a young man passes out of boyhood and becomes eligible to marry, to hold cattle, to run a household of his own.

Until he jumps, he is a boy, whatever his age.

After he jumps, he is not.

The Ceremony Around the Jump

The jump takes a few minutes. The occasion takes days.

Relatives and neighbours travel in. There is feasting, sorghum beer, dancing and long negotiation about timing. The ceremony is conducted by the *maza* — men who have already jumped and have not yet moved into the next stage of life.

It also includes something that visitors find hard to look at, and which should be reported plainly rather than hidden or sensationalized.

Before the jump, female relatives of the young man — sisters and kinswomen — approach the *maza* and ask to be whipped with thin switches. They ask repeatedly, and insistently. The whipping cuts, and the scars remain for life.

Within Hamar understanding, the women are not victims of the ceremony. They are demonstrating their commitment to their kinsman in a way the whole community can see, and the scars they carry constitute a lasting claim on him: an obligation he owes them in years of need.

That is what has been documented. What the ceremony feels like from inside a Hamar family — how women themselves weigh it, how opinion differs between households and generations — is not something an outsider can report, and this chapter does not pretend to.

A Rite Under Outside Attention

The Omo valley has drawn foreign visitors, photographers and film crews for decades. Payment for photographs has become part of the economy of the region, and the presence of paying outsiders has affected how some ceremonies are arranged and attended.

Meanwhile Hamar life has been reshaped by pressures that have nothing to do with ritual: land taken for large-scale agriculture, changes to the river the region depends on, schooling, markets and government policy.

The rite is not frozen. It is being practised by people living through significant change.

Why Have a Threshold at All?

Many societies have quietly stopped marking adulthood. There is a legal age, and there is a slow accumulation of milestones — a job, a rent payment, a first serious illness handled alone.

The Hamar version is different in one respect. It is public, it is dated, and it is witnessed.

Everyone in the room knows what you have become.

THE HUMAN LENS

Ask yourself when you became an adult.

Most people cannot answer with a date. They offer a rough period, or an event nobody else noticed, or an admission that they are not certain it has happened.

Ceremony removes that uncertainty. It also removes the choice: the community decides what the standard is, and you meet it in front of them.

Would you rather your adulthood had been declared by others on a single day, or arrived quietly, on your own terms, with nobody to confirm it?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Adulthood can be granted rather than assumed.** Among the Hamar, status changes on a specific day, in public, before witnesses.
2. **Initiation involves the whole family, not only the initiate.** Female relatives take a demanding and lasting part in the ceremony.
3. **Living rites change under outside pressure.** Tourism, payment for photographs and wider changes in the Omo valley all bear on the practice.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

initiation *(n.)* a ceremony that admits someone to a new status or group

The jump is an initiation, not a competition.

threshold *(n.)* a point marking the beginning of something new

Some societies mark the threshold into adulthood; others let it blur.

kinswoman *(n.)* a female relative

Each kinswoman who takes part is making a claim she can call on later.

eligible *(adj.)* allowed or qualified to do something

Only after the ceremony is a young man eligible to marry.

witness *(v.)* to see something happen and be able to confirm it

The community witnesses the change, so nobody can dispute it.

to pass out of *(phrasal verb)* to leave one stage or condition

He passes out of boyhood in the space of a few minutes.

to take part in *(phrasal verb)* to join in an activity with others

Relatives travel long distances to take part in the days of ceremony.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

This is not a metaphor for graduating or turning eighteen, and it should not be borrowed as one. It belongs to a specific people, with its own law of kinship and obligation, in a region under real economic and political pressure. An outsider reading a description — including this one — sees the outline and not the meaning.

Much of what the ceremony does is only legible to people who will live with its consequences for the next forty years.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

initiation — threshold — to take part in

DISCUSS

What, in your society, actually marks the end of childhood? Who decides, and does anybody witness it?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a moment when other people first treated you as an adult.

Dragon Boat Festival
TAIWAN

Why We Race What We Remember

Twenty paddles hang above the water, motionless.

At the front of the long boat a drummer kneels, facing the crew. At the very front, leaning out over the river, someone is stretched forward with one arm ready — because at the end of this lane there is a flag, and their job is to snatch it.

The drum begins.

Twenty blades hit the water on the same beat, and for two minutes nobody in the boat thinks about anything else.

This is the Dragon Boat Festival — *Duanwu* — held on the fifth day of the fifth lunar month. In Taiwan it is a public holiday, and it is marked across the Chinese-speaking world: in China, Hong Kong, Macau, Singapore, Malaysia and in diaspora communities far beyond them.

The races are the loud part. They are not the whole thing.

Rice, Leaves and a Drowned Poet

The story most often told concerns Qu Yuan, a minister and poet of the ancient state of Chu, who was exiled after giving advice his ruler would not hear, and who drowned himself in the Miluo River.

By tradition, local people rowed out to search for him and threw rice into the water so that the fish would eat that instead of his body.

From this come the two halves of the festival: the boats, and *zongzi* — glutinous rice wrapped in leaves, tied, and steamed or boiled. Fillings vary by household and by region; in Taiwan the northern and southern methods are different enough to argue about, and people do.

Historians point out that the festival almost certainly predates Qu Yuan, and absorbed older midsummer customs concerned with protection from illness. Mugwort and calamus are hung at doorways. Children wear fragrant sachets. At noon, someone always tries to stand an egg on its end.

A festival is rarely one story. It is several, folded together and given a single date.

The Contest Inside the Custom

Why do so many traditions end in a competition?

Because a race demands something a commemoration does not.

You cannot half-remember a poet. You can, however, half-attend a ceremony — arrive late, stand at the back, leave early, and mean no harm by any of it.

But a crew of twenty training through the spring is committed in a way no audience is. There is a boat to fill, a stroke rate to hold, a rival team

from the next company or the next village, and a flag that only one hand can reach first.

Competition creates the obligation to turn up.

That is the useful part. There is also a cost. When the trophy grows large enough, the poet gets smaller. Dragon boating is now an international sport with clubs and regattas in dozens of countries, most of whose members would not call themselves participants in Duanwu at all.

The custom carries the sport. The sport carries the custom.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about how you keep anything alive — a friendship, a language, a skill.

Sentiment alone is not reliable. It fades on wet Tuesdays.

What survives tends to have a structure attached: a fixture, a team, a season, someone waiting for you who will notice if you fail to arrive.

What is one thing you claim to value that has no fixed date in your calendar — and what would change if it did?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Competition makes remembrance repeatable.** A race supplies the effort and attendance that commemoration alone rarely commands.
2. **Festivals accumulate meanings.** Duanwu combines a story of loyalty, midsummer protective customs and a shared food.
3. **Popularity can loosen a custom from its origin.** As dragon boating becomes an international sport, the race travels further than the memory it began with.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

commemorate *(v.)* to honour the memory of a person or event
The festival commemorates a minister who drowned in the Miluo River.

exile *(v.)* to force someone to leave their home or country
Qu Yuan was exiled after giving advice his ruler refused to hear.

crew *(n.)* a group of people who operate a boat together
A crew has to train together for months before the drum makes sense.

rival *(n.)* a person or team competing against another
Half the pleasure is knowing which rival is in the next lane.

obligation *(n.)* something you feel you must do
A team creates an obligation that private good intentions do not.

to turn up *(phrasal verb)* to arrive, especially where you are expected
Twenty people have to turn up on the same morning, every year.

to hand down *(phrasal verb)* to pass something to a later generation

The recipes for the rice parcels are handed down within families.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

It is easy to read Duanwu as a general lesson about motivation and competition. That is a borrowing, not a translation. For many families the festival is primarily a food day and a day of protective customs, with no race involved at all; for temple and village teams, the boats carry religious and community meaning that a corporate regatta does not reproduce. The story of Qu Yuan also belongs to a specific political culture in which loyal remonstrance and exile mean something particular. A sports club paddling on a canal has the boat, not the festival.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

commemorate — rival — to turn up

DISCUSS

Does adding competition strengthen a tradition or slowly replace it?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time being part of a team made you do something you would not have done alone.

Sing-Sing

PAPUA NEW GUINEA

When Identity Is Something You Put On

It takes hours to get ready.

Pigment is mixed and applied to faces in patterns that were not invented this morning. Feathers are unwrapped from cloth and bark where they have been stored, sometimes for generations. Shells, tusks, woven bands, leaves and grasses are fastened, checked, adjusted.

Then the drums start — hand-held, hourglass-shaped — and a group of perhaps forty people begins to move as a single body, singing in a language that the group standing thirty metres away may not speak at all.

That is the detail to hold on to.

Papua New Guinea has over eight hundred languages, and hundreds of distinct cultural groups with their own histories, designs, songs and ceremonies.

There is no such thing as "the Papua New Guinean costume".

A *sing-sing* is, in the shared language Tok Pisin, a gathering where people sing and dance. The decoration worn for it is *bilas*. Beyond that shared vocabulary, what is worn, sung and danced belongs to particular clans and communities, and the differences are the point.

Two Different Occasions With One Name

A sing-sing may happen in a village for reasons that concern only the people there: a bride price ceremony, a funeral, an initiation, a feast, a settlement between groups, a church or political occasion, an Independence Day celebration.

Then there are the large cultural shows — the Goroka Show in the Eastern Highlands, the Mount Hagen Show in the Western Highlands, among others — where dozens of groups travel in and perform in turn. These began in the middle of the twentieth century, under Australian administration, partly as a way of bringing groups together peacefully. Today they are judged, ticketed and heavily photographed.

The two are related. They are not the same thing, and it is a mistake to describe the second as though it explains the first.

One is a community doing something for itself. The other is a stage, with an audience, a competition and a national and international profile.

Being Seen Correctly

Why go to all this effort to be looked at?

Because a group that cannot be recognized cannot be dealt with.

When two communities meet — to celebrate, to negotiate, to settle something, to mark a death — each needs to arrive as itself, visibly. The dress announces which clan, which ancestry, which alliances, which

claims. It is closer to a passport, a flag and a family record than to a costume.

And the meanings are not open to everybody. Particular designs, plumes and songs belong to particular groups, and the right to wear or perform them is held, inherited and sometimes restricted. A visitor with a camera sees colour. The people opposite see specific statements, most of which are not addressed to the visitor at all.

You can photograph a sing-sing without understanding a single sentence of it.

THE HUMAN LENS

You perform your identity too — with less feather and more fabric.

A suit. A team shirt. A ring. A haircut that took a decision. Something you wear at home and would never wear at work.

None of it is dishonest. It is how you tell people, before you speak, which group you belong to and how you expect to be treated.

What do you put on when you want to be recognized — and who exactly is meant to read it?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Papua New Guinea is not one culture.** Hundreds of groups, with over eight hundred languages, bring distinct dress, song and dance to a sing-sing.
2. **Display is communication between groups.** Dress announces clan, ancestry and claims in a way that words alone would not settle.
3. **Community occasions and staged festivals differ.** A village sing-sing and a judged, ticketed cultural show serve different purposes and audiences.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

adornment *(n.)* decoration worn on the body

Each group's adornment carries meanings that belong to that group.

distinct *(adj.)* clearly different or separate

Hundreds of distinct communities take part, each with its own songs.

clan *(n.)* a group of families with a shared ancestry

The dress announces which clan a dancer belongs to.

inherit *(v.)* to receive something from an earlier generation

The right to wear certain designs is inherited, not chosen.

staged *(adj.)* organized and presented for an audience

A staged festival is not the same occasion as a village ceremony.

to get ready *(phrasal verb)* to prepare yourself for something

Some groups get ready for hours before they walk out to dance.

to stand out *(phrasal verb)* to be noticeably different from others

The aim is not to blend in but to stand out as unmistakably yourselves.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

The comparison with wearing a uniform or a team shirt only goes so far. Your clothing choices are largely yours; much of what is worn at a sing-sing is not personal expression at all but held property, governed by inheritance, obligation and permission. Nor is a sing-sing a folk performance preserving a past — it is current practice inside communities dealing with land, money, migration and politics now. And this chapter describes only what such communities have themselves made public. The meanings of specific designs are theirs, and are not ours to explain.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

adornment — clan — to stand out

DISCUSS

What do people in your society wear to show which group they belong to? Who is allowed to wear it?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe an occasion when you dressed deliberately to be seen a particular way.

Holi

INDIA

> *Why Do We Need a Day for Beginning Again?*

The night before, there is no colour at all.

There is a fire.

In many parts of India, wood and old timber are stacked at a crossroads for days beforehand. On the eve of Holi, the pile is lit. The bonfire is called **Holika Dahan**, and people gather around it, walk around it, and in many places make offerings into it.

The fire is not scenery. It belongs to a story — Prahlada, a boy devoted to Vishnu, carried into the flames by Holika, and surviving them. Holi opens on the theme of good outlasting evil, and on the oldest symbol we have for change: something goes into a fire and does not come out in the same form.

Then morning comes.

One Festival, Many Festivals

It is tempting to describe Holi as a single national event. It is not.

In the Braj region, associated with Krishna, the celebration can run for days, and towns there are known for their own distinct forms of play. In Bengal it is widely observed as Dol Purnima, with images of Radha

and Krishna carried in procession and placed on swings. In Punjab, Sikhs gather for Hola Mohalla around the same time — a related but separate observance, with its own martial traditions. Elsewhere it may be a single loud afternoon.

The stories differ. The names differ. The length differs.

A tradition can be shared without being identical.

What the Colour Does

Then the powder goes into the air, and the water after it.

Look at how much of what you know about a stranger you read off their surface. The cut of the clothes. What the shoes cost. Age, sometimes occupation, often position.

Cover everyone in red and green and yellow, and for a few hours that surface stops reporting. Wet colour does not respect a uniform. The person laughing beside you may be genuinely unrecognizable, and so are you.

That is the well-known pleasure of Holi, and it is real. It is also worth saying plainly that the licence is not equally safe for everyone. Harassment under cover of the crowd is a documented and much-discussed problem, and some people — women in particular — stay home, or play only among people they trust.

Spring, and the Repair of Things

Holi falls at the full moon of the month of Phalguna, as winter gives way. Fields that were bare start again. It is not hard to see why the human idea attached to that season is the second chance.

In many households the festival is a time to visit, to settle small quarrels, to make up with people you have been avoiding. Not every quarrel — some things should not be smoothed over, and some relationships should not be resumed.

But renewal has never meant pretending that winter did not happen.

It means deciding that the past does not have to decide what comes next.

THE HUMAN LENS

You probably already know which relationship you have been holding on to badly — the one where you are technically in the right and quietly tired of being in the right.

A festival cannot fix it for you. What a day like Holi offers is smaller: a moment when everyone has agreed in advance that the ordinary rules are suspended, so the first move costs less.

If nobody handed you that day, what would you be willing to begin again anyway?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Holi is a religious festival first.** It carries Hindu meaning and story, beginning with the Holika Dahan bonfire and the triumph of good over evil, long before it is a spectacle of colour.
2. **It varies enormously across India.** Regions differ in the stories they tell, the names they use and the number of days they keep.
3. **Renewal is a decision, not an erasure.** The past is not cancelled by a festival; it is simply refused the right to determine everything that follows.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

bonfire *(n.)* a large outdoor fire built for a ceremony or celebration
The bonfire on the eve of Holi is lit in a public space where everyone can gather.

devotion *(n.)* deep religious loyalty or love
The story told at the fire is about a boy whose devotion protected him.

leveller *(n.)* something that removes the differences between people
For a few hours, wet colour acts as a leveller.

grievance *(n.)* a feeling of having been treated unfairly
A festival is a good moment to put down a grievance you have carried too long.

reconciliation *(n.)* the repair of a damaged relationship
Reconciliation is easier when both people have agreed on the day it may happen.

to make up *(phrasal verb)* to become friendly again after an argument

Many families use the festival to make up with relatives they rarely see.

to wash off *(phrasal verb)* to be removed by water

The colour washes off in a day; what people say to each other does not.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

A licensed suspension of the rules only works because everybody knows when it ends. Holi has a fixed place in the calendar, a shared meaning behind it, and a clear return to ordinary life the next morning — which is exactly what makes the freedom bearable. Import the licence without the boundary and you do not get a festival; you get an excuse, which is precisely how harassment has been able to hide inside the crowd. And no festival repairs a relationship on its own. It opens a door on one particular day. Somebody still has to walk through it and say something true.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

leveller — grievance — to make up

DISCUSS

Does your culture set aside a time when the usual rules are relaxed? Who is safest during it, and who is not?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you decided to begin something again.

First-Footing

SCOTLAND

Letting the Year Be Decided at the Door

It is a few minutes past midnight and somebody is standing outside in the cold, waiting to knock.

They are carrying things: a lump of coal, perhaps shortbread or a dark fruit cake, a pinch of salt, a bottle.

Inside, the house is warm and loud and watching the door.

Because in the tradition of *Hogmanay* — the Scottish name for the last night of the year — the first person to cross your threshold after midnight is your **first-foot**, and what they bring in with them is understood to set the tone of the year ahead.

Coal for a fire that does not go out. Food for a table that is not bare. Drink for company. Salt, in older versions, for what salt has always meant: preservation, worth, savour.

One person, one doorway, one moment — and the next twelve months are said to hang on it.

The Part Everybody Argues About

The best-known detail is the preference, in many places, for the first-foot to be a tall, dark-haired man. In some districts a fair-haired or red-haired arrival was thought unlucky, and in some, a woman.

The explanation usually offered is that a fair-haired stranger at a Scottish door once meant a Norse raider.

It is a good story, and it should be labelled as one. Folklorists regard the origin as unproven and probably a later rationalization of a custom whose real beginnings are not recorded. Practice also varied considerably by region and household, and it has loosened a great deal within living memory.

There is also a reason New Year carries so much weight in Scotland. After the Reformation, the celebration of Christmas was long discouraged there; Christmas Day did not become a public holiday in Scotland until the late 1950s. The winter festival that flourished instead was Hogmanay.

Arranged Luck

Here is the honest part.

The chance is very often not left to chance.

A household with a suitable candidate present will send him outside before midnight so that he can come back in afterwards. Neighbours agree in advance who is calling on whom. Someone makes sure the coal is by the door.

So the ritual is not really a lottery. It is a piece of theatre in which a family arranges the omen it wants and then enjoys receiving it.

We do not consult chance in order to be told. We consult it in order to begin.

That may be the whole function. A year does not naturally start; the calendar simply keeps counting. So people install a threshold, a moment, a stranger's knock — something that can be pointed at afterwards and called the beginning.

And once you have decided the year started well, you tend to behave as though it did.

THE HUMAN LENS

You almost certainly do a version of this.

The lucky shirt. The seat you always take. The way you refuse to say a thing out loud in case saying it spoils it. The small sign you look for on a morning that matters.

You may not believe any of it. You do it anyway, and it steadies you.

When you let a small sign decide how you feel about what is coming, are you handing over control — or quietly giving yourself permission to start?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Beginnings have to be made.** Time itself does not divide into years; ritual supplies the threshold that makes a start feel real.
2. **The chance is often arranged.** Households frequently organize their own first-foot, which reveals that the point is the moment, not the prediction.
3. **Folk explanations are not history.** The preference for a tall, dark-haired first-foot is well attested; the Norse-raider account of why is contested and unproven.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

threshold *(n.)* the floor at the entrance to a building; a point of entry
Everything in the custom depends on who crosses the threshold first.

omen *(n.)* a sign believed to indicate future good or bad fortune
The first visitor of the year is treated as an omen for the months ahead.

superstition *(n.)* a belief that certain acts or signs affect fortune
Most people describe it as superstition and observe it carefully anyway.

attested *(adj.)* supported by evidence or records
The preference is well attested; the reason for it is not.

rationalization *(n.)* an explanation invented afterwards to justify something
The raider story may be a later rationalization of a much older habit.

to call on *(phrasal verb)* to visit someone briefly

Neighbours arrange in advance who will call on whom after midnight.

to hand over *(phrasal verb)* to give control or responsibility to someone else

Nobody really hands over the year to a stranger at the door.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Hogmanay is not simply "Scottish New Year's Eve with extra rules". It grew large partly because Christmas was suppressed in Scotland for centuries, and it carries a specific religious and social history that a general point about luck ignores. First-footing is also unevenly observed: strong in some families and communities, faded or ironic in others, and different from region to region. Treating it as a national trait would misdescribe the country.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

threshold — omen — to call on

DISCUSS

Do you have a habit you do not believe in but would not skip? What would it cost you to stop?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you deliberately created a fresh start for yourself.

PART VIII

How We Express Who We Are

CUSTOMS 50–52

What do we owe the people closest to us?

50 Omiyage *Japan*

51 Arranged Marriage *India*

52 Bayram Hand-Kissing *Turkey*

Omiyage

JAPAN

Why We Bring Something Back

Twenty minutes before the train leaves, a traveller is standing in front of a wall of boxes.

The boxes are stacked in a station shop that exists for exactly this purpose. Inside each one is a regional sweet — a cake, a cookie, a confection made in this prefecture and understood to belong to it.

The traveller is not choosing a flavour. They are choosing a number.

Twelve pieces, or eighteen, or twenty-four, because there are that many people in the office, and every piece is separately wrapped so it can be handed round a desk.

This is **omiyage**: the thing you bring back.

Not a Souvenir

In English, a souvenir is a keepsake. It is bought to remind *you* of where you went. It sits on your shelf.

Omiyage is not for the shelf and not for you.

It is usually food, usually eaten within a week, and almost always given to people who did not go anywhere.

The written form of the word uses characters meaning something close to *produce of the land*. One line of explanation traces the custom to pilgrimage: a village would pool money to send a single representative to a distant shrine, and he came home carrying tokens for everyone who had paid his way.

Whether or not that is the whole origin, it describes the shape of the thing exactly.

Someone goes. Everyone else stays. The going has to be accounted for.

Japanese also distinguishes this from *temiyage*, the gift you carry with you when you visit someone's house. That one is for arriving. Omiyage is for coming back.

The Awkward Part

It would be easy to write this as pure thoughtfulness, and it isn't.

Omiyage carries obligation. In many workplaces, coming back from a vacation without a box is noticed, and the count matters — leaving one colleague out is worse than bringing nothing at all.

Younger workers, remote teams and smaller offices have loosened this a great deal, and plenty of people in Japan describe the office version as a chore they would happily be rid of.

But notice what the obligation is actually enforcing.

You went to Hokkaido. Your colleague covered your inbox. Your neighbour took in your mail. Your mother worried on a Tuesday.

The box is not a payment for that. It is smaller and stranger: evidence that while you were somewhere else, they were still in your head.

The gift is not the sweets. The gift is the fact that you were counting.

What Distance Does

Travel is a mild form of disappearance.

You go, and the ordinary machinery of your life runs without you. That is pleasant. It is also a small threat — a life that runs perfectly well without you might not need you back.

Every culture handles this somehow. Postcards. The phone call on landing. A fridge magnet nobody wants.

Omiyage handles it with a rule instead of a mood. It does not wait for you to feel affectionate at the right moment. It builds the return into the trip.

Feelings are unreliable on the fourth day of a vacation. Rules are not.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the last time you came back from somewhere.

Did you bring anything? For whom? And were you thinking of them while you were away, or only in the last hour at the airport?

Now the harder version.

Is a gesture worth less because you were obliged to make it — or does the obligation exist precisely because we cannot be trusted to remember on our own?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Omiyage is given, not kept.** Unlike a souvenir, it is bought for the people who stayed behind and is usually shared and eaten.
2. **The obligation is real, and so is the affection.** Duty and warmth are not opposites here; the rule makes sure the warmth actually arrives.
3. **The practice is changing.** Many workplaces have relaxed it, and plenty of people in Japan regard the office version as a burden.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

keepsake *(n.)* an object kept to remember a person or place

A souvenir is a keepsake; omiyage is closer to a debt repaid.

obligation *(n.)* something you feel you must do because of a social duty

The box of sweets satisfies an obligation as much as it expresses affection.

confection *(n.)* a sweet food, especially one carefully made

Each region is known for a particular confection sold at its stations.

reciprocity *(n.)* the exchange of things or favours for mutual benefit

Reciprocity runs quietly through most gift customs.

chore *(n.)* a routine task, often tedious

Some employees describe the office omiyage as a chore rather than a pleasure.

to hand round *(phrasal verb)* to pass something to each person in a group

The box is opened at the desk and handed round before lunch.

to account for *(phrasal verb)* to explain or make up for something

The gift accounts for the days you were absent.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

You cannot lift omiyage out of Japan and call it "being thoughtful". It works because it sits inside a dense web of workplace and neighbourhood reciprocity, with shared expectations about who is owed what and an entire retail system organized to supply it. Import the habit without the web and you produce a nice gesture; the Japanese version is closer to infrastructure. It is also not uniform — practice differs by region, industry and generation, and many people in Japan would like to see less of it.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

obligation — reciprocity — to hand round

DISCUSS

Who deserves to be remembered while you are away — and how do you decide where the list stops?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you gave someone a small gift that mattered more than its cost.

Arranged Marriage

INDIA

> *Who Knows You Best?*

There is tea on the table and rather too many people in the room.

Two families sit opposite each other, being polite. Somebody's uncle does most of the talking. On a phone is a *biodata* — the short profile that circulates in advance: education, occupation, family, community.

After half an hour the two people the meeting is about are sent to the balcony to talk alone.

Then each is asked one question.

Yes or no?

The Distinction That Has to Come First

Arranged marriage and forced marriage are not versions of one thing. They are opposites at the only point that counts.

In an arranged marriage, families identify and introduce candidates and the couple agrees or refuses. In a forced marriage, consent is absent — extracted by threat, deception or violence.

Forced marriage is abuse. It is illegal in India and in most countries, and is not the subject of this chapter.

The confusion has done real damage: it makes hundreds of millions of ordinary marriages sound sinister.

The System's Own Logic

Start from a different premise and the whole thing becomes coherent.

The premise is that romantic attraction is a poor instrument for a long decision: intense, short-lived, and bad at spotting what matters in twenty years.

So the assessment is made on other grounds. Background. Education. Temperament. Religion and language. Whether the two families can sit in a room together. In many Hindu families, birth charts.

And the assessors have known one party since birth and are not in love.

Underneath sits a second premise: a marriage is not only between two people. It is an alliance between households, obligated both ways for life.

If a marriage joins families, it is not obvious that the couple alone should choose.

What Is Genuinely Wrong With It

That is the case for the defence.

Arranged marriage is also one of the main mechanisms by which caste reproduces itself. Families overwhelmingly seek matches inside their own caste and community, generation after generation, and the

system's efficiency at this is precisely the problem. Inter-caste couples still meet opposition and, in places, violence.

Dowry has been outlawed since 1961 and persists anyway, sometimes ruinously, and the demands fall on the bride's family.

The pressure is not evenly distributed. Women are more often pushed toward early marriage, judged on appearance and skin colour in listings, and expected to move into another household.

And choice narrows. A veto is a smaller freedom than a search. If every candidate you are shown comes from one community, refusing them all does not get you out of the room.

None of this is answered by saying that the couple consented.

It Is Also Moving

Fast, and mostly from within.

Most marriages in India are still arranged in some form, but the form has changed. Websites and apps have replaced much of the uncle. Couples meet, message for months, go out and decide — often called *semi-arranged*: the family introduces, the couple courts.

Plenty of educated urban Indians with every option open to them choose this one anyway, believing it more honest about what marriage is for.

Others reject it outright; the local term for the alternative — *love marriage* — tells you the two are understood as rivals.

They are two attempts at one problem: how a person who cannot see themselves clearly ends up beside someone they can live with for decades.

One answers that you know best. The other answers that the people who raised you do.

Both produce happy marriages and miserable ones.

THE HUMAN LENS

Think about the most important decision you have made alone.

Who else had information you did not? A parent who watched you at seven. A friend who has seen every relationship you have had.

When you insist that only you can know what is good for you — is that self-knowledge, or the assumption you happened to be raised inside?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Consent is the dividing line.** Arranged marriage rests on the couple's agreement; forced marriage does not, and is abuse.
2. **The system has a logic.** It treats marriage as an alliance between families and trusts long acquaintance over attraction.
3. **The criticisms are serious and unresolved.** Caste endogamy, dowry, unequal pressure on women and narrowed choice are real features, not misunderstandings.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

consent *(n.)* permission or agreement freely given
Consent separates an arranged marriage from a forced one.

compatibility *(n.)* the ability of two people to live together well
Compatibility is assessed on grounds other than attraction.

endogamy *(n.)* the practice of marrying within one's own group
Caste endogamy is the most serious charge against it.

dowry *(n.)* money or goods given by a bride's family at marriage
Dowry has been illegal for decades and has not disappeared.

veto *(n.)* the right to refuse or reject something
A veto is not the same as a free search.

to look into *(phrasal verb)* to investigate something carefully
Both families look into each other before any meeting.

to go through with *(phrasal verb)* to complete something you have agreed to

Either party may decide not to go through with the match.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

There is no single Indian practice here. Custom differs by region, religion — Hindu, Muslim, Sikh, Christian, Jain — caste, class and generation, and a rule that holds in one community is wrong in the next. Nor can the system be borrowed piecemeal: it works, where it works, because families stay materially involved for life — housing, money, childcare, care in old age. Take the introductions without the obligations and you import the constraint without the support.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

consent — compatibility — to go through with

DISCUSS

Who in your life sees you more accurately than you see yourself?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time someone who knew you well gave you advice you did not want to hear.

Bayram Hand-Kissing

TURKEY

> *The Oldest Hand in the Room*

It is early, the family is in good clothes, and there is already a line in the hallway.

A grandmother sits in the best chair because that is where she has been put. One by one the others come to her — a son, a daughter-in-law, a child pushed forward by the shoulders.

Each takes her right hand, bends, kisses the back of it, and lifts it to their own forehead.

She says something short in return, a wish for the days ahead.

Then the next person steps up.

This is *el öpmek* — hand-kissing — and on the mornings of **Bayram** it happens in a great many Turkish households at the same hour.

The Two Bayrams

Bayram is the Turkish word for the two great Muslim festivals. *Ramazan Bayramı* closes the fasting month and is also called *şeker Bayramı*, the sugar feast. *Kurban Bayramı* is the feast of sacrifice.

Both bring several days of public holiday.

You dress. You may go to the morning prayer. Then you visit — and the visiting has an order.

Grandparents first. Then parents. Then aunts, uncles, older cousins. Then neighbours, and the old woman on the third floor whom everybody calls auntie and nobody is related to.

Cologne is poured into the guest's cupped hands, cool and sharp with lemon. Children collect coins and chocolate from house to house.

A Country Moving in One Direction

Look at it from above. For a few days a whole society travels one way: from younger to older.

Nobody is told the sequence. Everyone knows who outranks whom by birth, and the feet follow.

A family is not a fact. It is something people have to go and physically confirm.

A family is easy to lose. People move for work, marry outward, fall out over something small in a year nobody remembers. The link does not break loudly; it stops being used.

Bayram is the maintenance schedule. It sets a date, fixes the direction, and puts you in a room with people you would not otherwise have got round to.

What the Elder Owes

It would be easy to read the gesture as pure hierarchy. It is not quite that.

Watch what comes back. The hand is not withdrawn; it is given. The elder answers with a blessing, the child leaves with money, and behind the day sit obligations running downward all year — help, housing, mediation, money that arrives unasked.

The hand-kiss is the visible half of a two-way arrangement.

The honest version includes the rest. Deference can be used as a weapon, and a hand can be kissed by someone who is furious. Some young Turks find the gesture performative and let it go. Practice varies between secular and observant families, between city and village, and distance has turned many visits into phone calls.

Where the Visiting Ends

There is one more stop, and it is not a house.

Many families go to the cemetery at Bayram, often on the eve, to stand at the graves, tidy them, and read.

So the direction holds all the way. Younger to older, to oldest, to the ones who are no longer answering.

This book began at a different door, asking what a stranger is owed. It ends at this one, where nobody is a stranger and the oldest hand in the

room is reached for first — the same movement, hand to forehead, that the Filipino *mano* makes on the other side of the world.

We start by letting people in. We finish by holding on to the ones who let us in first.

THE HUMAN LENS

You have a list, whether or not you have written it down: the people you would visit if you had three free days and a reason.

Some you have not seen in years, for no reason you could defend out loud.

Bayram's trick is that it removes the need for a reason. The date arrives and the door is open.

If today were that date — whose hand would you take first?

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. **Respect is given a direction and a timetable.** The visiting runs from younger to older, so nobody has to decide who to see or when.
2. **The exchange runs both ways.** The elder returns a blessing, a coin, and a year of practical obligation.
3. **A family needs maintaining.** Ritual supplies the appointment that affection alone tends not to keep.

VOCABULARY & PHRASAL VERBS

deference *(n.)* respectful behaviour toward someone senior

The gesture is an act of deference, not of agreement.

seniority *(n.)* the state of being older or higher in rank

The order of visits follows seniority.

blessing *(n.)* a spoken wish for someone's wellbeing

The elder answers with a blessing.

observant *(adj.)* keeping the practices of a religion

Observant and secular families keep the day differently.

hierarchy *(n.)* a system in which people are ranked above one another

Hierarchy is easier to accept when it carries duties downward.

to drop in *(phrasal verb)* to visit briefly, often without arranging it

You drop in on neighbours you rarely see.

to fall out *(phrasal verb)* to stop being friendly after a disagreement

Relatives who fell out years ago meet again.

PRACTICE

WHERE THE ANALOGY BREAKS

Bayram is a religious festival, not a folk custom with a lesson attached. Lifting the hand-kiss out of it removes what holds it up: the fast that precedes one Bayram, the sacrifice that defines the other, and a kinship structure in which seniority carries real authority and real duty both ways. Turkey is also not one thing — Kurdish, Alevi, secular and observant households differ, and *el*

öpmek is used well beyond Bayram. Borrow the gesture without the obligations and you have manners, not a system.

USE THE LANGUAGE

Make sentences using:

deference — seniority — to drop in

DISCUSS

Who would notice if you stopped visiting?

WRITE

Using the **STAR** structure — Situation, Task, Action, Result — describe a time you went to see someone you had been putting off seeing.

Sources and Further Reading

Every source below was opened and read before it was listed here. Where a custom belongs to a living community, that community's own account has been preferred to an outside one.

Two chapters describe Indigenous traditions: the Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address and the First Salmon Ceremony of the Chinook, Swinomish and Columbia River nations. These are living practices, not historical curiosities — still spoken, still held, and still belonging to the people whose traditions they are. Their sources come from those nations themselves.

Web addresses change. Where one has moved, the title and publisher given here should be enough to find the source again.

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